

UNDERSTANDING INTERGENERATIONAL DYNAMICS & PERCEPTIONS ON AGEING

The India Intergenerational Bonds (INBO) - HelpAge India Report 2025



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Executive Summary

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Introduction

India faces a significant demographic shift, with a rapidly growing elderly population alongside the world's largest youth cohort. This transformation, coupled with evolving family structures away from traditional joint households, creates complex intergenerational dynamics, especially in urban middle and lower-middle-class families. Elders frequently report feeling disconnected and devalued, while youth struggle with differing expectations. This study addresses the urgent need to understand these emotional, relational, and psychological aspects of intergenerational ties in urban India.

Research Objectives and Scope

This study aimed to explore urban Indian intergenerational relationships, focusing on youth (18-30) and elders (60+) in SEC B and C households across ten cities. Key objectives included understanding mutual perceptions of aging, assessing the quality of interactions—including digital and financial support—and identifying communication barriers. The research, employing mixed methods, sought to provide insights for programs and advocacy promoting intergenerational understanding and support.

Methodology

The study utilized a **mixed-methods approach**, combining extensive **quantitative surveys** with targeted **qualitative Focus Group Discussions (FGDs)**. Over 5,700 youth and elder respondents participated in structured face-to-face interviews using pre-tested digital questionnaires, ensuring robust data collection. Complementary FGDs were conducted in four diverse cities, providing rich narratives that illuminated the emotional nuances behind the survey data, offering a holistic view of intergenerational dynamics in urban India.

Sampling Design

A **multi-stage stratified random sampling** design was used for the quantitative survey, targeting 5,000 respondents across 10 cities to ensure representation by age, gender, and socio-economic class (SEC B and C). Wards were selected using PPS systematic random sampling, followed by random household and within-household respondent selection. For qualitative insights, FGDs were strategically held in four regional cities (Kanpur, Kolkata, Mumbai, Madurai), with separate groups for youth and elders, and by gender, to ensure diverse and open discussions.

Sample Coverage

The study successfully surveyed **5,798 respondents**, surpassing the 5,000 target, enhancing analytical robustness. The sample closely mirrored the proposed youth (70%) and elder (30%) proportions, with minor, acceptable deviations across age bands and SEC. Gender distribution was perfectly balanced (52% male, 48% female), and city type remained consistent with targets (61% metros, 39% non-metros). Eight qualitative FGDs were conducted across the selected cities, providing rich contextual data.

Salient Findings

Demographic Profile

- **Educational Divide:** Youth show significantly higher educational attainment, with nearly half of elders having no formal education. Disparities persist by age, gender (favoring males), and socio-economic class (SEC B vs. SEC C).
- **Occupational Shift & Gender Roles:** Youth are primarily students or in formal private sector jobs. Elders are largely retirees or homemakers, with significant health-related work cessation. Traditional gender roles for women (homemaking) remain strong across both generations.
- **Financial Dependence & Income:** Just under half of elders are financially independent, often linked to education and employment; the dependent largely rely on family. Most student youth are fully financially dependent on family.
- **Evolving Living Arrangements:** While nuclear families are common for both, joint family living is more prevalent among elders, especially older women and the financially dependent. Despite urbanization, **multigenerational co-residence remains a key feature**, predominantly through children and grandchildren, sustaining intergenerational support.

Perceptions about Ageing

- **Youth Perceptions Blend Concern and Respect:** Youth primarily associate elders with being "lonely" (56%) and "dependent" (48%), but also "wise" (51%) and "respected" (43%), indicating a mix of empathy and admiration, alongside some stereotypes of physical frailty and outdated views.
- **Elders' Emotional Realities Often Negative:** A majority of elders (54%) report negative feelings about aging, citing neglect, dependence, or weakness, with loneliness being the most common emotion (47%). This confirms youth's concern for elders' emotional state, though youth may underestimate the intensity of these feelings.

- **Disconnect in Perceived vs. Lived Value:** While youth express high "Value and Respect" (score of 63.59) for elders and believe they should be involved in decisions, elders often feel their opinions are not genuinely sought or valued in practice ("We are told the plan, not asked").
- **Media Influence Shapes Youth Attitudes:** Youth recognize media's significant influence (80%) on their perceptions of elders, often portraying them as caring, wise, but also dependent or even comic. This highlights the potential for media to both reinforce and challenge stereotypes.
- **Capability and Support Needs Understood by Youth:** Youth generally believe elders can remain active and independent with support, and elders who are financially stable often report higher contentment. However, a significant portion of elders, particularly the oldest and financially dependent, experience anxiety and a loss of control, underscoring critical support gaps.
- **Proximity Doesn't Always Reduce Bias:** Counterintuitively, youth living in close proximity to elders reported higher "Stereotype Negative Bias" scores compared to those living further away, suggesting that frequent exposure doesn't automatically reduce traditional biases, highlighting the need for deeper, quality engagement.
- **Non-Metro vs. Metro Perceptions:** Youth and elders in non-metro cities often report stronger traditional values and intergenerational bonds, yet also higher fears about aging and greater perceived generation gaps. In contrast, metro youth show a more modern, less ageist outlook, but often with less direct intergenerational engagement.

Interactions and Bonding between Elders and Youth

- **Dominant Kinship Ties & Gendered Patterns:** Youth primarily interact with grandparents (49%) and parents (45%), while elders mostly interact with sons (50%) and grandsons (40%). This highlights the central role of immediate family, with cultural and practical reasons often leading to higher interaction between elders and male kin (sons, grandsons).
- **High Frequency of Interaction, Especially In-Home:** Two-thirds of elders (66%) and 61% of youth report daily interaction, primarily occurring at home (81-82%). This frequency is higher in joint families and non-metro cities, indicating the continued importance of shared living spaces and traditional community structures.
- **Digital Divide in Communication:** While face-to-face interaction is overwhelmingly dominant (88% for both), elders report significantly lower engagement in digital

communication modes (e.g., video calls: 28% elders vs. 43% youth; social media: 14% elders vs. 30% youth), highlighting a notable digital gap.

- **Shared Activities Anchor Bonds:** "Conversations about personal/family matters" (87% youth, 84% elders) and "eating meals together" (71% youth, 72% elders) are the strongest common activities, underscoring their role in daily connection. However, youth report very limited engagement in play-related activities (7% indoor games, 2% outdoor games).
- **Elders Express Strong Emotional Bonds but Also Vulnerabilities:** A significant majority of elders (73%) feel "Extremely Close" or "Close" to youth. However, 54% express negative feelings about aging, and loneliness is the most common emotion (47%), revealing underlying vulnerabilities despite perceived closeness.
- **Perceived Value and Respect Vary:** While 86% of elders feel moderately to very much valued by youth, expressions like "We are told the plan, not asked" suggest a disconnect between youth's expressed respect and elders' desire for meaningful involvement in decision-making.

Respect, Value, and Role of Elders

- **Familial Respect is Highest, Community Varies:** Elders feel most respected by **younger family members (59%)** and healthcare providers (52%), while perceived respect from younger neighbors and friends is slightly lower (50% each), and perceived disrespect is highest from these groups (21%).
- **High Inclusion in Family Decisions:** A large majority of elders (75%) report their opinions are **always (46%) or often (29%)** considered in family decisions, particularly among younger elders (60-70 years), the financially independent, and those in non-metro cities.
- **Perceived Value is Stable or Improving:** Most elders (82%) believe their value in the eyes of youth has either **increased (42%) or remained the same (40%)** over time, though 15% feel it has decreased, particularly among the oldest and most dependent.
- **Diverse Contributions to Family and Community:** Elders contribute significantly through **advice and life experience (72%)**, childcare (50%), and household work (47%). Financial contributions (36%) and emotional support (31%) are also notable.
- **Perceived Respect Index Highlights Disparities:** The overall Perceived Respect and Value Index score is **55.16 out of 100**, indicating moderate perceived value. Higher scores are seen among educated, financially independent, and co-residing elders, while those who are isolated or financially dependent tend to feel less acknowledged.

Digital Inclusion and Technology Use

- **Limited Digital Access for Elders:** While **71%** of elders use basic mobile phones, only **41%** own smartphones, and a mere **13%** use computers, internet, or social media. This indicates a significant portion of the elderly population remains excluded from advanced digital connectivity.
- **Major Barriers to Digital Adoption:** Two-thirds of elders (**66%**) find digital tools "too confusing," and over half (**51%**) fear making errors. Lack of interest (**40%**) and insufficient instruction from others (**25%**) are also significant barriers.
- **Youth as Primary Digital Support (with communication gaps):** Children (**54%**) and grandchildren (**52%**) are the main digital teachers for elders. However, a significant perception gap exists: youth believe elders are "disinterested" (**78%**) or "forget instructions" (**66%**), while elders cite youth's "lack of patience" (**71%**) and "fast explanations" (**49%**) as key challenges.
- **Digital Technology Perceived as Bridging Gaps:** A strong majority of elders (**73%**) believe digital technology has "definitely" or "to some extent" brought them closer to youth, underscoring its potential for fostering intergenerational connection despite existing usage barriers.
- **Digital Inclusion Varies by Demographics:** The overall Digital Inclusion Index score for elders is **50.71 out of 100**, but this masks disparities. Digital inclusion is higher among younger elders, males, the educated, financially independent, and those co-residing with youth, especially in non-metro cities.

Financial and Health Inclusion

- **Significant Elder Financial Dependency:** Nearly half of elders (**45%**) are financially independent, but a substantial **38%** are partially dependent and **15%** are fully dependent. This dependency is higher among older elders, women, and those with less education.
- **Youth Underestimate Financial Support Provided:** While elders report significant youth assistance with financial tasks like ATM withdrawals (**55%** vs. **23%** youth acknowledgment) and health insurance (**40%** vs. **18%** youth acknowledgment), youth often under-recognize their actual role in these routine or informal tasks.
- **Widespread Health Concerns and High Care Needs:** The majority of elders (**43%**) describe their health as "fair," "poor," or "very poor." **Mobility problems (74%)** and **chronic pain (73%)** are the most prevalent health issues. Significant assistance is needed for Instrumental Activities of Daily Living (IADLs) like **transportation (74%)** and **managing money (70%)**.

- **Alignment on Practical Health Support, Gap in Emotional Care:** Both elders (**81%**) and youth (**82%**) agree on the importance of youth taking elders to doctors. However, a gap exists in emotional care: **48% of youth** believe they should listen to elders' emotional concerns, while **only 42% of elders** expect this, highlighting an area for improved intergenerational communication.
- **Converging Support Expectations:** The **Support Need and Expectations Score** shows broad alignment between elders (mean **42.92**) and youth (mean **51.15**), indicating youth are generally aware of and willing to provide support. However, support needs are higher among older, less educated, and financially vulnerable elders, and youth in joint families and non-metro cities report stronger engagement.

Challenges in Intergenerational Communications

- **Shared Perception of Communication Barriers:** Both elders (**76%**) and youth (**74%**) primarily identify "youth having busy schedules" as the top barrier to intergenerational interaction. They also agree that the "other party lacks interest" (elders **40%**, youth **39%**), highlighting a mutual perception of disengagement.
- **Youth Feel More Judged and Misunderstood:** Youth are more likely than elders to cite "communication gaps" (youth **30%** vs. elders **28%**) and "judgment from elders" (youth **25%** vs. elders **22%**), suggesting they feel more scrutinized or misunderstood in these interactions.
- **Comfort Levels Vary by Topic and Relationship:** Discussions on "life advice" are moderately comfortable for both groups, while "career or education plans" are the least comfortable. Interestingly, both elders and youth often report greater comfort discussing sensitive topics like "friendships, relationships, or love" and "mental health, emotions, or stress" with **non-immediate family (e.g., family friends, other relatives)** rather than direct kin.
- **Widespread Recognition of a Generation Gap:** A significant majority of youth (**51%**) and elders (**45%**) perceive a "big gap" between generations, with most others acknowledging a "manageable gap." This near-universal recognition provides a strong foundation for efforts to improve intergenerational understanding.
- **Mutual Feelings of Misunderstanding:** A core barrier to communication is the reciprocal feeling of not being understood: **72% of youth** believe elders "don't understand the current generation," while **54% of elders** feel youth "don't understand older generation views."
- **Optimism for Bridging the Gap:** Despite the challenges, both elders (**49%**) and youth (**57%**) express strong optimism that mutual understanding can "definitely be improved." They

largely agree that "spending more quality time together" (**84% of elders, 86% of youth**) and engaging in "open and respectful conversations" are the most effective ways to foster better connections.

Support Systems and Awareness of Government Schemes

- **Awareness of Government Schemes is mixed:** Elders show high awareness of **monthly pensions (68%)** and **housing/ration schemes (63%)**, but significantly lower awareness of **legal protection (35%)**, **digital training (31%)**, and **emergency helplines (31%)**. This highlights a need for better outreach in these critical areas.
- **Family is Primary Support, but Other Systems are growing:** **86% of elders** cite family members as their primary support system, especially those over 80 and financially dependent. However, a notable **45%** also rely on neighbors or friends, and **24%** access NGOs and government services, indicating a diversification of support.
- **Elders Prioritize Emotional Support and Time:** Elders place the highest importance on youth **"spending more time together" (mean score 2.53 out of 3)** and **"emotional support/listening" (2.46)**, more so than financial help (2.37) or teaching digital tools (1.94). This underscores the critical need for companionship and empathy.
- **Universal Consensus on Family Responsibility:** Both elders (mean rank **5.23 out of 6**) and youth (mean rank **5.00**) overwhelmingly identify **family members** as having the primary responsibility for elder care. However, youth assign a higher responsibility to the government (mean rank **3.89**) than elders (mean rank **3.70**).
- **High Youth Willingness to Support and Volunteer:** A strong **76% of youth** believe they have a role in improving elders' lives, and **75%** are willing to volunteer for elder care activities like companionship or tech assistance. This willingness is highest among educated youth, students, and those in joint or extended families.

Future Aspirations and Fears about Ageing – Elder and Youth Views

- **Shared Core Fears, Different Emphases:** Both youth and elders primarily fear **loneliness/isolation (Youth: 69%, Elders: 68%)**, **poor health (Youth: 67%, Elders: 61%)**, and **financial insecurity (Youth: 62%, Elders: 58%)** in old age. Youth, however, show greater anticipatory anxiety about being dependent for daily tasks and technology-related obsolescence.
- **Strong Desire for Family-Based Living:** There is a widespread cultural norm for multi-generational co-residence, with **88% of youth** expecting to live with family when old and

83% of elders currently living with or planning to move in with family. This desire for family-based living remains a cornerstone for both groups.

- **Youth More Open to Formal Care Options:** While children/grandchildren are the primary expected caregivers for both (elders: 65%, youth: 63%), youth show a notably higher inclination towards **paid caregivers/domestic help (28% vs. 18% of elders)** and **old age homes/assisted living (30% vs. 19% of elders)**, indicating a growing pragmatic acceptance of non-familial support.
- **Financial Security and Health are Top Priorities for a Good Old Age:** Both generations overwhelmingly agree that **financial security (elders: 70%, youth: 72%)** and **good physical and mental health (elders: 66%, youth: 68%)** are the most important factors for a good life in old age. Youth also place a slightly higher emphasis on **being respected and valued**.

Key Learnings from the Study

- **Perception Gap in Elder Well-being:** While urban Indian youth generally associate elders with wisdom and are concerned about their well-being, elders often experience deeper emotional distress and feel less genuinely valued than youth perceive. Youth tend to underestimate the intensity of elders' negative emotions.
- **Digital Divide and Communication Frustrations:** Despite frequent in-person interactions, a significant digital divide exists. Youth (78%) widely believe elders are "disinterested" in learning digital skills, while elders (71%) attribute this to youth's "impatience" and "fast explanations." Elders (44%) also feel embarrassed to ask for help repeatedly, a sentiment youth (6%) largely do not acknowledge.
- **Family as Cornerstone, but Formal Care Acceptance Growing:** Family members are overwhelmingly the primary support system for elders. However, youth show a notable pragmatic shift towards accepting and expecting formal care options like paid caregivers and old age homes for their own future aging.
- **Shared Fears, Evolving Aspirations for Aging:** Both generations share core fears of loneliness, poor health, and financial insecurity. While both strongly aspire for family-based living in old age, youth increasingly desire independent living near family or in quality retirement communities, indicating an evolving outlook on aging.
- **Emotional Needs Under-addressed Despite Proximity:** Even with frequent physical interaction, elders often report a lack of genuine emotional engagement, feeling "told the plan, not asked," or experiencing "quiet disappointment." This highlights a gap between physical presence and meaningful emotional connection.

Recommendations

- **Public Education and Empathy Workshops:** Implement "Aging Sensitization" curricula in schools and colleges to foster practical empathy and active listening among youth regarding the emotional realities of aging.
- **Digital Inclusion: Youth-Led Training Initiatives:** Establish "Digital Buddy" programs to pair tech-savvy youth with elders for patient, one-on-one digital literacy training focused on practical applications like video calls and online banking.
- **Strengthening Care Infrastructure:** Create community-based elder support centres offering holistic services, including emotional counselling and health screenings, to address elders' needs beyond physical care.
- **Intergenerational Programs:** Launch "Wisdom Exchange" programs where elders share traditional skills and stories while youth offer modern knowledge, fostering mutual learning and leveraging elders' role as emotional anchors.

Introduction, Methodology and Sampling

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. Background and Context

India's demographic structure is undergoing a profound transformation. As of 2025, approximately **12% of the Indian population is aged 60 and above¹**, a figure projected to rise to **19% by 2050**. At the same time, India also holds the distinction of being home to the **world's largest youth population**, with over **365 million individuals aged 15–29 years²**.

The weakening of traditional family support due to urbanization and migration amplifies the vulnerability of the elderly.⁴

These demographic shifts are set against a backdrop of evolving family structures. The traditional Indian joint family — once central to intergenerational caregiving and value transmission — is steadily being replaced by **nuclear and urban household units**. Migration, space constraints, and changing work patterns have weakened the daily proximity between elders and the youth. This is particularly evident in **urban middle and lower-middle class households**, typified by **SEC B and C segments³**, where the interplay of respect, obligation, and distance becomes nuanced and sometimes conflicted.

Even in co-residential setups, elders often report **emotional disconnection, lack of participation in decision-making, and loss of authority**, while youth may experience pressure to conform to expectations that conflict with their evolving identities and aspirations.

The younger generation perceives the affairs in their own way and works according to their own liking, while the older generation obstructs them with their own views and experiences directly or indirectly, creating an intergenerational conflict in society.⁵

1.2. Need for the Study

Amidst these demographic and socio-cultural shifts, there is a growing need to understand and respond to the **changing dynamics of intergenerational relationships** in urban India. While ageing is increasingly addressed from the perspectives of health, income, and care, **the emotional, relational, and psychological experiences of elders and their interaction**

¹ National Commission on Population, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare (2020) – “Report of the Technical Group on Population Projections for India and States 2011–2036”.

² Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports (2017), Government of India — “National Youth Policy”.

³ Refer to Annexure for the Socio-Economic Classification (SEC) Table

⁴ UNFPA India Ageing Report (2023)

⁵ Lalitha, K., & Suneetha, P.V. (2019). *Intergenerational conflicts between older persons and younger generation*. RFP Journal of Gerontology and Geriatric Nursing, 1(1), 25–31.

with youth remain under-researched, especially in socio-economically diverse urban contexts.

There are emerging signals of **disconnect and misunderstanding** between generations:

Despite reduced interaction and decision-making roles, many elders continue to view themselves as contributors to family well-being, and youth respondents often expressed admiration for elder wisdom even if emotional closeness was limited.⁶

- Elders often report **feeling neglected or redundant**, especially when financially dependent.
- Youth express **respect in principle** but feel unprepared or uncomfortable initiating deeper engagement with elders.
- Communication styles, lifestyle expectations, and values differ significantly between the age groups, leading to **reduced emotional closeness despite physical proximity**.

This study seeks to bridge the existing knowledge gap by examining:

- **Youth and Elder Perceptions of ageing and older persons**
- **Feelings of value, respect, and emotional bonding**
- **Patterns of interaction, inclusion, and intergenerational support**
- And how these differ by **gender, socio-economic class, family structure, health status, and proximity**

Understanding these dynamics is essential not only for development of intervention programmes and advocacy, but also for strengthening **intergenerational solidarity**, reducing ageism, and promoting emotional well-being across life stages in Indian families.

⁶ LASI Wave 1 Report (2020), International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS), Mumbai, in collaboration with MoHFW, Harvard, and WHO.

2. RESEARCH OBJECTIVES AND SCOPE

2.1. Research Objectives

The study aims to explore the nature, quality, and perceptions of intergenerational relationships between **urban youth (aged 18–30 years)** and **older persons (aged 60+ years)** in India, with a focus on socio-economic categories **SEC B and C**. Specifically, the study seeks to:

- Examine **youth perceptions** of ageing and attitudes toward older persons, including prevalent stereotypes, expressions of respect, emotional bonding, and their willingness to engage in elder support.
- Understand **how older persons perceive the process of ageing and their role, respect, and value** within family and society, particularly in the context of changing family structures and increasing longevity.
- Assess the **frequency, mode, and emotional quality of interaction** between youth and older persons, across various domains including social, caregiving, digital, and financial involvement.
- Analyse perceptions of **digital, financial, social, and health inclusion** among elders and the **role of youth in facilitating or obstructing** this inclusion.
- Identify **communication gaps and generation-based barriers** in interaction and co-existence, as perceived by both groups.

This study aims to provide inputs for **programmatic strategies, public awareness campaigns, and advocacy tools** that promote intergenerational understanding, inclusion, and support within urban Indian families.

2.2. Scope of the Study

- **Geographic Scope:**

The study was conducted across ten Indian cities — **Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Ahmedabad, Kanpur, Nagpur, and Madurai** — representing a mix of metro and non-Metro cities across regions.



Figure 1: Map of India showing Location of Study Centres

- **Target Groups:**

- **Youth respondents:** 18–30 years old, both male and female, belonging to SEC B and C urban households.
- **Elder respondents:** 60+ years old, both male and female, from the same household SEC segments.

- **Key Information Areas:**
 - Demographic, educational, economic, and living profiles
 - Attitudinal and emotional perceptions of ageing
 - Respect, role, and inclusion of older persons
 - Bonding and quality of intergenerational interactions
 - Digital and financial support structures
 - Communication dynamics and generational gaps
 - Support needs, aspirations, and fears of ageing
 - Volunteerism potential among youth for elder care
- **Approach:**
 - **Quantitative Surveys** with both youth and elder samples
 - **Qualitative Focus Group Discussions (FGD)** with both generations
 - **Disaggregated Analysis** by metro/non-Metro city, gender, SEC, education, age, health, living arrangement, proximity, and relationship status

3. METHODOLOGY

This study adopted a **mixed-methods approach**, combining structured **quantitative surveys** with qualitative **Focus Group Discussions** (FGDs) to explore perceptions, interactions, and emotional dynamics between youth and elders in urban India.

The **quantitative component** comprised structured face-to-face interviews with youth and elder respondents using tailored survey instruments. Youth questionnaires captured demographic and educational profiles, attitudes toward ageing, emotional bonding, stereotypes, interaction patterns with elders, and perceptions of inclusion (digital, social, financial). Similarly, elder questionnaires explored their perceived role, emotional states, relationships with youth, decision-making involvement, support needs, and reflections on relevance and respect. Both

The study used a mixed method approach combining quantitative surveys with qualitative FGDs for a holistic insight.

tools were translated into local languages, pre-tested in the field, and administered digitally using tablets, allowing for real-time quality monitoring. Enumerators underwent extensive training on ethical protocols, respondent sensitivity, and digital data collection procedures.

Supervisors conducted random spot checks and back-verification of entries to ensure adherence to methodological rigor. Informed consent was obtained from all participants, and confidentiality protocols were strictly maintained throughout the data collection process.

To complement the quantitative insights, **qualitative FGDs** were conducted across youth and elder groups in the study cities. Each group comprised 6–8 participants, selected to ensure diversity by gender and age bands. FGDs for youth focused on their understanding of ageing, emotional connection with elders, barriers to engagement, and aspirations for improved intergenerational bonds. Elder FGDs explored themes of perceived respect, loss of decision-making power, emotional needs, and reflections on changing family dynamics. Discussions were facilitated by trained moderators using a semi-structured guide. All sessions were audio-recorded, transcribed, and thematically analysed. The qualitative narratives provided valuable depth, revealing the emotional undercurrents behind statistical patterns and capturing the voices of both generations in their own words.

Together, the combined methodologies enabled a holistic examination of intergenerational relationships — quantifying key trends and uncovering nuanced personal experiences — across the diverse and evolving urban fabric of India.

4. SAMPLING DESIGN

The study employed distinct but complementary sampling strategies for its quantitative and qualitative components, ensuring statistical representativeness for survey findings and contextual diversity for the focus group discussions.

4.1. Quantitative Survey

The study used a **multi-stage stratified random sampling design**, grounded in urban demographic realities and the socio-economic segmentation relevant to SEC B and C households. The sampling strategy was developed to ensure city-wise representation and sufficient variation in respondent profiles, especially across gender, age group and SEC.

It was determined that a total sample size of 5000 would be covered across the 10 cities and the sample was broken up into quotas for each city to ensure representation across age groups, gender and SEC. The quotas were derived as per the prevalent projected percentages of the various segments at an average level across these 10 cities.

Sampling quotas were derived using city-wise population projections for 2025, sourced from credible databases like UN Urbanization Prospects, World Population Review, and Census extrapolations. The estimated SEC B and SEC C population—assumed to form 45–55% of each city’s urban population—was further segmented by age and gender. Age group splits were aligned with urban demographic trends from the National Commission on Population and NFHS-5, while gender distribution was assumed at 52% male and 48% female. These estimates formed the basis for proportional sampling across youth and elder cohorts in all study cities.

The study employed a multi-stage stratified random sampling design across 10 cities, using demographic projections and SEC indicators to allocate quotas by age, gender, and socio-economic category

The multi-stage stratified random sampling process was as following -

Stage 1: Selection of wards/localities based on SEC mapping

For each city, 10 wards were selected and 50 interviews were conducted within each ward, keeping specified quotas across gender, age and SEC.

The wards were selected using the PPS systematic random sampling procedure. The wards were arranged in the descending order of households having television and 2-wheelers (used as surrogate indicators for SEC B and SEC C households). Then they were selected using the systematic circular sampling method.

Stage 2: Random household selection within chosen wards

Starting at a randomly selected starting point, every fifth household on the right was selected, until 50 interviews were done as per the quota in that ward

Stage 3: Within households, random selection of eligible youth and older persons

Keeping the quotas in mind respondents from the youth and older persons segments were randomly selected. Attempts were made to cover youth and older persons from the same household where quota overlaps were available.

This rigorous approach enabled the construction of a **balanced, stratified urban sample**, capturing both statistically reliable data and the rich variation needed for nuanced intergenerational analysis. The methodology was geared toward ensuring representativeness across the range of intergenerational experiences common in SEC B and C urban India.

4.2. Qualitative Focus Group Discussions

In order to ensure homogeneity of the groups, so that there was a free-flowing discussion, separate groups were constituted across youth and elder age groups, and across gender. These discussions were centered in 4 of the 10 proposed cities in such a way that there was adequate regional representation across the 4 zones – North, East, West and South and also across Metros and Non-Metro cities. The cities that were selected were Kanpur (North Zone, Non-Metro city), Kolkata (East Zone, Metro), Mumbai (West Zone, Metro) and Madurai (South Zone, Non-Metro city). 2 group discussions were held in each city alternating between age groups and gender.

5. SAMPLE COVERAGE

The proposed and achieved sample sizes for both the quantitative survey and the qualitative FGDs are given below.

5.1. Quantitative Survey

The sample percentages proposed and size achieved across SEC, age groups, gender and city types is given below.

	Proposed Sample Percentages	Achieved Sample Percentages	Achieved Sample Size
Youth	72%	70%	4085
18-24 years	41%	38%	2201
25-30 years	31%	32%	1884
Elder	28%	30%	1713
60-70 years	17%	19%	1112
71-80 years	9%	9%	496
80 years +	2%	2%	105
SEC B	62%	57%	3316
SEC C	40%	43%	2482
Male	52%	52%	3036
Female	48%	48%	2762
Metros	60%	61%	3556
Non-Metro cities	40%	39%	2242
Total	5000	5798	5798

Table 1: Proposed and Achieved Sample Percentages and Sizes

The final achieved sample size was **5,798**, exceeding the proposed target of **5,000 respondents**. This overachievement reflects effective field implementation and allowed for enhanced robustness in subgroup analysis. The proportion of **youth (70%)** and **elders (30%)** closely mirrors the proposed split (72% and 28% respectively), with only minor deviations.

Within the youth cohort, the **18–24 age group** was slightly underrepresented (38% vs. proposed 41%), while the **25–30 age group** was marginally overrepresented (32% vs. proposed 31%). Among elders, **60–70-year-olds** were slightly oversampled (19% vs. 17%), while other elder age bands aligned with expectations.

In terms of **socio-economic classification**, **SEC B was somewhat underrepresented** (57% vs. 62%), while **SEC C was slightly overrepresented** (43% vs. 40%). **Gender representation was perfectly balanced** with 52% males and 48% females as planned. **City-type distribution** remained stable, with **metros contributing 61%** and **Non-Metro cities 39%**, nearly identical to the target proportions.

Overall, the sample demonstrates strong alignment with planned quotas, and minor deviations are well within acceptable ranges for social research studies of this scale.

5.2. Qualitative Focus Group Discussions

The centres and group compositions of the FGDs are given below.

Centre	Age Group	Gender	Number of FGDs
Kanpur	Youth (18-30 years)	Female	1
Kanpur	Elder (60-80 years)	Male	1
Kolkata	Youth (18-30 years)	Female	1
Kolkata	Elder (60-80 years)	Male	1
Mumbai	Youth (18-30 years)	Male	1
Mumbai	Elder (60-80 years)	Female	1
Madurai	Youth (18-30 years)	Male	1
Madurai	Elder (60-80 years)	Female	1
Total			8

Table 2: Group Compositions across Centres

Study Findings

6. DEMOGRAPHIC PROFILE

This section presents the demographic, social, and economic characteristics of the youth and elder respondents, providing a foundational understanding of their backgrounds, household contexts, and living arrangements across the ten study cities.



6.1. Educational Achievements of Youth and Elders

The education profile reveals a clear generational shift, with youth displaying markedly higher levels of educational attainment compared to elder respondents. Among elders, **nearly half (49%) have no formal education or have studied only up to Class 1–4. 17% of elders were not literate** and do not know how to read or write, more so among the 80+ and females. In contrast, youth respondents reflect a much more educated profile. Over **one-quarter (27%) are graduates or postgraduates**, and an additional 25% have completed Class 11–12.

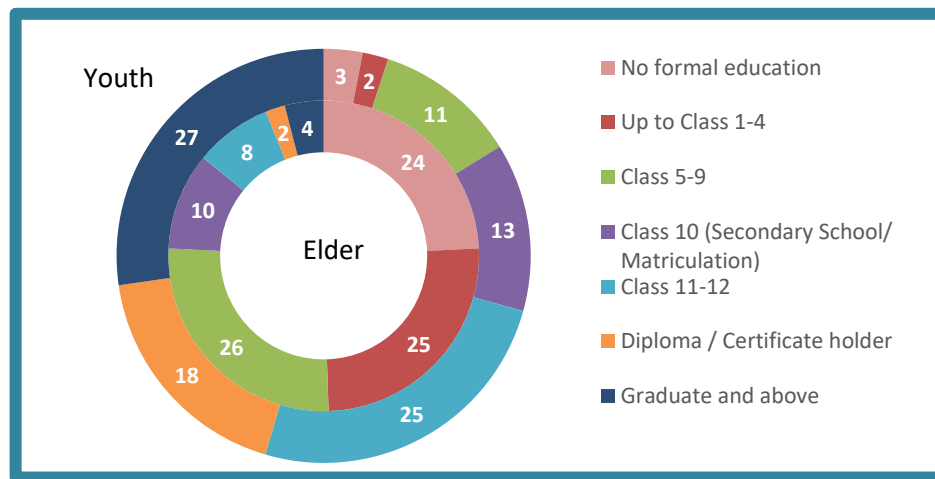


Figure 2: Educational Achievements of Youth and Elders

Educational disadvantage among elders deepens with age — **40% of those aged 80 and above have had no formal schooling**, compared to **22% among those aged 60–70**. The proportion of elders who are graduates remains very low across all subgroups, peaking at just 7% in SEC B and dropping to 1% in SEC C. Sharp gender disparities are evident in the elder population: **29% of elder women report no formal education compared to 18% of men**, while female elders are significantly less likely to have completed secondary or higher education. A similar pattern is seen across socio-economic categories — elders from SEC C households are significantly more disadvantaged than their SEC B counterparts.

Graduation levels are higher among older youth (25–30 years), indicating continued progression through education and that the younger respondents (18-24 years) are students studying in undergraduate courses. However, socio-economic and gender-based differences persist. Among **SEC B youth, 36% are graduates, whereas only 15% of SEC C youth have attained similar qualifications.** Males show a marginal edge in graduation (29%) compared to females (27%).

Geographically, educational attainment is slightly higher in metros, though non-Metro cities are catching up. Youth in both city types show encouraging levels of schooling, suggesting the narrowing of gaps in access to education across urban India. Overall, the data highlights not only intergenerational educational advancement but also the continued relevance of gender, age, and SEC in shaping educational outcomes.

6.2. Occupation and Employment

The occupational landscape for youth and elders reveals stark contrasts shaped by **life stage, gender roles, and socio-economic position**, while also reflecting enduring structural patterns in Indian urban society.

Among youth, the dominant occupation category is **student** (33%), with a majority of **18–24-year-olds (51%)** still in education. In contrast, the elder population shows a strong presence of **retirement (31%)** and **homemaking (27%)**, underscoring their withdrawal from the formal workforce. Youth participation in **full-time employment (34%)** is comparable in size to elder retirement, indicating the transitional positioning of this age group between education and retirement.

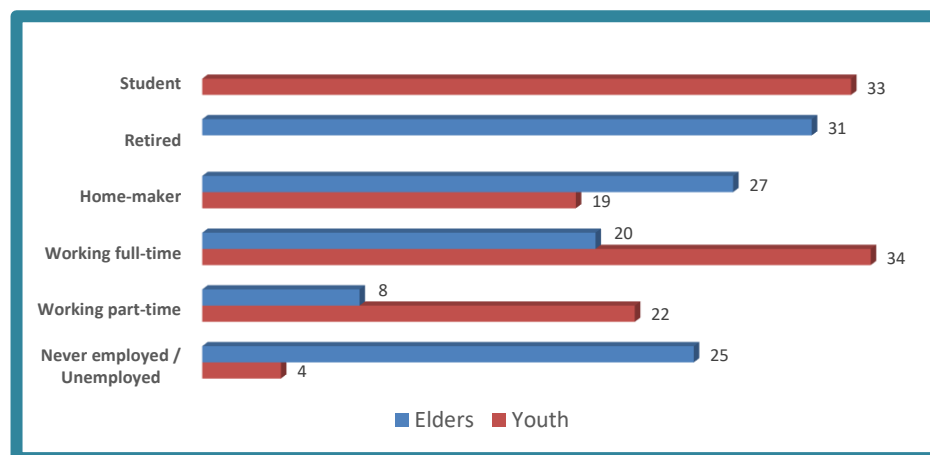


Figure 3: Occupation of Elders and Youth

Gendered patterns are particularly stark. Among youth, **36% of females are homemakers** versus just **4% of males**, reflecting early domestic responsibilities or social norms limiting female workforce entry. Among elders, **45% of women** identify as homemakers, compared

to **only 9% of men**, suggesting the continuity of traditional gender roles across generations. However, the fact that homemaking peaks among **25–30-year-old women** (28%) and not just older women highlights that these roles persist even among younger cohorts.

Workforce participation is significantly higher among male respondents across both generations. **45% of youth males** are employed full-time, compared to only **22% of females**. Among elders, **19% of males** continue to work full-time or part-time, compared to **just 5% of females**. Moreover, **self-employment is more common among elder males (12%)** than females (4%), suggesting male elders are more likely to remain economically active or entrepreneurial post-retirement.

While **non-participation** in the workforce is negligible among youth (4% unemployed), **17% of elders** are unable to work due to health issues or frailty — a number that rises sharply to **42% among those aged 80 and above**. This contrast highlights the impact of ageing on functional ability and economic independence.

Finally, part-time employment is reported by **22% of youth** and **8% of elders**, but for youth it represents a stepping stone in the education-to-work transition, while for elders it reflects continued engagement or economic necessity in later life.

Youth respondents, who are employed part-time or full-time, are overwhelmingly engaged in the **private sector (79%)**, indicating a strong orientation toward formal urban employment. In contrast, only **31% of elders**, who are employed part-time or full-time, reported private sector work, with their occupational profile spread more evenly across **self-employment (16%)**, **business ownership (19%)**, and **agriculture (12%)**—sectors with limited youth presence.

Government jobs are rare across both groups but slightly higher among elders (3% vs. 1% in youth), particularly in non-Metro cities. **Self-employment and business ownership**, marginal among youth (4% each), are significantly more common among elders, reflecting legacy occupations or post-retirement enterprises.

Youth are largely engaged in formal private sector jobs, while elders rely on a broader mix of self-employment, agriculture, and informal work, reflecting generational and economic differences in occupational pathways.

Daily wage work remains relevant for both groups, though slightly higher among elders (14%) than youth (9%). Meanwhile, **agriculture is virtually absent among youth (1%)**, but still sustains a notable share of elders, especially the 80+ group.

In essence, while youth are concentrated in **formal sector jobs**, elders display a **more diversified and informal occupational mix**, shaped by generational, economic, and health-related factors.

6.3. Financial Independence and Income Sources

Just under half (**45%**) of elders reported being **financially independent**, primarily through income or pensions. This proportion is notably higher among **males (52%)**, **younger elders (60–70 years, 49%)**. Notably, independence is highest for those living in **nuclear families (51%)**.

Partial dependence is reported by **38%**, with a higher share among **females (41%)**, **SEC C (39%)**, and those in **joint and extended families**, possibly indicating shared household contributions.

Full dependence on family is relatively low overall (**15%**), but spikes among the **very old (24% of 80+)**, **females (18%)** and **SEC C (16%)**.

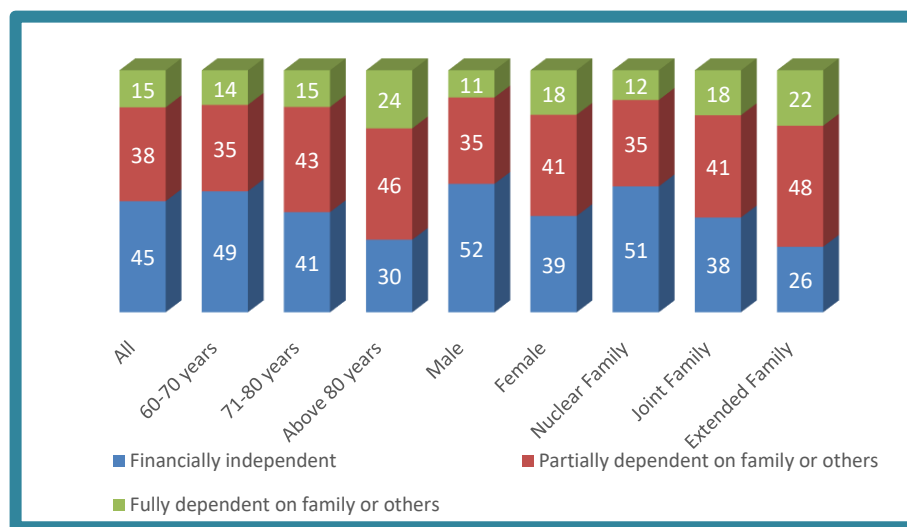


Figure 4: Financial Independence of Elders across age, gender and type of family

Financial independence is higher among those with higher education (63% among diploma/graduate level and 54% among secondary and higher secondary educated). It is also highest among elders who are **working full-time or self-employed (68–70%)**, and among those employed in the **government jobs (86%)** or **private sector (77%)**. As expected, independence is also highest for those living alone (62%) or with spouse only (62%). Elders who are **unable to work due to health reasons** show a strong trend of partial dependence (39%). **Full dependence** on family is higher among those with **no formal education (22%)**.

This data on financial dependence underscores the intersection of age, health, and living arrangement with financial vulnerability.

Among the youth, students were queried about their financial independence and it was found that a majority (**58%**) of them are **fully financially dependent** on their families. Dependence is highest among **younger youth (64% of 18–24 age group)** and **females (66%)**. Nearly **one in four students (24%)** are **mostly dependent**, meaning their family covers major expenses, but they manage some costs themselves. A smaller segment (**11%**) report being **partially dependent**, contributing significantly via part-time work or scholarships. Only **6% of student youth are fully financially independent**.

Elders' sources of income show clear stratification based on their level of financial dependence. Among those who are **financially independent (45%)**, the most common sources of income include **government pension (58%)**, **own business or self-employment (30%)**, **salary or wages from current work (18%)**, and **employer-provided pensions or provident funds (23%)**. This group also reports modest contributions from **rental income (12%)** and **interest from savings (5%)**, indicating a mix of continued work and asset-based income.

In contrast, the **partially dependent group (38%)** relies less on personal earnings and more on **limited or irregular pension access**. While 49% report receiving a government pension, only 19% access employer pensions, and a smaller proportion (10%) still earn from current work. Dependency on **children and relatives increases** here, with **25% reporting financial support** from family as a source of income.

Among the **fully dependent elders (15%)**, access to all personal income sources drops sharply. Only 22% receive a government pension, and less than 1 in 10 report any form of earnings or investment income. A dominant **68% rely entirely on financial support from children or relatives**, and this group includes many who are older, not in paid work, or facing physical limitations.

This pattern reveals a strong link between **continued work, pension coverage, and financial independence**. Where these supports are absent, **family remains the primary fall-back**, especially for the most vulnerable.

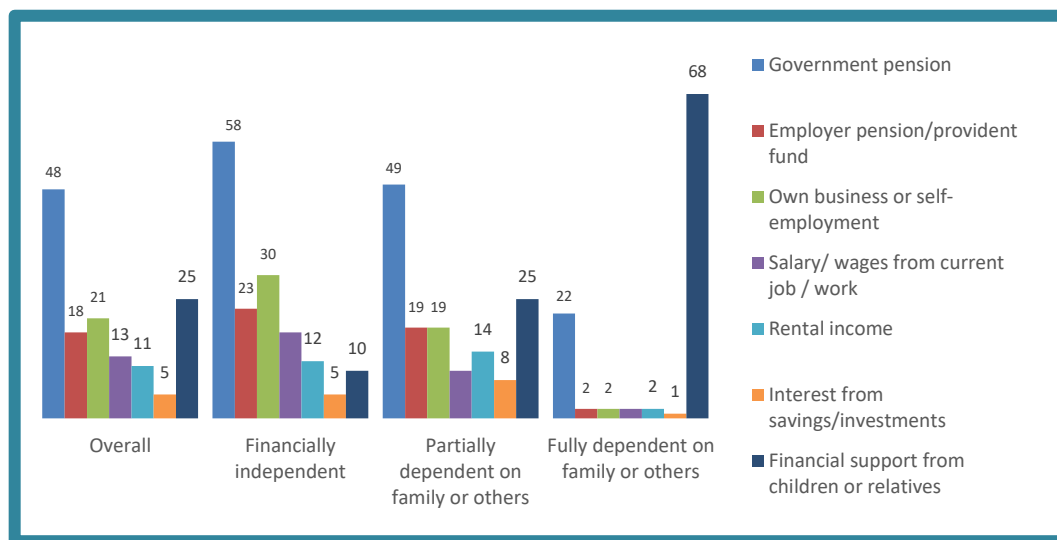


Figure 5: Source of Income of the Elderly by their Financial Independency

The data on average monthly personal income reveals clear generational, gender, and socio-economic disparities. **Elders earn an average of ₹8,233 per month**, with **men (₹10,507)** earning significantly more than **women (₹5,875)**. Income is higher among **SEC B elders (₹9,492)** than **SEC C (₹6,859)**, and peaks at **₹11,725** among those who are financially independent.

In contrast, **youth report a higher average income of ₹13,637**, reflecting active labour market engagement. **Male youth (₹14,354)** out-earn **females (₹12,493)**, though the gap is narrower than among elders. **SEC B youth (₹14,652)** earn more than **SEC C youth (₹12,177)**, and those in **private sector jobs** earn an average of ₹14,641.

Overall, the data highlights **intergenerational income progression**, but also persistent **gender and class-based income disparities**, suggesting that while youth are better placed economically, structural inequalities continue to shape earning capacity across both age groups.

6.4. Marital Status, Living Arrangements and Household Structure

Among **youth respondents**, **64% are single** and **34% are married**, consistent with their life stage. Only **1% each** reported being **widowed** or **separated/divorced**, reflecting low levels of marital dissolution or bereavement at younger ages.

For **elders**, **68% are married** and **only 3% are single**. However, a much larger share of elders (28%) —especially women (40%) — are typically **widowed**, reflecting **longer female life**

expectancy and gendered survival patterns. Increasing age also led to loss of a life partner with **57% of 80+ being widowed**.

In summary, while **marriage dominates elder life histories**, youth are **predominantly unmarried**, with rising marriage rates among older youth. Widowhood and long-term marriage are defining features of elder marital status, whereas youth are in a **transitional phase from singlehood to marriage**.

Most elders live in family-based arrangements:

- **51% live with spouse and children**, with this share rising to **54% among younger elders (60–70 years)**, among **males (60%)** and those belonging to **SEC B (55%)**.
- Also, **55% of those with financial independence** live with their spouse and children indicating contribution to household finances by them.
- **33% live with children only**, especially common among **females (43%)**, **those above 80 years old (56%)** and **those completely financially dependent (47%)**, reflecting widowhood or spousal absence, as well as financial vulnerability as they age.
- **7% live only with their spouse**, more common among **males (9%)** and **those with financial independence (10%)**, indicating continued companionship and better living

Most elders live in family-based arrangements, with co-residence patterns strongly influenced by gender and financial dependence

security.

- A small **4% live alone**, but this is slightly higher among **females (5%)** and **those with financial independence (5%)**.
- Only **3% live with other relatives or friends**, consistent across subgroups.

These differences suggest that **gender and financial dependence status shape living arrangements significantly**. **Female and those with financial dependence are more likely to depend on children**, while **male and better-off elders more often co-reside with spouses** or live more independently. This reflects both **economic dependency** and **social norms of caregiving** in urban aging households.

Elders and youth predominantly live-in **nuclear households**—55% and 57% respectively. However, **joint family living is more common among elders (40%)**, especially **older elders (61% of 80+ years)**, **females (42%)**, and **SEC B elders (42%)**. This reflects continued reliance on family-based caregiving and co-residence.

Among youth, **nuclear setups are more prevalent** in the **25–30 age group (60%)**, indicating a shift toward smaller, self-contained family units. **Joint family living is higher among younger youth (39%)** and **those living with elders (55%)**. Extended family living is rare across both groups but slightly more reported among youth. 4% among elders said that they lived in other household structures. These are mainly those who live alone or live with one other relative, who is not the spouse.

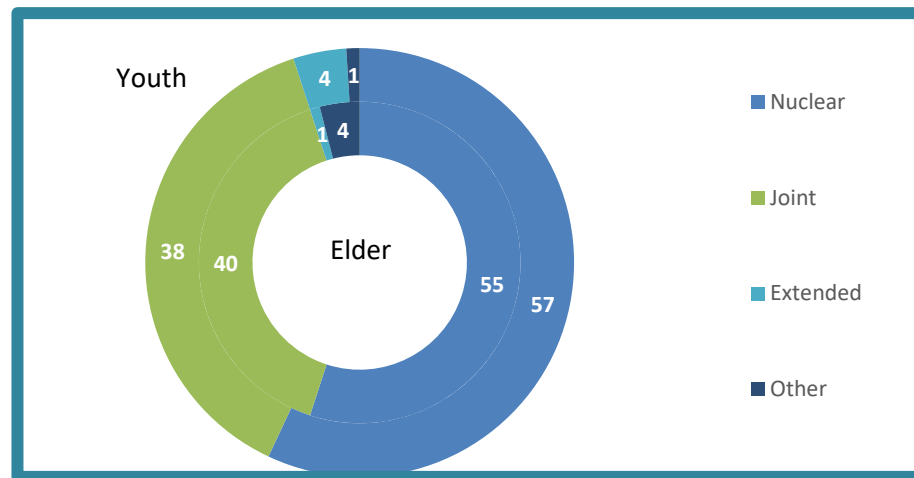


Figure 6: Household Structure across Elder and Youth

The pattern suggests that while **elders remain embedded in larger family systems**, **youth—particularly older, employed segments—are gradually moving toward nuclear arrangements**, reflecting generational change in urban household structures. The youth's higher nuclear living reflects a shift towards smaller, independent family units due to mobility, employment, and changing social norms.

6.5 Co-residence and Relationship with Co-resident

The proximity patterns reported by both elders and youth are strikingly aligned—**42% of elders and 43% of youth live in the same household**, while roughly one-third reside in the same city but different households (32% elders, 30% youth), and about a quarter live in different cities or villages (24% elders, 25% youth). This symmetry reflects a balanced perception of intergenerational closeness, indicating that co-residence and geographic proximity remain central features of urban familial structures.

Intergenerational co-residence in urban India is predominantly vertical, rooted in immediate familial ties. From the **elders' perspective**, the most common co-residing relatives are **sons (57%)** and **daughters (30%)**, with **grandchildren (28% grandsons, 23% granddaughters)** also playing a notable role. This reflects a caregiving model centred on direct descendants, especially among **younger elders (60–70 years)** and **financially independent or joint family members**.

Youth respondents most commonly live with elder (60+ years) **parents (24% father, 24% mother)** and **grandparents (26% grandfather, 27% grandmother)**. Relations such as **great-grandparents (7–8%)** and **extended relatives like uncles/aunts (3% each)** do co-reside but are less common. These figures indicate that **multigenerational living remains strong, particularly in joint households.**

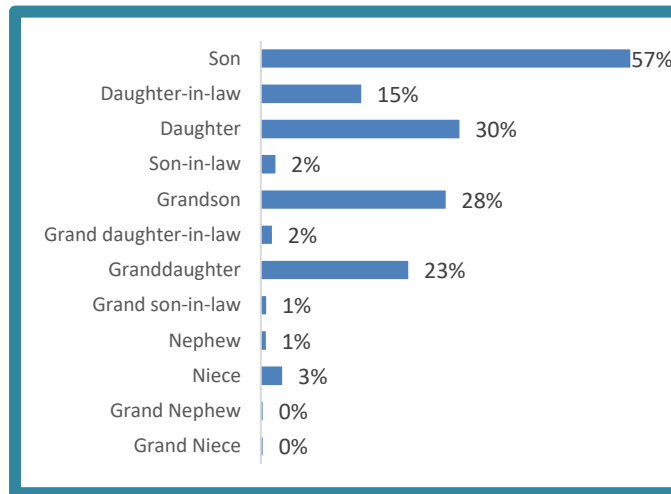


Figure 7: Relationship of Co-resident Youth with Elder

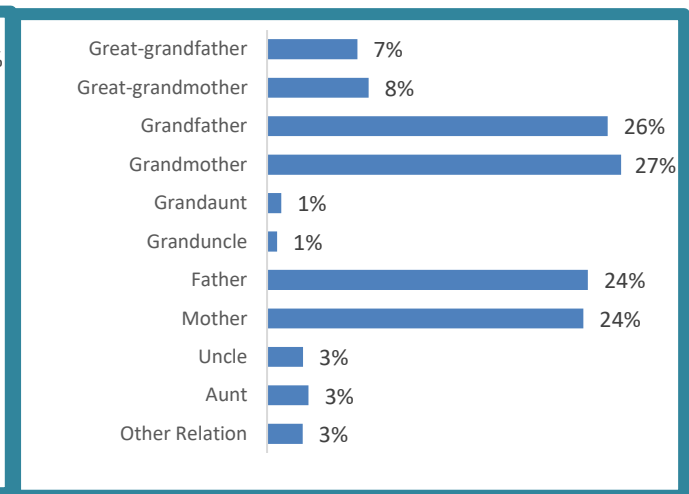


Figure 8: Relationship of Co-resident Elder with Youth

These figures underscore the **strong norm of multigenerational living**, with most elders continuing to reside closely with younger family members—especially children and grandchildren. Such proximity supports **daily interaction, emotional bonding, and practical care**, making co-residence a critical component of elder well-being in urban India.

In summary, the demographic profile reveals a significant generational shift: youth are markedly more educated, economically engaged, and reside predominantly in nuclear families, while elders show lower educational attainment, higher financial dependence, and stronger representation in joint households. Elders' living arrangements and financial independence are closely tied to gender, health, and marital status—women, the very old, and those with limited education are more likely to be widowed and fully dependent. Despite urbanization, multigenerational co-residence remains prevalent, especially through vertical ties like children and grandchildren, preserving intergenerational support structures in Indian urban households.

7. PERCEPTIONS ABOUT AGEING

This section explores how ageing is perceived by both youth and older persons, using attitudinal scales and thematic groupings to assess stereotypes, respect, and perceptions of elder capability. Responses from youth were analysed across subgroups—by age, gender, education, SEC, and proximity to elders—and grouped under three indices: **Stereotype/Negative Bias**, **Value and Respect**, and **Dependency and Capability**. These scores help identify patterns such as **Strong Ageism**



(high stereotype, low respect) and **Openness to Elder Inclusion** (high capability beliefs). The section also examines how elders are portrayed in media, the challenges they face, and the emotional language used by youth to describe ageing, drawn from qualitative responses.

In parallel, older persons shared their **self-perceptions and emotional states**, reflecting both dignity and vulnerability. Their experiences—spanning loneliness, relevance, and independence—are contrasted with youth perspectives. These are further analysed across demographics like gender, SEC, proximity to youth, living arrangements, and financial or health status, with qualitative narratives offering deeper insights into their lived realities.

7.1. Youth perceptions – associations and attitudes

Respondents were shown a set of words and asked which best describe their perception of elders. The analysis showed that youth most frequently associate older persons with “**Lonely**” (56%), followed by “**Wise**” (51%), “**Dependent**” (48%), and “**Respected**” (43%)—indicating a blend of admiration and concern. “**Fragile**” (42%) and “**Active**” (37%) reflect mixed perceptions of elders’ physical vitality, while “**Ignored**” is least mentioned (17%)



Figure 9: Words Associated with Elders by the Youth

The youth were then presented with a set of attitudinal statements related to older persons. These statements spanned a range of views—from stereotypes and prejudices to respect, inclusion, and beliefs about elders’ independence and capability. Each respondent rated their level of agreement

using a 5-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree, 5 = Strongly Agree). The responses were subsequently grouped into three key thematic groups:

1. **Stereotype / Negative Bias** – capturing agreement with ageist or limiting stereotypes about elders (e.g., being burdensome, out of touch, unable to contribute).
2. **Value and Respect** – reflecting perceptions of elders as valuable, respected members of family and society.
3. **Dependency and Capability** – assessing beliefs about the extent of elder independence, contribution, and self-sufficiency.

These thematic aggregations allow for a clearer understanding of underlying attitudes among youth toward ageing and older individuals.

Stereotype / Negative Bias

The data on **mean agreement levels** (based on the 5-point scale) shows that youth respondents exhibit **moderate agreement** with several stereotypical views about older persons, especially around physical and cognitive decline. The highest agreement is with **“Old people look tired and worn out most of the time” (3.68)** and **“Most elderly people appear weak and unhealthy” (3.65)**, indicating that physical frailty is a common perception. This is closely followed by **“The elderly tend to have outdated views and are old-fashioned” (3.64)**.

Mean agreement levels for statements like **“Older people are unable to learn new things” (3.49)** and **“Elderly people often refuse to change their views” (3.50)** suggest that many youth perceive elders as inflexible and slow to adapt. Views on social interaction and image are also moderately endorsed— **“Older persons interfere too much in younger people’s life” (3.41)** and **“Wrinkles and grey hair make them look unattractive” (3.42)**.

Importantly, **“Old people are a burden on families”** received the lowest agreement (**2.97**), indicating broader rejection of overtly ageist attitudes.

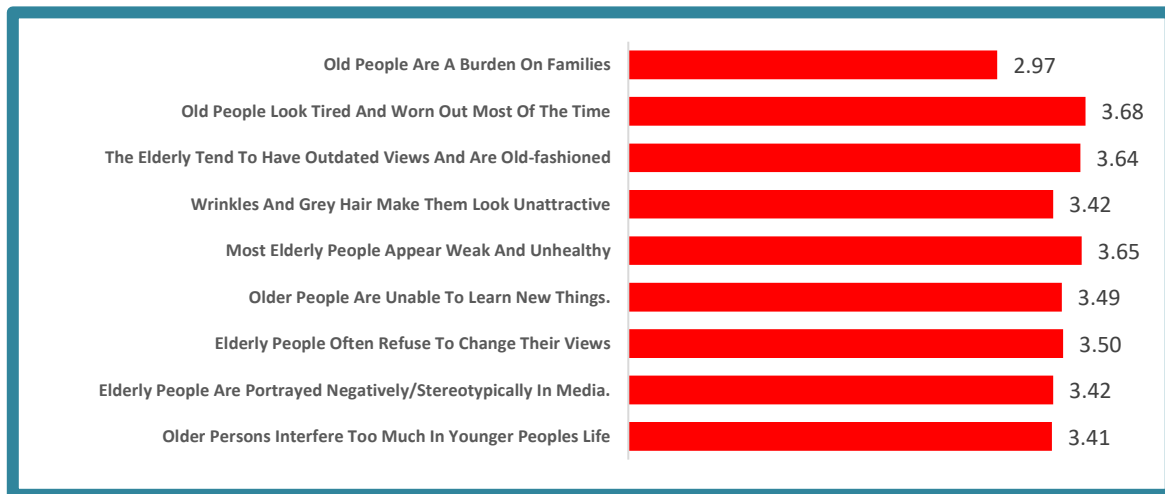


Figure 10 Mean Agreement Levels on Stereotype/Negative Bias Statements by Youth

While overt ageism is not strongly endorsed, youth hold **moderately stereotypical views**, particularly around elders' physical weakness and resistance to change. These findings suggest a need to counter everyday ageist assumptions through increased intergenerational engagement and positive visibility of active ageing.

Value and Respect

This segment explores youth attitudes reflecting the value and respect they attribute to older persons, based on a thematic grouping of attitudinal statements. The overall agreement across statements is **consistently high**, indicating strong endorsement of positive views toward elders.

The highest mean score was for **“Ageing is a natural dignified phase of life” (3.88)**, suggesting broad acceptance of ageing as a normal and respectful life stage. Similarly, youth **affirm their responsibility** through **“Youth have a responsibility to engage with and support the elderly” (3.77)** and **“Elders should be actively involved in community and family decisions” (3.75)**, both showing high agreement. The statement **“Old people have valuable advice to offer” (3.72)** also received strong support.

However, lower agreement levels for negative statements such as **“Older people are often neglected in families” (3.50)** and **“The knowledge and experience of older people are underutilized” (3.41)** suggest that while youth acknowledge these issues, **they are less widely endorsed** compared to positive beliefs.



Figure 11: Mean Agreement Levels on Value and Respect Statements by Youth

Youth respondents demonstrate **strong personal respect and responsibility** toward older persons, with high agreement on positive statements about elder wisdom, inclusion, and the dignity of ageing. In contrast, **lower agreement with negative statements** about neglect and underutilization suggests that while youth **recognize societal gaps**, they **do not personally endorse** such disregard. Overall, youth attitudes reflect **empathy, value, and support** for elders, alongside awareness of the need for greater societal inclusion.

Dependency and Capability

Youth perceptions on elder dependency and capability show a **balanced view**, recognizing both limitations and the potential for active ageing.

The statement **“Older persons can remain active and independent if supported”** received the **highest agreement (3.78)**, indicating a strong belief in elder capability when appropriate support is available. This is followed closely by **“Elderly people have already passed their productive phase of life” (3.73)** and **“Older persons today are lonelier than in the past” (3.69)**—reflecting acknowledgment of age-related withdrawal and emotional vulnerability.

There is **moderate agreement** that “**Digital tools can help strengthen relationships**” (3.49), suggesting openness to digital inclusion but with room for improvement in perception or experience. The statement “**The government and society provide enough support for elderly wellbeing**” scored low at **3.55**, indicating **limited confidence** in systemic support structures.

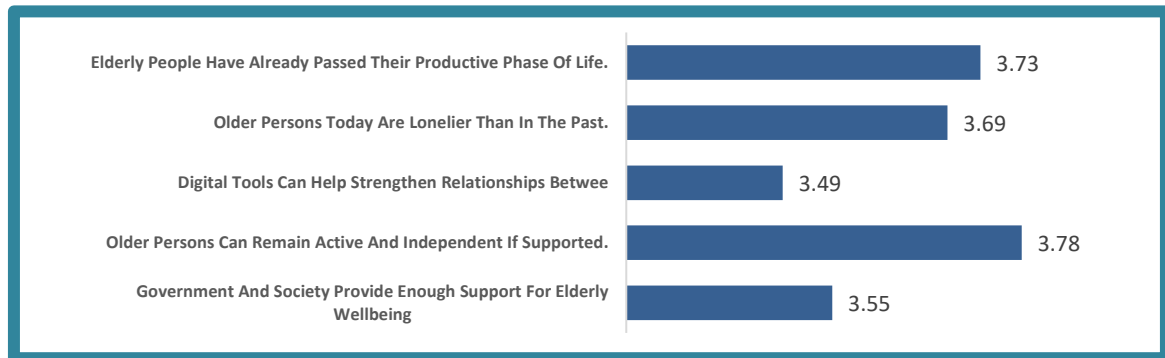


Figure 12: Mean Agreement Levels on Value and Respect Statements by Youth

Youth believe in elders' ability to remain active and independent with support, while also recognising emotional and systemic gaps. There is **realistic empathy** toward elder loneliness and **modest optimism** about the role of technology and institutional support, pointing to a nuanced and informed perspective on ageing.

Composite Index Scores

To quantify youth attitudes toward ageing, a set of **composite index scores** was developed based on grouped attitudinal statements, as given above. Each index captures a specific thematic dimension—**overall ageing attitude, stereotype bias, respect, and capability perceptions**—and allows comparison across respondent subgroups.

Four indexes were calculated:

1. **Ageing Attitude Score (1–100)** – derived from all attitude statements to provide an overarching measure of perception.
2. **Stereotype / Negative Bias Score (1–100)** – based on agreement with negative age-related stereotypes.
3. **Value and Respect Score (1–100)** – based on agreement with positively worded statements affirming elder respect and inclusion.
4. **Dependency and Capability Score (1–100)** – reflecting views on elder independence and the role of support.

For details of how the scores were calculated, please refer to the annexure.

These scores provide a robust, interpretable summary of youth perceptions and facilitate comparison across key demographic and relational segments.

The mean scores across various relevant subgroups are given in the table below.

Sub-groups		Ageing Attitude Score	Stereotype Negative Bias Score	Value and Respect Score	Dependency and Capability Score
Overall	All	50.02	61.63	63.59	51.97
Age Bracket	18–24 years	50.07	61.90	64.14	51.90
	25–30 years	49.96	61.31	62.95	52.05
SEC	B	50.13	61.77	64.10	51.98
	C	49.86	61.41	62.84	51.96
Gender	Male	49.84	62.02	63.59	51.95
	Female	50.21	61.19	63.59	51.99
Household Structure	Nuclear	49.97	60.72	62.37	51.84
	Joint	50.03	63.00	65.34	52.05
	Extended	49.26	64.33	63.72	53.46
Living with Elders	In Same HH	49.35	63.70	64.37	51.82
	In Same City	49.9	60.26	61.97	51.27
	Different City/Village	51.33	59.63	64.26	52.97
Metro vs. Non-metro	Metro cities	50.59	59.12	62.52	51.34
	Non-Metro cities	49.17	65.36	65.18	52.91

Table 3: Composite Scores of Attitude towards Ageing across various sub-groups

Ageing Attitude Score

The overall **mean Ageing Attitude Score** among youth stands at **50.02**, indicating a **neutral to moderately positive orientation** toward ageing on a 1–100 scale.

Differences across subgroups are generally modest. By **age**, younger youth (18–24 years) score slightly higher (50.07) than older youth (25–30 years, 49.96). **Females** (50.21) express marginally more positive attitudes than **males** (49.84). Across **socio-economic classes**, SEC B youth show a slightly more favourable attitude (50.13) than SEC C (49.86).

On **household structure**, youth from **joint families (50.03)** show marginally higher scores than those in **nuclear (49.97)** or **extended families (49.26)**. Interestingly, those with **low proximity to elders** report the highest scores (51.33), possibly reflecting idealised views of ageing from a distance.

Finally, **metro city respondents** (50.59) report more favourable attitudes than those in **non-Metro cities** (49.17), hinting at a modest urban gradient in ageing perceptions.

Youth perceptions of ageing are broadly neutral, with subtle positive variations among females and those with less direct proximity to elders. The pattern suggests respect for ageing is present but moderated by personal circumstances, exposure, and socio-economic conditions.

Stereotype Negative Bias Score

The **overall Stereotype Negative Bias Score** among youth is **61.63** (on a scale of 1–100), reflecting a **moderate level of agreement with age-related stereotypes**. While this suggests some persistence of stereotypical views, the scores vary meaningfully across demographic segments.

Gender differences are noticeable: **males** score higher (**62.02**) than **females** (**61.19**), indicating slightly stronger ageist biases among young men. In the **Focus Group Discussions** this gender difference was perceived with **male youth respecting the elder for strength**, but **considering them ‘nagging’ or ‘stubborn’**. **Female youth** on the other hand **viewed them as loving, but overprotective and emotional**.

Across **age groups**, the 18–24 and 25–30 age brackets show negligible differences (61.90 vs. 61.31), suggesting age is not a major differentiator in stereotype endorsement.

By **socio-economic class**, youth in **SEC B** score marginally higher (61.77) than those in **SEC C** (61.41), showing minimal class-based variation. However, **household structure** presents a clearer trend—**extended family respondents** report the **highest stereotype score (64.33)**, followed by **joint families (63.00)**, and the **lowest** scores are found among those in **nuclear households (60.72)**. This may suggest that more traditional family settings are linked to stronger age-based generalisations.

A striking pattern emerges in **proximity to elders**: youth with **low proximity** report the **lowest stereotype score (59.63)**, while those with **high proximity** score highest (**63.70**). This counters assumptions that closeness reduces bias, suggesting that more frequent exposure may reinforce traditional views rather than challenge them.

There is also variation across city types. **Non-Metro city respondents** report the **highest stereotype score (65.36)**, significantly above their **metro city** counterparts (**59.12**), indicating stronger ageist views in less cosmopolitan environments.

Stereotypical perceptions of older persons persist at a moderate level among youth, with slightly higher bias among males, joint/extended family dwellers, and Non-Metro city

residents. Interestingly, **greater proximity to elders does not necessarily reduce stereotype bias**, pointing to the need for deeper engagement that challenges rather than reinforces generational assumptions.

Value and Respect Score

The **overall Value and Respect Score** among youth stands at **63.59** (on a scale of 1–100), indicating a **generally positive attitude** toward older persons, with youth affirming the value, wisdom, and inclusion of elders in family and society.

Differences across **age, gender, and SEC** are minimal. Youth aged **18–24 years** (64.14) show slightly more respectful attitudes than those aged **25–30 years** (62.95). **Females** (63.59) and **males** (63.59) report identical scores, reflecting uniform gender attitudes. By socio-economic class, **SEC B** (64.10) scores marginally higher than **SEC C** (62.84).

Household structure reveals a meaningful gradient. Youth from **joint families** score highest (**65.34**), followed by those in **extended households** (**63.72**), and the **lowest respect levels are seen in nuclear families** (**62.37**). This suggests that **shared living environments with elders foster greater appreciation and inclusion**.

In terms of **proximity to elders**, the score is high across all groups, though slightly elevated among those with **high proximity** (**64.37**) and **low proximity** (**64.26**), compared to **medium proximity** (**61.97**)—indicating that both intimate exposure and respectful distance may encourage valuing elders.

A notable difference is seen between **metro city** youth (**62.52**) and those in **Non-Metro cities** (**65.18**), with the latter showing stronger expressions of respect, possibly due to more traditional or community-oriented value systems.

Youth attitudes toward older persons reflect a **strong sense of value and respect**, especially in joint family contexts and smaller cities. These findings affirm that the cultural foundation for respecting elders remains robust, though continued efforts are needed to translate these sentiments into everyday inclusion and participation of older persons.

Dependency and Capability Score

The **overall Dependency and Capability Score** is **51.97**, indicating a **balanced youth perception**—neither strongly viewing elders as dependent nor fully independent. This moderate score reflects both **acknowledgment of elder capability** and **recognition of support needs**.

Age and gender differences are minimal: both **age brackets** (18–24 and 25–30 years) and **males (51.95)** and **females (51.99)** report nearly identical scores, suggesting stable views across these segments. By **socio-economic class**, SEC B (51.98) and SEC C (51.96) also show virtually no variation.

Household structure presents slight variation:

- **Extended family** youth report the **highest score (53.46)**, implying stronger belief in elder capability when embedded in larger family support systems.
- Youth from **joint families (52.05)** score slightly higher than those from **nuclear households (51.84)**.

Proximity to elders influences perceptions notably, with youth with **low proximity** to elders report the **highest score (52.97)**, suggesting a more idealistic view of elder independence.

Geographically, **Non-Metro city** youth score **higher (52.91)** than **metro city** respondents (51.34), indicating **slightly more confidence in elder self-sufficiency** in less urbanised contexts.

Youth hold **moderately positive views** of elder capability, especially when elders are embedded in larger families or observed from a distance. While they recognise the need for support, there is also a clear belief that elders can remain active and independent with the

Urban youth perceive elders with a blend of respect and concern—valuing their wisdom and role, yet associating them with loneliness, dependence, and physical decline.

right conditions—underscoring a **realistic and empathetic outlook on ageing**.

Youth in urban India hold a nuanced view of ageing—balancing cultural respect with realistic concerns. While positive associations like “wise” and “respected” are

common, “lonely” and “dependent” also feature prominently, reflecting empathy tinged with concern. Attitudinal data reinforces this mix: high respect and inclusion scores coexist with moderate agreement on age-related stereotypes, especially around physical decline and outdated views. Youth broadly support elder engagement and capability, but their perceptions remain shaped by both lived experience and societal narratives. These insights call for deeper intergenerational interaction to bridge perception gaps and promote active, valued ageing.

7.2. Youth Perceptions – Media Portrayals of Elder

This section explores how youth perceive the way older persons are depicted in media—whether positively, negatively, or stereotypically—and examines how these portrayals influence their own attitudes and impressions about ageing. Media serves as a powerful

channel of social learning, and understanding its impact helps contextualise youth perceptions beyond direct family or social experiences.

While **49% of youth believe elders are portrayed positively** in the media, a notable **28% view portrayals as neutral** and **10% as mixed**—suggesting that representations may often lack clarity or emotional depth. Older, less educated youth, students, home-makers and those living in close proximity to elders in the same family and those from non-Metro cities report more positive influence.

Youth primarily associate elders in media with **positive familial roles**, with **69% identifying them as caring grandparents**, the most frequently cited portrayal. Other common depictions include **dependent or sick elders (53%)**, **wise mentors (49%)**, and **respected community members (46%)**, suggesting a blend of reverence and vulnerability.

However, **42% also stated that elders were shown as comic or irrelevant characters**, indicating that media often uses older persons in **lightweight or peripheral roles**, which may dilute the seriousness of elder representation. Meanwhile, only **25% say that media associate elders with loneliness or isolation**, highlighting undercurrents of emotional marginalisation. A very small percentage (**2%**) say elders are rarely or never shown in media.

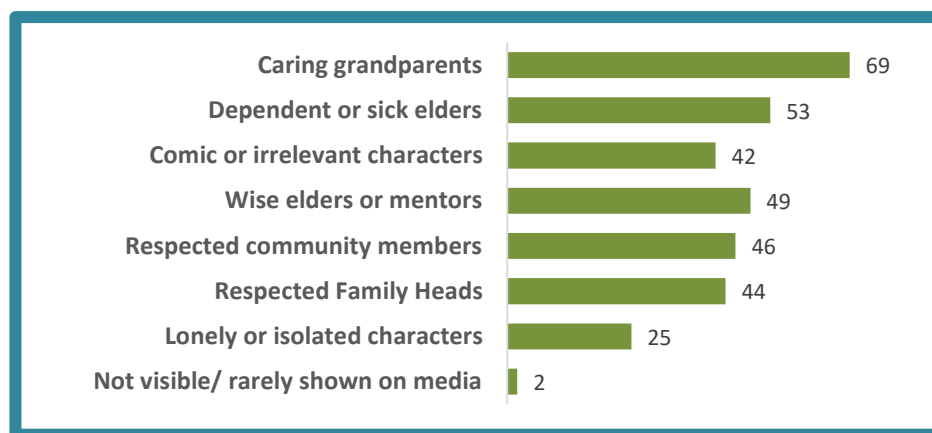


Figure 13: Youth Perception of Roles Portrayed by Elders in Media

Youth see elders in media as largely caring and wise, but also vulnerable and occasionally trivialized. The presence of comic and dependent portrayals suggests a need for **more balanced and empowering representations** that reflect the full dignity, diversity, and capability of older persons.

Media portrayals of elders appear to influence youth significantly, with a combined **80%** saying portrayals affect them either **“definitely” (46%)** or **“to some extent” (34%)**. Only 16% say media has little or no impact.

Perceived impact is **higher among those living in joint families as compared to those living in nuclear families**, with 50% in joint families and only 44% in nuclear families saying that media portrayals definitely impacted them. It was also **higher among students, home-makers and those living in joint families and non-Metro towns**, possibly due to stronger identification with on-screen portrayals.

The data confirms that **media plays a substantial role in shaping youth attitudes toward ageing**. This was further brought up by youth voices during FGDs stating that –

“After watching Baghban, I just wanted to save money for my own old age.” — Youth, Kanpur

“Social media makes us laugh at grandparents, but also admire them. Those short videos do change how we see them.” — Youth, Madurai



This underscores the importance of promoting **authentic, diverse, and respectful representations of older persons** to positively influence intergenerational understanding.

7.3. Youth Perceptions of Challenges faced by Elders

Youth overwhelmingly identify **health problems (69%)** and **financial insecurity (66%)** as the most pressing challenges facing older persons today, highlighting concerns around ageing-related frailty and insufficient income security. **Loneliness and isolation (52%)** also feature prominently. These challenges were mentioned more by youth staying in **joint families (60% by nuclear family members, 66% by joint family members)**, in close proximity to elders – possibly reflecting the realities observed by them.

Issues such as **lack of respect (41%)** and **neglect or abuse (34%)** are also recognised by a significant share of respondents.

Fewer youth highlight structural or systemic barriers: **limited digital access (15%)**, **lack of public services (15%)**, and **disengagement from community or family (9%)** are less frequently mentioned.

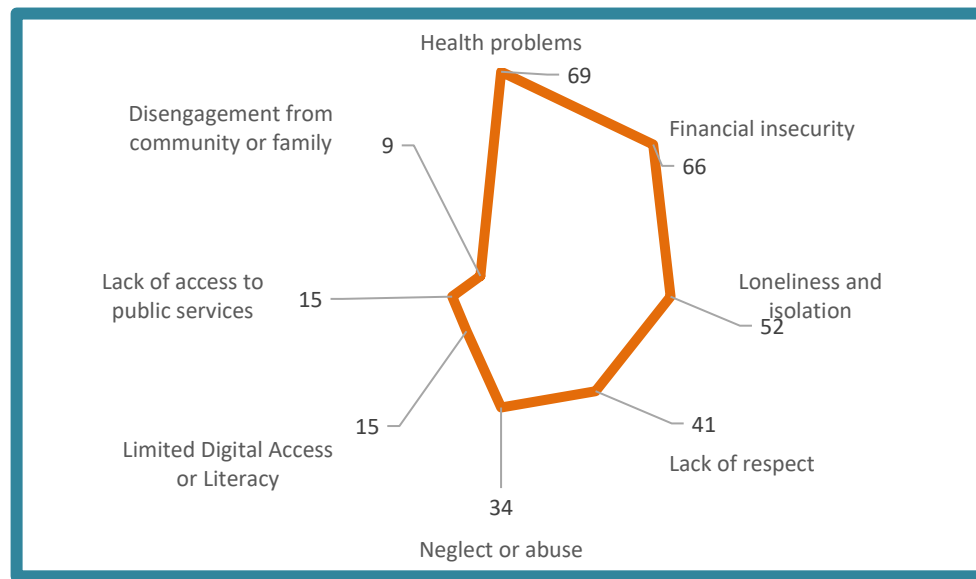


Figure 14: Youth Perceptions of Challenges faced by Elders

Notably, **Non-Metro city respondents** express greater concern for emotional and social challenges—such as **isolation (64%)** — compared to metro youth, indicating a perceived erosion of intergenerational bonds in smaller urban settings.

Youth view ageing through a lens of **health, financial, and emotional vulnerability**, with relatively less focus on digital and institutional exclusion. Youth voices from the FGDs echoed this –

“Growing old means being dependent, lonely, and forgotten.” – Youth, Madurai

“It’s about retirement, medicine, and sometimes depression.” – Youth, Mumbai

“Ageing is a journey — but a stressful one.” – Youth, Mumbai

“There’s fear of health issues, losing importance, and becoming a burden.” – Youth, Madurai

The responses reflect a combination of personal empathy and observed realities, underscoring the need for stronger elder support systems—both within families and through public infrastructure.

7.4. Elders' Self-perception – Feelings and Emotions Experienced

This section examines how older persons feel about growing old, including the major emotions experienced by them now. It captures elders' self-perceptions of ageing and contrasts these with how youth perceive the emotional experiences of older people. The analysis covers variations across age, gender, socio-economic status, living arrangements, and relational proximity to youth.

A majority of elders (54%) express **mostly negative feelings** about ageing—citing emotions like neglect, dependence, or weakness. Negative sentiment is especially pronounced among those who are younger (60-70 years – 57%), males (56%), those from SEC B (56%), those with higher education (61% - 74%), those who have been working or are working now (57% - 63%), those who are financially independent (64%) and living in non-Metro cities (63%) with their spouse and children (63%).

A majority of elders report negative feelings about ageing, with emotional wellbeing shaped more by connection and context than by age, education, or financial independence.

Only **11% express positive feelings**, such as feeling valued or wise and about **one-third (32%) report neutral feelings**, indicating quiet acceptance of ageing without strong emotional charge. Positive and Neutral feelings were higher among the **80+ years old, those with no formal education, unable to work due to health problems and financially dependent**.

Elders report a broad spectrum of emotions as well, with **loneliness (47%)** emerging as the most commonly experienced feeling, especially among the **80+ age group** and those **living alone**.

Happiness (45%) and **fulfilment (38%)** are also widely felt, as are **contentment (34%)** and **confidence (32%)**, particularly among **home-makers, those who are employed and who have financial independence**. However, **anxiety (38%)**, **irritability (27%)**, and **sadness (24%)** remain significant—more frequently reported by those who are **above 80 years old, unable to work and financially dependent**.

The 80+ dependent segment often inhabits a space of **emotional ambivalence**—balancing acceptance and resignation with periodic distress stemming from lived realities. This highlights the need for **psychosocial support**, not just physical care, to ensure dignity and emotional well-being in very old age.

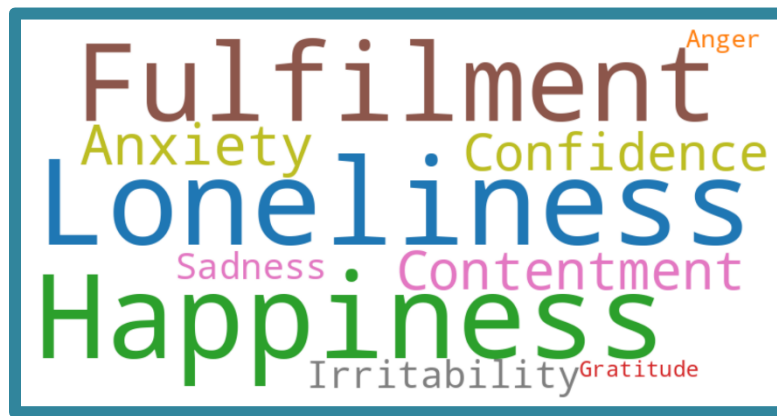


Figure 15: Emotions experienced by the Elders

Negative feelings about ageing and feeling lonely and ignored were also voiced by the elders in the Focus Group Discussions. Some of the elder speaks were –

“We are told the plan, not asked. That hurts more than staying silent.” — Elder, Madurai

“Even if we live in the same house, we eat alone.” — Elder, Kanpur

“Children don’t sit and talk anymore. They are always on their phones.” — Elder, Kolkata

“We used to gossip with friends. Now we scroll silently. Even loneliness has gone digital.” — Elder Kolkata

Women tend to internalize distress silently, focusing on continuing caregiving roles to retain a sense of purpose:

“I still cook because my grandson loves it. I feel useful then.” — Female, Madurai

“I cry sometimes, but not when they can see.” — Female, Madurai

Men, on the other hand, express more concern over lost control, physical decline, and dependence:

“I just walk and sit in the park sometimes. That’s enough.” — Male, Mumbai

In conclusion, older persons express a range of emotional experiences toward ageing—many report negative feelings like loneliness, irrelevance, and emotional neglect, especially among the younger elderly, males, the educated, and financially independent. At the same time, a segment of elders—particularly those who are economically engaged, employed, or financially stable—express happiness, contentment, and a sense of fulfilment, often tied to

continued contribution or routine. Another group, including the oldest old, financially dependent, or those with limited education, show a quiet resignation or neutral acceptance of ageing, marked by reduced expectations rather than dissatisfaction. Together, these insights reveal that **elder wellbeing is shaped not only by age or income, but by emotional connection, purpose, and inclusion**—elements that remain critical for ageing with dignity.

7.5. Elders' Self-perception – Dependence vs. Independence

This section explores how older persons perceive their own independence and support needs, highlighting variations by age, financial status, education, and family context.

The data shows that **elderly perceptions of independence vary significantly by age, education, financial status, and family structure**.

Overall, a **plurality (37%)** of elders identifies as **fully independent and preferring it that way**, while **33%** say they are **mostly independent but rely on family for some things**, reflecting a balanced view between autonomy and selective support.

Older elders (80+) report the **lowest levels of full independence (18%)** and **highest levels of dependency (24%)**, suggesting increased reliance on others with age.

Interestingly, those with **no formal education** and those **financially dependent** are **less likely to report dependency** and more likely to describe their role as **interdependent** or part of mutual support structures. This may reflect adjusted expectations or stronger community bonds.

Elders who are **financially independent** are the most likely (52%) to say they are **fully independent and prefer it that way**, while only 13% of them report feeling dependent—confirming the **positive impact of economic autonomy** on perceived self-sufficiency.

Nuclear family members report being **completely independent (44%)** or **mostly independent (28%)**, while **joint family members** report a **higher percentage of mostly independent and completely dependent**.

A small yet notable proportion of elders across all groups (4–10%) report feeling **overburdened by responsibilities despite ageing**, hinting at a segment that continues to carry emotional or caregiving loads.

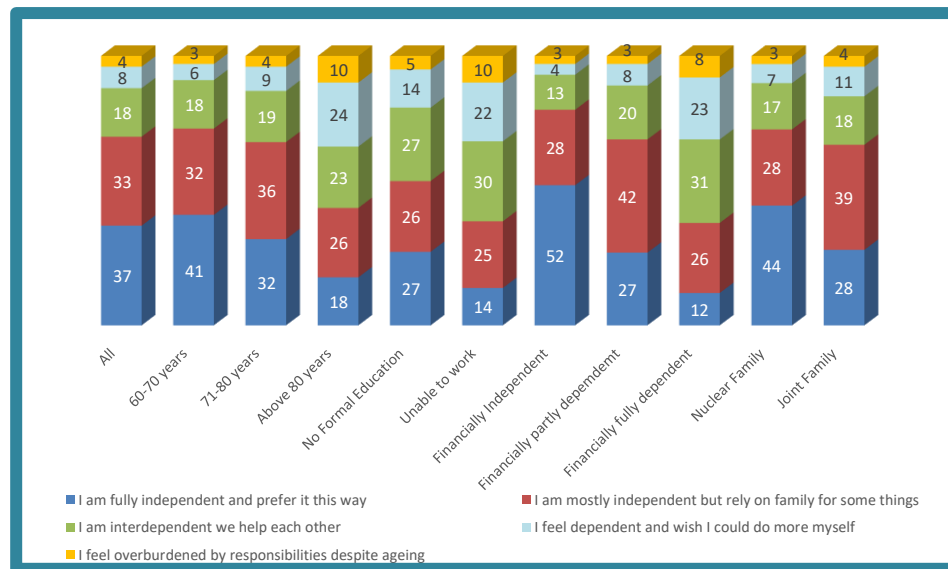


Figure 16: Perception of Elders about Dependence vs. Independence across sub-groups

From the Focus Group Discussions, it was seen that practical dependence emerged in daily situations.

“When I’m sick, I don’t want to ask for help. But I have no choice.” – Elder, Kolkata/Mumbai

It was also seen that care-giving roles sustain a sense of independence and purpose.

“I still cook because my grandson loves it. I feel useful then.” – Female, Madurai

Perceptions of independence among elders are shaped as much by **economic status and living arrangements** as by age. While many maintain a sense of autonomy, others navigate interdependence or silent burden. These insights underline the importance of **support structures that respect elders' agency while offering responsive assistance**.

7.6. Comparison of Youth Perceptions and Elders’ Self-Perception about Ageing

Emotions and Associations

Youth primarily associate ageing with *loneliness* (56%), *dependence* (48%), and *wisdom* (51%)—a mix of concern and respect. Elders, however, predominantly report *negative feelings* (54%) about ageing—especially younger, educated, and financially independent elders—validating youth perceptions of emotional distress, though youth tend to under-recognize the intensity of these feelings.

Respect and Value

Youth express strong agreement on respecting elders (Value & Respect Score: 63.59), affirming their wisdom and inclusion in decisions. Yet, many elders do not feel equally valued, as shown by quotes like "*We are told the plan, not asked.*"—indicating a disconnect between youth intentions and elders' lived emotional realities.

Stereotypes vs. Lived Experience

Youth hold moderate stereotype biases (Score: 61.63), especially about elders being physically frail or outdated. Elders themselves confirm feelings of decline, dependence, and being left out—reinforcing some of these stereotypes but also revealing deeper emotional layers such as sadness, anxiety, or resignation that youth may not fully grasp.

Youth express respect and empathy toward elders, but elders' self-perceptions reveal deeper emotional disconnects—highlighting the need for more meaningful intergenerational engagement beyond intention and image.

Capability and Independence

Youth believe elders can remain active if supported (Dependency & Capability Score: 51.97), and elders who are economically independent or employed often report higher levels of *happiness, contentment, and confidence*. Yet, a large proportion of elders, especially the oldest and financially dependent, experience *anxiety, loneliness*, and a loss of control.

Media Influence

Youth perceive elders in media mostly as *caring, wise, but also dependent or comic*, and 80% acknowledge that these portrayals influence their views. Elders, meanwhile, report feeling *ignored or digitally displaced* even within households, suggesting that media may shape youth attitudes but does not necessarily translate to deeper engagement or empathy in real life.

In conclusion, youth respect elders in principle and recognise their vulnerabilities, but often underestimate the emotional depth of elders' negative experiences. Elders, in contrast, feel increasingly invisible or undervalued despite youth's stated intentions. Bridging this perceptual gap requires not just intergenerational contact—but authentic communication and shared decision-making that affirms elders' dignity, purpose, and emotional well-being.

8. INTERACTIONS AND BONDING BETWEEN ELDERS AND YOUTH

This section explores the nature, depth, and frequency of interactions between youth and older persons, capturing both perspectives. It examines where, how often, and in what ways intergenerational engagement occurs—across daily routines, social, digital, and financial domains—and how these vary by demographic and relational factors. The analysis is enriched with qualitative insights on emotional bonding, perceived value, and missed connections, culminating in an Intergenerational Interaction Score that reflects the overall strength of these relationships.



8.1. Frequency and quality of interaction

This sub-section analyses how frequently youth interact with older persons, the modes and contexts of these interactions, and the demographic patterns and qualitative nuances that shape them.

Relationship between Youth and Elders who interact with each other

The data shows that youth most commonly interact with **grandparents (49%)** and **parents (45%)**, followed by **neighbours (36%)** and **family friends (24%)**—indicating that both family and community-based relationships are central to intergenerational interaction.

Elders most frequently report interacting with **sons (50%)** and **grandsons (40%)** followed by **slightly lower interactions with daughters (30%)** and **granddaughters (29%)** indicating that immediate family—particularly adult children—remains the primary point of contact in intergenerational relationships. **The spouses of children and grandchildren, other relatives and neighbours/tenants are the third most interacted with groups.** This reflects a generational gradient in closeness, where interactions are more routine and support-based with children, and more emotionally fulfilling or socially engaging with grandchildren.

The higher interaction levels reported by elders with **sons** compared to **daughters**, and with **grandsons** compared to **granddaughters** can be attributed to a combination of cultural, residential, and caregiving norms prevalent in many Indian households such as patrilocal living patterns, whereby in traditional Indian family systems, **married sons typically stay with or near their parents**, while **daughters move to their husband's home** after marriage. Moreover, in many households, **sons are culturally seen as the default providers of support in old age**—financial, logistical, and emotional. Elders may spend more time with **grandsons** due to cultural and practical reasons, such as **grandsons are often more mobile and digitally connected**, making them more visible or available to assist elders in daily tasks

(e.g., banking, smartphones). Also in patriarchal settings, grandsons may be more encouraged to visit or engage with grandparents, while granddaughters might face more household or social restrictions. Elders often interact more with the son's side of the family (including grandsons), especially in households where inheritance, property, or financial matters reinforce closer ties. In many families, **male youth are given more freedom to interact, move socially, or accompany elders outside the home**, while female youth may be less visible in these roles, even if emotionally close.

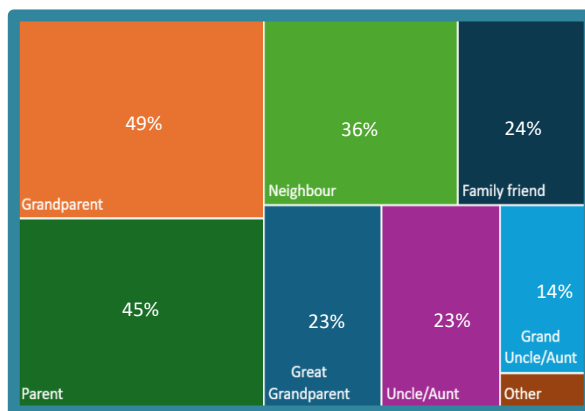


Figure 17: Relationship of Elder with Youth they interact with

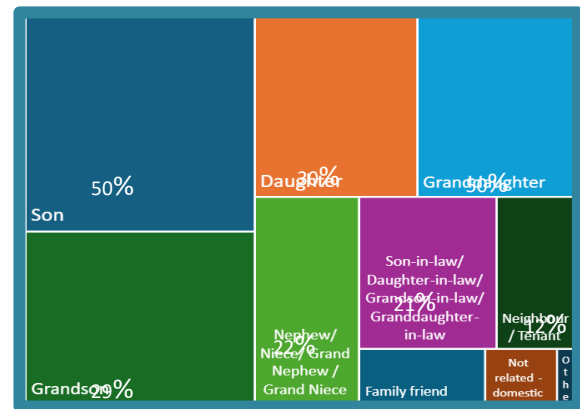


Figure 18: Relationship of Youth Elder they interact with

Youth with **no formal education** and **home-makers** report stronger ties to **parents and other relatives, friends and neighbours**, suggesting more localized or dependent networks.

Those in **extended households** show higher interaction with a wider range of elders, including **uncles/aunts** and **other relatives**, reflecting more layered intergenerational living.

Elders living in joint families are more likely to report interaction with a **broad set of youth**, including grandsons, granddaughters and their spouses indicating the social density of such arrangements.

In contrast, elders in **nuclear households** or those living alone often depend on **neighbours** or **family friends**, underlining the importance of community ties in the absence of co-residing kin.

Overall, the data highlights that **while kin-based interactions dominate, non-familial relationships** (especially neighbours and family friends) play a significant role—especially in **urban** and **non-cohabiting** contexts.

Frequency and Duration of Interaction

The data on frequency of interaction between elders and youth reveals strong regular engagement, with clear patterns across demographic and socio-economic subgroups.

Overall, two-thirds of elders (66%) report interacting with youth **daily**, and **20%** do so a few times a week. This shows that 86% of elders maintain at least weekly contact with youth, suggesting strong intergenerational touch points. Elders also reported spending on an **average 40 minutes with the youth in each interaction**.

Along similar lines, **61%** of youth report interacting with elders **daily**, and **19%** a few times a week – totalling **80%** with at least weekly engagement.

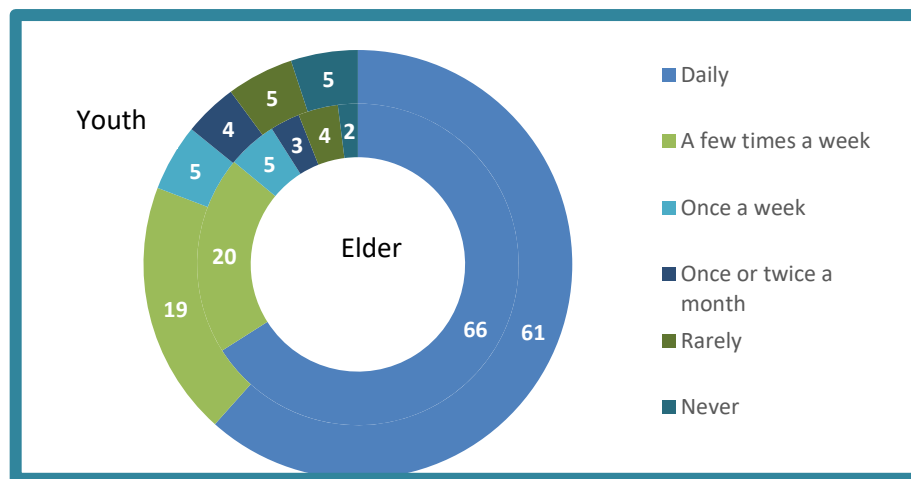


Figure 19: Frequency of interactions between Youth and Elders – Elder and Youth reported

Daily interaction, as reported by the elders, is highest among those living in **joint households** (79%) as compared to those living in **nuclear families** (58%)

Those living **in the same household as youth** (73%), in non-Metros (78%) and belonging to SEC B (74%) also have higher daily interactions.

Interestingly, even among **those aged 80+**, daily interaction remains high at **69%**, though slightly more elders in this group report reduced interaction ("rarely" at 10%).

Those interacting with **their children and their spouses** reported **higher daily interactions (73%)** as compared to those **interacting with their grandchildren (66%)**, indicating the care-giving roles played by children vis-à-vis the emotional or social connect with grandchildren.

Youth reported daily interactions with elders were notably higher among **students (69%)**, **home-makers (66%)**, **daily wage workers (67%)**, and the **self-employed (72%)**—a pattern that can be explained by their **greater availability at home, more flexible schedules**, and **proximity to family environments**.

As in the case of elders, those living in joint and extended families, with their elders, interacting with their parents and grandparents and living in Non-Metros reported higher daily interactions

Proximity remains a strong predictor of frequent interaction across both groups—those co-residing or in joint families report the highest engagement. Both youth and elders report high levels of intergenerational contact, with elders indicating slightly more frequent and consistent interaction.

The segment of **students, home-makers, daily wage workers, and the self-employed**—represents a **naturally embedded, high-contact group** in elder–youth dynamics. Because they already interact with elders daily, they are uniquely positioned to **strengthen emotional bonds, enhance elder wellbeing, and support active ageing**.

Locations and modes of interactions

This sub-section explores where and how interactions between youth and elders typically take place, highlighting physical, social, and digital spaces that facilitate intergenerational engagement from both perspectives.

The data reveals broad **alignment between youth and elders** in reporting that interactions most often occur **at home (81% youth, 82% elders), at family events (63% youth, 66% elders)** and **at public places** such as parks, temples, community centres (**56% youth, 53% elders**).

However, important differences emerge in **functional and digital modes**, which reflect generational perspectives, lifestyle routines, and access. **Youth reported 24% interaction at workplace** - possibly reflecting exposure through family businesses or observing working elders, while only **18% elders** reported such interactions due to mainly retirement or non-participation. Youth overestimate **digital interaction** slightly (**16%**), while **elders' (12%)**

lower reporting may reflect digital discomfort or low access, especially among the oldest or rural elders.

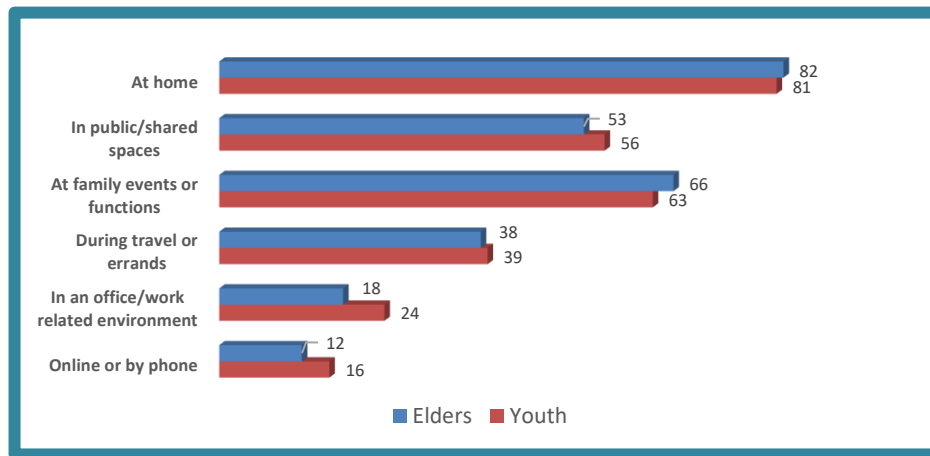


Figure 20: Elder and Youth specified locations of interactions

Joint families and same-household proximity show the highest frequency of in-home interaction on both sides. **Non-Metro city youth (84%) and elders (84%)** both report high at-home interaction.

Youth who are part of **nuclear families** report **higher interactions (61%) with elders at public / shared places**.

Youth and elders interacting with neighbours or family friends more often mention **travel and errands** related interactions

Both youth and elders overwhelmingly identify **face-to-face interaction** as the dominant mode (**88% each**), underscoring the importance of physical presence in intergenerational bonding. However, **elders report significantly lower engagement via digital modes** compared to youth, especially on **phone calls (63% elders vs. 71% youth)**, **video calls (28% vs. 43%)**, **social media (14% vs. 30%)**, and **written communication (4% vs. 10%)**.

This digital gap is more pronounced among elders who are older, less educated, or not economically engaged. Youth, especially educated, and student groups, who interact with family friends, appear more likely to perceive digital interactions as meaningful, while elders may not register these as strongly due to access, confidence, or preference.

In conclusion, while both youth and elders affirm that most interactions occur face-to-face and at home, there is a clear perceptual gap in the use and value of digital modes. Youth increasingly cite phone, video, and social media as meaningful forms of connection, whereas elders engage less with or under-recognize these channels. Strengthening

intergenerational bonds will require not only preserving in-person contact but also equipping elders with the confidence and access to participate in evolving digital forms of communication.

The fact that phones are not a very welcome mode of interaction was also brought out by the elders during the FGDs.

“Children don’t sit and talk anymore. They are always on their phones.” — Elder, Kolkata

“Because of phones, personal meetings have come down.” — Elder, Madurai

Public places such as parks were also considered to be good places of interaction, though roads were considered to be unsafe.

“Parks are really good nowadays. But on the roads, people push — they don’t see who is walking.” — Elder, Mumbai

Kinds of interactions – social and daily activities

This sub-section explores the types of interactions—both social and daily—between youth and elders, capturing shared activities such as conversations, entertainment, celebrations, and outings. It draws from the self-reported experiences of both groups to highlight convergences and gaps in intergenerational engagement.

Other types of interactions such as digital, financial and health-related are being discussed in subsequent sections.

Social Interactions

Conversations about personal and family matters emerged as the strongest common link—reported by **87% of youth** and **84% of elders**, underscoring mutual involvement in decision-making and emotional sharing.

Storytelling (youth: 52%, elders: 49%) and **watching movies or listening to music together** (youth: 52%, elders: 46%) also show good alignment, indicating emotionally resonant, low-effort shared experiences across both groups.

Around **54% of youth** and **44% of elders** report participating in religious or cultural events together, showing high engagement among youth and a slightly lower but significant presence among elders. There was alignment also on celebrating religious festivals and birthdays together with 30% of both elders and youth citing this instance.

29% of elders and **34% of youth** mention travelling or going on holidays together, while going out for meals or shopping is much lower (**elders: 17%, youth: 21%**), reflecting occasional but valued leisure bonding.

Youth report very limited play-related interactions—**7% for indoor games** and **2% for outdoor games**—and elders echo similar levels (**5% and 1% respectively**). These low numbers highlight an under-utilized area of potential light-hearted engagement.

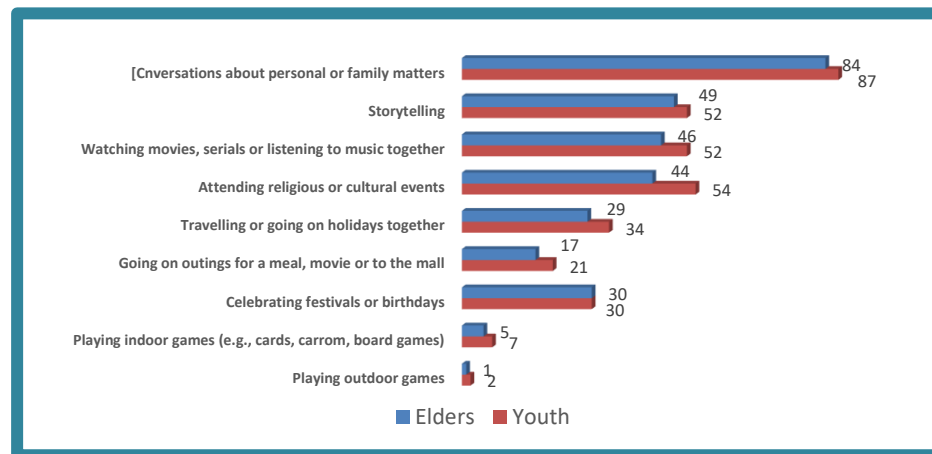


Figure 21: Types of social Interactions reported by Youth and Elders

Youth and elders living in **joint families** reported significantly higher engagement in shared activities such as **storytelling, watching movies or serials together, attending religious or cultural events**, and even **travelling or going on holidays**. This may reflect the richer day-to-day interactions and multi-generational cohesion typically found in joint households, where shared spaces and routines naturally foster more opportunities for emotional and cultural bonding.

Interestingly, **elders living in the same city but in separate households from youth** reported **greater participation in religious and cultural events, travel, and celebrations** than those co-residing in the same household. This could be due to a more intentional effort to spend quality time during visits, as opposed to routine interactions in shared homes which may be more functional or fragmented.

A distinct Metro-Non-Metro difference also emerges: both **youth and elders in Non-Metro cities** engaged more often in **storytelling and shared media consumption** than their Metro counterparts. This may be linked to slower-paced lifestyles, closer community ties, and fewer digital distractions—factors that encourage more interpersonal engagement and leisure time spent together.

Interactions related to Daily Activities

Both elders and youth largely align in their reports of shared daily activities, reflecting mutual acknowledgement of key areas of interaction and care. **Eating meals together** tops the list, cited by 72% of elders and 71% of youth, underscoring how mealtimes remain a consistent and accessible bonding opportunity across generations.

A strong area of support is seen in **health-related tasks**, reported by 67% of elders and even more by youth (72%), indicating that caregiving—such as accompanying elders to doctor visits or helping with medication—is both significant and recognised across perspectives.

Spiritual practices like prayers or meditation are also a notable form of connection, with slightly more youth (59%) than elders (52%) mentioning it, possibly pointing to a perceived or aspirational value among youth for culturally rooted shared routines.

Everyday **household chores** such as cooking or cleaning are acknowledged by over 40% of both groups, while **more intimate support tasks** (e.g., helping dress, bathe, or move around) are reported slightly more by youth than elders, suggesting elders may underreport assistance in these areas due to modesty or a desire to maintain an image of independence.

Interestingly, **running errands together** is the least cited shared activity (16% elders, 14% youth), indicating that functional outings may be less common or less valued as joint experiences.

The very low percentage of those reporting “**None**” (4% from both sides) reinforces the finding that intergenerational engagement—whether routine, emotional, or supportive—is present in most relationships. Those who specified no daily activities interactions were mainly based in different cities / villages.

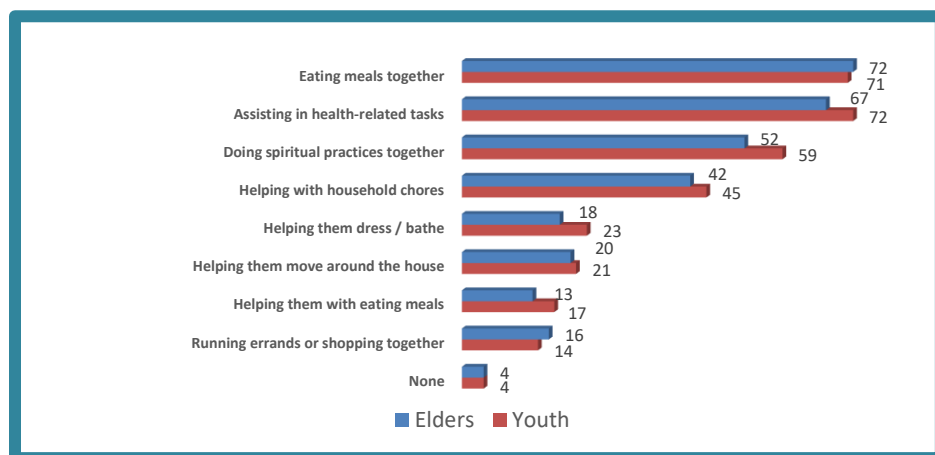


Figure 22: Daily Activities done together as reported by Elders and Youth

Older elders (80+ years) reported higher need for **assistance with health-related tasks and activities of daily living**—such as dressing, bathing, mobility, and eating—likely due to age-related physical decline and increased dependency.

Youth who were students were more likely to **eat meals with elders, assist with health-related tasks, and participate in spiritual practices**, possibly because of more flexible schedules and greater time spent at home. Similarly, **home-makers in both youth and elder groups** were more involved in **household chores**, reflecting traditional caregiving and domestic roles. Notably, **young female home-makers** also contributed significantly to elders' **personal care needs**, such as bathing and mobility assistance.

Joint family households, across both elders and youth, showed **higher involvement in shared meals, spiritual routines, and caregiving tasks**, compared to nuclear families. This reflects the more **interdependent structure and cultural orientation** of joint families, which naturally support collective caregiving and shared daily experiences.

Non-Metro respondents were more likely to report **shared spiritual practices and assistance with health-related tasks**, possibly due to **stronger traditional family bonds**, less institutional support, and greater reliance on family for elder care in smaller towns.

Hence, we find that intergenerational relationships are deeply rooted in shared social and daily activities, with strong alignment between youth and elder perspectives. Mealtimes, conversations, health-related caregiving, and spiritual routines emerge as key anchors of everyday connection. Joint family settings and non-Metro contexts foster richer interaction, while even separately housed elders maintain bonds through purposeful engagement. Despite generational shifts, the data reflects a continued cultural ethic of mutual involvement and care, with only a small minority reporting no shared engagement—signaling the enduring presence of meaningful youth–elder interactions in Indian households.

This is also brought out by some of the types of interactions specified during the FGDs -

“We just sit and talk while having tea. That’s our time together.” — Youth, Mumbai

“Sometimes I bring my dadi mithai and tell her a joke — it makes her day.” — Youth, Kanpur

“They raised us with stories. Now we teach them how to book train tickets.” — Youth, Kolkata

“I help my grandmother with videos... she asks so many times, I repeat it all calmly.” — Youth, Mumbai

8.2. Elder perspectives on bonding

This subsection delves into how older persons perceive their emotional connection with youth—exploring the depth of bonding, feelings of being valued or respected, and satisfaction with intergenerational interactions. It examines whether these sentiments have changed over time and what factors—such as age, gender, living arrangements, financial dependence, health, and proximity—shape these experiences. The analysis is enriched by qualitative insights that highlight both moments of meaningful involvement and instances of emotional distance in daily life.

Emotional bonding

A significant majority of elders feel emotionally connected to the youth they interact with—**52% rate the bond as “Extremely Close” and another 21% as “Close,”** totaling 73% expressing strong emotional proximity. Meanwhile, **23% report a neutral stance**, neither close nor distant, possibly reflecting more functional or reserved relationships. Only **4% express emotional distance**, suggesting that overtly strained intergenerational ties are rare. Overall, the findings indicate that most elders feel a meaningful emotional bond with the youth in their lives.

If we study the mean scores of emotional bonding (where 1= Not at all Close and 5= Extremely Close) we find interesting patterns across subgroups.

Emotional bonding decreases with age. Elders aged 60–70 report the highest closeness (4.28), while those above 80 show a marked drop (3.83), likely due to increasing frailty, dependency, or reduced shared activities.

Financial independence correlates positively with emotional bonding (4.35), while fully dependent elders score lower (4.01), possibly reflecting feelings of burden or reduced autonomy in relationships.

Emotional closeness is highest among those living with spouse and children (4.29) or in joint families (4.30) (nuclear family – 4.19). It is **lowest among those living alone (3.55)**. All of

Emotional ties run deepest where elders are empowered, families are united, and kinship stays close.

which suggest emotional distance due to social isolation or lack of familial integration.

Elders with no IADL (instrumental activity) limitations report the **highest emotional bonding (4.55)**, suggesting that those with higher functioning may feel more respected and involved.

Elders living in the **same household (4.35)** or non-Metro cities (4.38) feel closer, while those in **different households in the same city (4.05)** or living alone feel less connected, highlighting the role of shared daily life in maintaining emotional bonds.

Emotional closeness is strongest when youth are **sons/daughters (4.39)** and lowest with **friends (3.87)** and **neighbours (3.97)**, reaffirming that direct kinship and caregiving roles foster stronger emotional connections.

Perception of being valued and opinions respected

The majority of elders feel positively about how youth perceive them—**49% say their presence and opinions are “very much” valued**, and another **37% feel valued “to some extent.”** This indicates that **86%** of elders perceive at least moderate recognition and respect from the younger generation.

However, **14% express some level of disconnect**, with **12% feeling “not really” valued** and **2% “not at all.”** These figures, though smaller, highlight a meaningful segment experiencing emotional distance or marginalisation.

The low “not sure” response (1%) suggests that most elders hold clear opinions about their perceived value—either through direct interactions or observable behaviours. This reinforces the importance of meaningful inclusion in family decisions, conversations, and daily life to foster sustained emotional bonding and self-worth among elders.

Elders feel seen, heard and valued —especially when youth are near, they have financial independence, and families stay close.

A very similar pattern, as with emotional bonding, was observed when mean scores (1=Not sure, 5= Very much valued) were studied across various sub-groups.

Younger elders, those with financial independence, living with spouse and children or even with non-family in the same household, those not needing IADL (Instrumental Activities of Daily Living) support and those interacting with children or their spouses report higher mean scores of being valued and respected.

Also, Non-Metro city elders report higher perceived respect (**4.50**) than those in metro cities (**4.20**), indicating that more traditional family systems and slower-paced lifestyles may foster stronger intergenerational regard.

Feelings about interactions with youth

An overwhelming majority of elders—**80% in total**—report enjoying spending time with youth, with **50% stating “Yes, very much”** and another **30% saying “Yes, somewhat”**. An additional **18% remain neutral**, suggesting neither strong enthusiasm nor disinterest,

possibly due to irregular or limited interactions. Only **1% say “Not really”**, and none express complete disinterest. This clearly reflects a generally positive emotional connection and receptiveness among elders toward intergenerational engagement, underscoring its importance for their well-being and social inclusion.

Elders’ enjoyment of spending time with youth varies meaningfully across several subgroups and the findings suggest that elders who are more **physically active** (younger and needing no assistance), **economically independent, better educated, and embedded in close-knit living arrangements** tend to derive more joy from spending time with youth. On the other hand, those facing health challenges, financial dependence, or social isolation may struggle to connect as deeply, underscoring the importance of inclusive engagement strategies and family support.

When asked specifically what feelings were evoked when they interacted with youth, the majority of elders described their interactions as uplifting, with **42% feeling “happy and refreshed”** and **30% reporting a sense of being “emotionally closer.”** However, **19% said these moments reminded them of their age**—highlighting an emotional ambivalence. Only a small fraction **felt indifferent (3%), left out (4%), or emotionally low (1%)**, suggesting that while most experiences are positive, a few carry undercurrents of vulnerability or distance.



Figure 23: Feelings evoked in Elders when they interact with Youth

Elders **aged 60–70** feel more **“happy and refreshed” (46%)** than the **80+ group (26%)**, who instead feel more **“emotionally closer” (39%)** or **“reminded of their age” (17%)**.

Elders **living with spouse and children or in joint families** feel more positive, while those **living alone or with spouse only** report lower emotional benefits.

Co-residing elders feel more refreshed (48%), whereas those in **different cities feel more distanced or reminded of age (23%)**.

Close family ties (sons/daughters) lead to more happiness (49%), compared to interactions with neighbours or others.

Metro elders feel less refreshed (39%) than those in non-metro cities (48%), possibly due to faster-paced, more fragmented interactions in metros.

These differences highlight the need to strengthen meaningful, supportive interactions—especially for the oldest old, isolated elders, and those with limited mobility or weaker relational ties.

When queried about which category of persons elders like to interact with, **majority of elders express a preference for social interactions—39% enjoy spending time equally with both younger and older people,** while **35% prefer peers of their own age.** This reflects a strong desire for connection, with many open to intergenerational engagement. **Only 16% prefer spending time solely with youth,** suggesting that while some elders seek younger company, most are drawn to familiarity and shared experiences with peers. **Very few prefer solitude (2%) or have no clear preference (8%),** indicating that social isolation is not a widespread choice but may still affect a small group.

Preference for interacting with peers drops sharply among the **oldest group (80+ years: 23%)** and is replaced by a higher inclination to **engage with both age groups equally (47%).** This may reflect greater emotional openness or a stronger need for broader companionship among the very old.

Males show a stronger preference for peers (38%) than females (33%).

Financially independent elders show a greater inclination toward peer interaction (39%), while those fully dependent are more likely to **prefer both groups (61%).**

Elders in **Non-Metro cities** are more **peer-oriented (41%).**

Hence, we can surmise that elders largely value social connection, with most preferring interaction with both peers and youth. The very old and financially dependent show greater openness to intergenerational engagement, while males, the financially independent, and non-metro residents lean more toward peer interaction. These patterns highlight the need for inclusive social spaces that support both peer bonding and cross-generational connection.

Changes over time

This subsection explores whether elders now feel a greater desire to spend more time with youth, as well as how elders perceive the evolution of their relationship with younger generations over time.

A strong **majority of elders (86%)** express openness to spending more time with youth—**45% affirmatively** and **41% as a possibility**—indicating a clear interest in intergenerational connection. Only **8% are disinclined**, and **6% remain unsure**, suggesting that efforts to foster youth-elder engagement would likely be welcomed by most elders.

Across sub-groups the mean score of willingness to spend more time (1=Not Sure, 4=Yes want to spend more time) was examined and it was found that **willingness declines slightly with age, from 3.30 (60–70 years) to 3.10 (80+ years)**, suggesting reduced energy or opportunity among the oldest elders. **Financially independent elders (3.31)**, express more interest, compared to the **fully dependent (3.19)**. Elders **living alone (2.82)** report the lowest willingness, while those **living with children (3.31)** or in the **same household as youth (3.39)** are more open to spending time. Elders in **Non-Metro cities (3.46)** report significantly higher scores than those in **Metros (3.15)**, possibly reflecting more unmet social engagement needs in non-Metros.

Elders report a largely stable or improving relationship with youth over time—**37% say interaction has increased**, while **40% feel it has stayed the same**, indicating continuity or growth in intergenerational engagement for most. However, **1 in 5 elders (20%)** feel that interaction has decreased, pointing to a perceived distancing in some families. Very few

Elders show a strong desire to deepen bonds with youth, though age, dependence, and isolation can dim the spark, while proximity, independence, and non-metro living keep connections thriving.

report never having interacted with youth in the past (2%) or at present (1%), confirming that intergenerational contact remains a relevant and lived experience for the vast majority.

Elders aged **80+** report the **lowest increase** in interaction (**25%**) and the **highest decrease** (33%), suggesting greater

disengagement in later life.

Financially **independent elders (44%)** report more increase than the **fully dependent (25%)**, who also show **higher decrease (35%)**.

Elders **living with spouse and children** see more **increase (40%)** than those **living alone (22%)**. Those in the **same household (42%)** report the highest increase, while those in **different household in the same city (45%)** maintain that the interaction has remained the same.

Those living with **sons/daughters (46%)** report the most positive change; as do elders in **non-Metro cities (50%)**, suggesting stronger recent engagement in smaller cities.

Most elders express a clear willingness to engage more with youth, and many perceive that intergenerational interaction has either increased or remained steady over time. However, this sense of connection is uneven—older, dependent, and isolated elders report lower willingness and more decline. In contrast, those who are financially independent, co-reside with immediate family, or live-in non-metro cities report more positive changes. These patterns highlight both the potential and the gaps in fostering deeper, more inclusive youth-elder relationships.

Finally, emotional bonding remains a deeply significant yet often silent dimension of elder–youth relationships. While many elders continue to express love, pride, and joy in their interactions with the younger generation, they also reveal feelings of invisibility, exclusion, and quiet disappointment. Their words offer a candid window into the emotional landscape of ageing—marked by moments of warmth and belonging, but also by a growing sense of emotional distance. The following quotes reflect this duality, capturing the lived experiences of elders as they navigate affection, relevance, and resilience in their ties with youth.

“They don’t always listen, but when they talk to us — it makes the whole day better.” — Elder, Kanpur

“We know they’re busy. But even one story they tell us makes us feel alive.” — Elder, Madurai

“My son had two job offers — I told him to follow his heart. He did, and he’s happy.” — Elder, Kolkata

“They come for money, not for advice. Now we are in second position.” — Elder, Mumbai

“Earlier we used to visit each other with food. Now, no one even greets.” — Elder, Kolkata

8.3. Intergenerational Interaction Score

The Intergenerational Interaction Score provides a composite measure of the frequency, emotional closeness, and variety of shared activities between youth and elders. By capturing both perspectives, this score offers a holistic view of how connected the two generations truly feel—beyond mere co-residence or physical proximity. It reflects the depth and quality of engagement, revealing patterns of inclusion, emotional bonding, and mutual involvement. Analyzing this score across subgroups helps identify where

intergenerational ties are thriving and where gaps persist, guiding targeted efforts to strengthen these relationships.

The **Intergenerational Interaction Score for youth** is a composite score (0–100), derived from six components:

- **Frequency of interaction**
- **Social Interaction Diversity**
- **Digital Engagement Diversity**
- **Financial Engagement Diversity**
- **Daily/Supportive Activities**
- **Emotional Closeness**

Each component was scored using specific formulae and normalized to ensure comparability across different activity types. Please refer to the table specifying the details of these calculations in the Annexure. Exclusions were applied for non-responses to maintain data quality. The final score reflects not just how often youth interact with elders, but how emotionally and practically engaged they are across daily life, technology, and support contexts.

The mean Intergenerational Interaction Score among youth is **48.64**, indicating moderate engagement with elders. However, meaningful variations emerge across subgroups:

Age, SEC, and Gender

Scores are broadly similar across age groups, SEC, and gender, with only minor differences (e.g., **males: 48.88** vs. **females: 48.37**).

Youth from **SEC B (48.81)** score slightly higher than **SEC C (48.38)**, suggesting marginally better interaction among relatively better-off youth.

Occupation

Students (51.7) and **homemakers (52.02)** report the highest interaction, likely due to more time at home.

Scores are lowest among the **unemployed (45.22)** and those in **private sector jobs (47.08)**, where stress and time limitations may restrict engagement.

Household Structure

Youth in **extended (54.56)** and **joint families (53.45)** show significantly higher scores than those in **nuclear families (45.19)**, highlighting the importance of shared living arrangements in fostering intergenerational bonds.

Proximity to Elders

Interaction is highest when youth live **in the same household (51.84)** and drops in **different households in the same city (45.42)** or **different cities/villages (46.8)**.

Relationship with Elders

Scores are highest when elders are **parents (54.7)**, **other relatives (56.7)**, or **family friends (54.15)**, indicating deeper interaction with closer or more familiar relations.

Interaction is still strong with **grandparents (53.35)**, but lower with **neighbours (50.22)**.

City Type

Youth in **Non-Metro cities (51.67)** report higher interaction scores than those in **Metro cities (46.6)**, suggesting that smaller urban contexts may enable more sustained elder engagement.

Like the score for youth, the **Intergenerational Interaction Score for elders** is a composite index (ranging from 0 to 100) designed to measure the depth, frequency, and emotional quality of their engagement with younger people. It brings together six key components that reflect both practical and emotional aspects of elder–youth interaction.

- **Frequency of Interaction**
- **Time Spent with Youth**
- **Social Interaction Diversity**
- **Digital Engagement Diversity**
- **Financial Engagement Diversity**
- **Daily/Supportive Activities**
- **Emotional Closeness**

The final **Intergenerational Interaction Score** is the sum of these six components, after they were scored using specific formulae and normalized to ensure comparability across different activity types. Please refer to the table specifying the details of these calculations in the Annexure. Exclusions were applied for non-responses to maintain data quality. The

The Intergenerational Interaction Score reveals how deeply youth and elders are woven into each other's daily lives—beyond just proximity, it measures the heartbeat of their emotional and everyday connection.

final score offers a holistic view of how engaged elders feel with the younger generation—across routine activities, emotional support, and digital and financial connection.

The Intergenerational Interaction Scores for **youth and elders are closely aligned** at an overall level, with **youth reporting a mean score of 48.64** and **elders slightly lower at 47.36**. However, differences emerge

across subgroups, highlighting generational asymmetries in perception and experience of interaction.

Age

By age, **youth show consistent interaction scores across both the 18–24 and 25–30 age bands**. In contrast, **elder scores decline steadily with advancing age**. Elders **aged 60–70 report a score of 48.29, which drops to 46.18 among those aged 71–80, and further to 43.14 for those above 80**. This indicates that older elders experience a notable decrease in engagement, likely due to reduced mobility, health limitations, or a shift in family dynamics.

Occupation

Occupational status also shapes intergenerational dynamics. **Youth who are students or homemakers report higher scores**, indicating greater availability and family involvement. Similarly, **elders who are homemakers or self-employed** show stronger interaction compared to those never employed or unable to work due to health, who score notably lower. This points to the importance of ongoing roles, even informal, in sustaining intergenerational bonds.

Living arrangements

Living arrangements have a marked impact. **Youth in joint or extended families report the highest interaction scores, while those in nuclear households score considerably lower**. A similar pattern is observed among elders: **those living with their children in joint families score much higher (48.65) compared to elders living alone (36.26) or only with a spouse (39.19) in nuclear families**. These findings underline the role of co-residence in facilitating regular, multidimensional interaction.

Relationship with Youth

The nature of the relationship with the other generation is another strong differentiator. **Youth who interact with their parents or grandparents report significantly higher engagement** than those who connect primarily with neighbours or unrelated co-residents. Elders, too, **feel more engaged when the interaction is with sons, daughters, or close relatives**, as opposed to distant or unrelated individuals, where scores tend to dip below the average.

Proximity to Youth

Proximity to elders or youth also matters. **Those who live in the same household—whether youth or elder—consistently report the highest interaction levels. Scores drop when living in the same city but different households, and further when residing in different cities or villages**. This highlights the importance of daily physical presence in maintaining meaningful intergenerational contact.

City Type

A difference also appears by city type. **Youth and elders living in non-Metro cities** report higher scores compared to those in Metro cities. This may reflect a slower pace of life, greater family cohesion, or more stable household structures in smaller urban centres, all of which support closer intergenerational ties.

Overall, while both youth and elders demonstrate moderate levels of intergenerational interaction, the experience is far from uniform. Elders—particularly the oldest, isolated, less educated, and financially dependent—feel the gaps more acutely. In contrast, youth show greater consistency in interaction, shaped largely by education, family structure, and proximity. These findings suggest that interventions to enhance intergenerational bonding must be sensitive to the differing needs and realities of both age groups.

This section highlights those intergenerational relationships between youth and elders remain largely strong, marked by frequent interaction, shared daily routines, and emotional closeness—especially within joint families and co-residing households. However, elders who are older, financially dependent, or living alone report weaker engagement and lower emotional bonding. While youth show consistent interaction across subgroups, elders experience greater variability shaped by age, health, and living arrangements. The Intergenerational Interaction Scores reflect these patterns, reinforcing that proximity, family ties, and supportive environments are key to sustaining meaningful connections across generations.

9. RESPECT, VALUE AND ROLE OF ELDERS

This section explores how elders perceive their respect, relevance, and role within the family and wider society. It examines the extent to which they feel acknowledged by youth, involved in decision-making, and valued for their contributions—both emotional and practical. The section also introduces the Perceived Respect Index, which provides a composite view of how elders evaluate their standing across personal, familial, and institutional domains. By examining differences across gender, socio-economic class, age, proximity, financial and health status, this section sheds light on which elders feel respected—and which feel sidelined—in a rapidly evolving social landscape.



9.1. Elder Perceived Respect from Youth

This subsection examines how elders perceive the respect they receive from youth—within the family and in society—focusing on their inclusion in decisions and changes over time. Differences across gender, age, SEC, living arrangements, proximity, financial and health status help reveal who feels valued and who feels left out.

Perceived Respect

On exploring respect perceived by elders from different segments of younger people across familial, social, and professional settings it was found that elders feel most respected by **younger members of their family** (59%), followed by **younger members of society in general** (54%) and **younger healthcare providers** (52%). Respect levels are slightly lower when it comes to **younger neighbours** and **service providers** (50% each), and **younger friends** and **community leaders** (49% each).

Conversely, between **14% and 21%** of elders feel **rarely or not at all respected**, with the highest disrespect perceived from **younger neighbours** and **younger friends** (21%). Notably, perceived disrespect is **lowest for younger members of society in general (14%)** and **healthcare providers (16%)**, suggesting relatively higher trust and regard in these broader or professional relationships.

Overall, while elders feel more respected within the family and formal settings, interactions in community and peer contexts show more variability, indicating room for improvement in societal attitudes toward older persons.

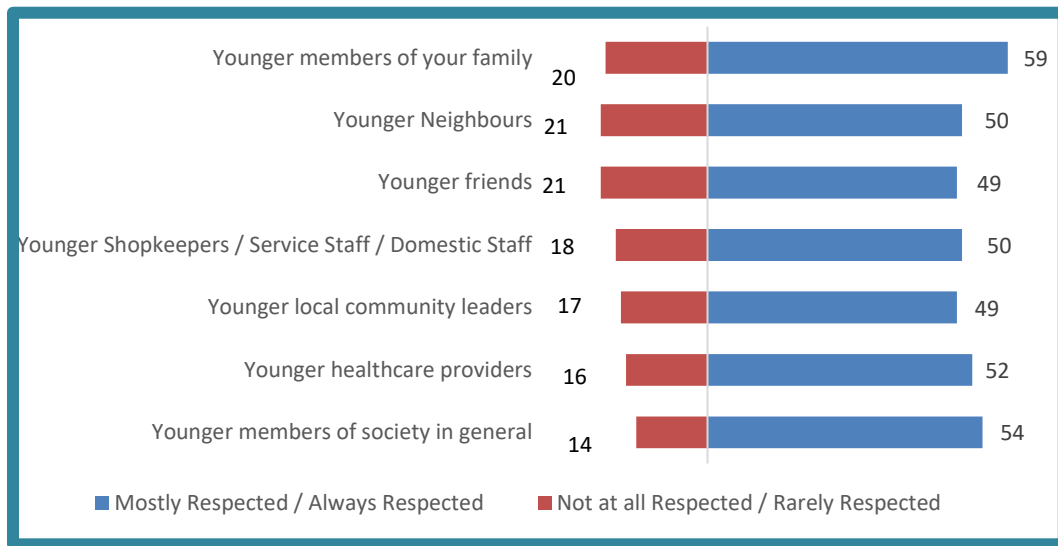


Figure 24: Perceived Respect by Elders from different Segments of Society

The mean scores on a 1–5 scale (1=Not at all Respected, 5= Always Respected) indicate that elders generally perceive moderate respect from younger people across roles, with notable variations by subgroup. Respect is perceived to be **higher among elders aged 80+**, suggesting age-based reverence increases over time. **Elders from SEC B** report greater respect than those from SEC C, highlighting a socioeconomic gradient in intergenerational regard.

Respect is significantly higher among **elders who are physically able (no ADL/IADL limitations)**, and **living spouse and children**, reaffirming the importance of autonomy and co-residence. Those **living alone or only with a spouse** consistently report lower scores across most categories, indicating isolation reducing perceived respect.

Non-Metro elders report higher respect levels than their metro counterparts, suggesting that traditional norms and closer community ties continue to shape attitudes in smaller urban centres.

Overall, respect is perceived to be stronger where proximity, independence, and active family structures are present, while dependence, isolation, and urban anonymity appear to dilute it.

Opinions considered in family decisions

Regarding whether their opinions were considered in family decisions about finances, living arrangements, caregiving, making travel plans, food cooked in the house as per their needs, etc., a large majority of elders—**75%**—report that their opinions are **always (46%)** or **often (29%)** considered in family decisions, indicating strong perceived inclusion in household matters. An additional 19% say they are **sometimes** involved, while only a small minority feel **rarely (4%)** or **never (1%)** consulted. These findings suggest that most elders continue to play an active, respected role in family decision-making, though a small segment may still experience marginalisation or lack of agency.

Most elders feel included in family decisions, especially the younger, financially independent, and those in joint households or non-metro areas.

Mean scores (**4.16 at an overall level**) for elders' involvement in family decision-making (on a 1–5 scale, 1=Never, 5=Always) show clear subgroup differences. **Elders aged 60–70**, from

SEC B households, those who are **financially independent**, and those **living with spouse and children** report higher involvement, typically scoring above 4.2. In contrast, older **elders (80+ years)** and those **living alone, fully dependent** report lower scores, often below 3.8. **Non-metro elders** and those interacting with **sons/daughters** also report significantly higher involvement, reflecting stronger traditional family structures and respect dynamics in these groups.

Change in Perceived Respect and Value over Time

A majority of elders perceive their value in the eyes of youth as either **increasing (42%)** or **remaining the same (40%)**, reflecting stability or improvement in intergenerational regard over time. However, **15% feel their value has decreased**, pointing to a notable segment experiencing a sense of decline in recognition or respect. The low "not sure" response (4%) suggests most elders have a clear view of how their perceived value has evolved.

Perceptions of increased respect from youth vary significantly across subgroups. Elders

Respect tends to grow or stay steady for younger, independent elders living with family, while older, dependent, and isolated elders often feel their recognition fading over time.

aged **60–70**, those with **higher education, financial independence**, and **living with spouse and children or in the same household with youth** are more likely to report increased respect over time. In contrast, elders who are **above 80, fully dependent** or **living alone**,

report lower levels of increased respect and higher levels of decline. Notably, elders in **non-Metro cities** and those interacting with **sons/daughters** perceive stronger improvement. These differences underscore the role of proximity, autonomy, and traditional family structures in shaping perceived respect across generations.

9.2. Value felt in family and society

This subsection explores how elders perceive their worth and relevance within the family and the broader community. It examines whether they feel valued by the younger generation, acknowledged for their contributions, and seen as meaningful members of their households and society. The analysis also highlights differences across demographic and relational subgroups.

Valued by Youth

A large majority of elders—**74%**—feel that the younger generation values their advice and life experience either **always (38%)** or **sometimes (36%)**, indicating strong perceived intergenerational respect. However, **1 in 5 elders (20%)** feel rarely understood, and **3%** feel not valued at all, pointing to a notable minority experiencing emotional disconnect. Only a small number either don't share advice (1%) or are unsure (2%), suggesting that most elders are actively engaged in offering guidance and seek acknowledgment in return.

The mean scores show that elders generally feel their advice is valued by youth (overall average: 4.08 on a 5-point scale), but this perception varies significantly across subgroups.

Elders feel heard—especially when educated, independent, and living with family—though a fifth still sense their wisdom goes unrecognized.

Scores are highest among elders who are **younger (60–70 years)**, **better educated (graduates: 4.56)**, **financially independent (4.17)**, and **engaged in formal employment or pensions from their employers**. Those **living with spouse and children (4.14)** or in **non-Metro cities (4.31)** also feel more acknowledged.

In contrast, perceived value is notably lower among **elders over 80 (3.88)**, **daily wage workers (3.75)**, the **fully dependent (3.87)**, and those **living alone (3.55)**. Elders who interact primarily with **sons/daughters** report higher value (**4.27**), compared to those relating mostly to **grandchildren (3.96)** or **other relatives (3.97)**. Proximity also matters—elders **co-residing with youth (4.21)** feel more respected than those in **separate households within the same city (3.88)**.

These patterns suggest that emotional and social inclusion—reinforced by co-residence, autonomy, and direct family ties—strongly influence elders' sense of being heard and respected.

Relevance to family and community

Elders feel **most useful and relevant to their immediate family and grandchildren or young family members (59%)**, indicating strong intergenerational value within the household. However, perceived relevance drops in the wider social circle—**only 42–44%** feel useful to **neighbours** and **friends**, and even fewer to **local communities (37%)**, **religious/cultural groups (41%)**, and **society at large (39%)**. A notable **one in four elders or more** feel only

slightly or not at all useful across these broader domains, suggesting that while familial roles remain affirming, elders often experience reduced relevance in community and societal contexts.

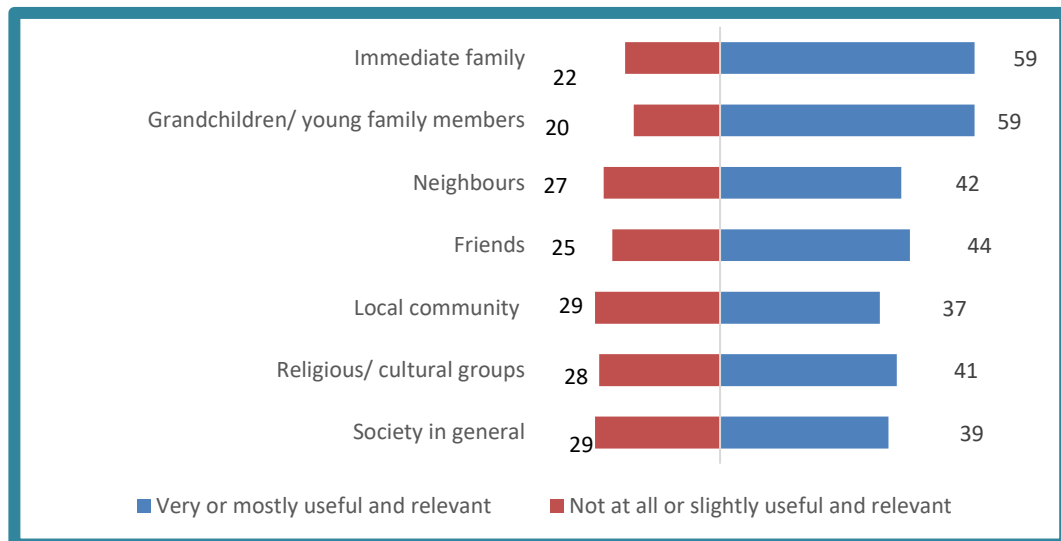


Figure 25: Perceived Usefulness and Relevance by Elders across Family and Society

If we look at mean scores (on a scale of 1-5), significant subgroup differences emerge. **Elders aged 80+**, despite reduced functionality, report **higher scores with family**, possibly reflecting increased caregiving attention or emotional dependence from family. Elders from **SEC B** also report more relevance across all domains, especially in broader societal groups.

Those who are **financially independent**, with **no ADL/IADL limitations**, and **living with spouse and children** or in **joint families**, report higher relevance scores, especially within family. By contrast, **elders living alone**, or with **poor health**, report lower scores—especially in community and cultural contexts.

Regionally, **Non-Metro city elders** feel more relevant across all groups compared to **Metro elders**, highlighting stronger perceived social inclusion in smaller urban contexts.

Overall, perceived usefulness is highest in close familial roles and declines in wider societal domains, especially for isolated, dependent, or less empowered elders.

Contribution to family and community

Elders continue to play meaningful roles within families and communities, with **72% contributing through advice and life experience**—the most common form of engagement. **Half assist with childcare (50%)**, and **47% participate in household work**, reflecting ongoing involvement in daily family life.

Financial contributions (36%) and **emotional support (31%)** also feature prominently, showing that many elders provide both material and psychological support. Fewer engage in **volunteering or community work (19%)** likely due to mobility or health limitations.

Only **7% feel they do not currently contribute**, underscoring that most elders perceive themselves as active, valued contributors within their households or communities.



Figure 26: Elders stated Contributions to Family and Society

Sharing advice and life experience is the most reported form of contribution across all groups (72% overall), but it is even higher among the **educated (up to 82%)**, **retired or home-makers** and those who are **financially independent**. It drops significantly among the **oldest elders (65%)** and those with **poor health or living alone (50%)**.

Helping with childcare is more common among **home-makers (60%)** and those who are **self-employed (65%)**, those with **higher education**, and elders in **joint families**, while it is less frequent among **those aged 80+ (44%)**, those **living alone**, and **daily wage workers (44%)**.

Participation in household work is higher among **females (50%)**, **home-makers (60%)**, and those living in **joint families (53%)**, while it falls among the **very old (27%)**.

Financial contributions are more common among **higher educated elders**, those that are **financially independent and living in joint families**.

Volunteering or community work is notably higher among **retired (26%)** and **self-employed elders (26%)**, those with **higher education**, while **participation drops** among those **80+ (10%)** and **agricultural workers (4%)**.

Emotional support is higher among **those with no formal education (39%), self-employed (38%) and unemployed due to health reasons (40%)**. This may seem counterintuitive at first, but it reflects the nature of their roles within families. Elders with **no formal education** may not contribute significantly through financial or digital means but often serve as

Even without wealth or work, elders become the heart of the home—offering steady emotional anchors where presence speaks louder than provision.

emotional anchors in the household—offering wisdom, moral guidance, and presence, which family members value, especially in culturally rooted settings. Those who are **self-employed** typically have more flexible schedules and spend more time at home, enabling stronger emotional involvement with family. Elders who are **unemployed due to health reasons** may receive care from

family but also contribute emotionally by being present, expressing gratitude, or fostering close bonds during vulnerable times. Their dependence can, paradoxically, deepen emotional reciprocity and closeness within the household. In all three groups, emotional support emerges as a key channel of contribution, especially where physical, financial, or professional participation may be limited.

Finally, **non-contributors** (those who feel they do not contribute) are more likely to be **aged 80+ (17%), fully dependent (14%), or living alone (22%)**, pointing to isolation and reduced self-worth in these segments.

These differences show that elders' contributions are shaped by age, health, financial independence, education, and family structure—highlighting the importance of inclusive family roles and supportive living arrangements in maintaining elders' sense of purpose.

Acknowledgement of contribution by youth

A significant majority of elders—**78%**—feel that their contributions are **always (44%) or sometimes (34%)** acknowledged by youth, reflecting a generally positive perception of intergenerational appreciation. However, **15%** feel **rarely acknowledged**, and **3% not at all**, indicating that nearly 1 in 5 elders experience some level of neglect or invisibility.

Perceived acknowledgement of elders' contributions by youth is notably higher among younger, **more educated elders, particularly those with graduate-level qualifications**, and those who are **financially independent or receive formal income such as salaries or pensions**. Elders in **joint families, those living with spouse and children**, and those **co-residing with youth** feel more recognized, as do **elders residing in non-Metro cities**. In contrast, elders who are **fully dependent, aged 80 and above, unemployed or not working due to poor health, living alone or only with a spouse** report lower levels of perceived acknowledgement. This suggests that proximity, autonomy, and educational status play a key role in shaping intergenerational appreciation.

9.3. Perceived Respect Index

The **Perceived Respect and Value Score** for elders is a composite index (0–100) that combines four key dimensions: perceived respect from youth, voice in family decision-making, valuation of elder advice, and their usefulness to others. Each component is individually scored and normalized—respect is scaled to 35, decision-making and advice to 10 each, and usefulness to 45. Responses marked as zero (i.e., invalid or non-applicable) are excluded from calculations to ensure data accuracy. The final score reflects an elder’s overall sense of dignity, recognition, and role within family and society. Full calculation details are provided in the annexure.

The Perceived Respect Index offers a revealing pulse-check on elder dignity—showing that while many feel moderately valued, respect rises with education, autonomy, and co-residence, but fades with isolation and dependence.

The **overall mean score** on the Perceived Respect and Value Index is **55.16 out of 100**, indicating a **moderate level of perceived value, recognition, and usefulness** among elders. While many feel respected and valued by their families and society, this sense is not universal—certain subgroups experience lower acknowledgment, highlighting disparities shaped by age, health, financial

autonomy, and living arrangements.

Age and Gender

Respect and value **increase with age**, with elders aged **80 years and above scoring the highest (56.08)**. This suggests cultural reverence for older elders may offset declining roles in household activities. **Gender differences are minimal**, though **males (55.60)** report marginally higher scores than **females (54.71)**, potentially reflecting traditional household power dynamics.

Education and Socio-Economic Status (SEC)

Perceived value rises consistently with **education**. Elders with **higher secondary education (56.95)** and **graduates (55.83)** feel most respected, while those with **no formal education (53.97)** feel comparatively less valued. Similarly, elders in **SEC B (55.48)** report greater recognition than those in **SEC C (54.81)**, reaffirming the link between social class and perceived worth.

Occupation and Work Status

Elders who are **employed (55.86)**, **self-employed (55.62)**, or **retired (55.74)** report higher scores than those who are **never employed (53.89)** or **unable to work due to health issues (54.50)**. Notably, **agricultural workers report the highest score (58.58)** among occupations, possibly reflecting strong community identity in rural settings. **Daily wage workers (54.45)** feel the least valued.

Financial Status and Income Sources

Financial independence contributes positively to perceived respect (55.24), while **full financial dependence** results in lower scores (54.63). Among income sources, elders receiving from **rental/interest (56.45)**, **own business or salary (55.72)**, or **employer pensions (55.79)** feel more valued than those relying on **family support (55.02)**.

Living Arrangement and Household Type

Elders **living with spouse and children (55.38)** feel more respected than those **living alone (53.55)** or **with spouse only (53.90)**. This underscores the role of co-residence in affirming elder status. Perceived respect in **nuclear families (55.28)** and **joint families (55.01)** are more or less on the same level.

Proximity and Relationship with Youth

Proximity enhances respect—elders **living in the same household with youth score highest (55.73)**, while those in **separate households in the same city score lower (54.56)**. Respect is also strongly influenced by **relationship type**: **Son/daughter - 56.12**, **Grandchildren - 55.40**, **Neighbours - 53.26** and **Family friends - 54.10**. This highlights the importance of direct kinship in affirming elder value.

City Type

Elders in **Non-Metro cities report significantly higher scores (56.36)** compared to those in **Metro cities (54.51)**. This may be attributed to tighter-knit family structures, slower lifestyles, and greater interdependence in smaller urban centres.

The Perceived Respect and Value Index reveals that while most elders feel moderately valued, this perception is **not equally shared across all segments**. Elders who are **educated, economically independent, functionally healthy, and co-residing with immediate family** report higher respect and value. In contrast, those who are **isolated or financially dependent** tend to feel less acknowledged. These insights emphasize the need for **inclusive family roles, stronger community bonds, and supportive systems** that recognize the evolving contributions and dignity of elders.

In conclusion, the section highlights that while most elders feel respected and valued by younger generations, this perception varies significantly by age, education, financial independence, health, and living arrangements. Older elders, particularly those aged 80 and above, tend to receive higher respect—reflecting enduring cultural reverence for age—even though their participation in decision-making or practical contributions may decline. Elders who are financially independent, functionally able, and co-residing with family report greater inclusion and appreciation. Conversely, those unable to work due to poor health or with no formal education—though less recognised in formal roles—often contribute through strong emotional support,

serving as anchors of care and connection within families. These findings underscore the need to affirm both tangible and intangible contributions of elders and foster inclusive, respectful intergenerational relationships.

10. DIGITAL INCLUSION AND TECHNOLOGY USE

This section explores the digital inclusion of elders, focusing on their access to devices, comfort with technology, and the role of youth in bridging the digital divide. It examines patterns of ownership, usage barriers, and willingness to learn, alongside generational dynamics of support and engagement. By combining quantitative insights with qualitative narratives—of fear, pride, and persistence—it captures how digital technology can both challenge and connect generations. The Digital Inclusion Index offers a composite measure to assess where elders stand and which factors most influence their digital empowerment.



10.1. Elders' Digital comfort and Device Access

Here we delve into elders' access to digital devices, their comfort in using them, and the barriers they face. It also highlights their openness to learning, and draws on personal accounts to reveal the emotions—fear, pride, or confusion—that shape their digital journeys.

Ownership of digital tools and devices

Digital access among elders remains basic and uneven. While **71% use a basic mobile phone**, only **41% have smartphones**, indicating limited access to app-based connectivity. Usage of more advanced tools is low—just **13% use computers, internet, or social media**, and only **5% access online services** like banking or health apps. Notably, **14% of elders do not use any digital tools**, reflecting a significant segment still excluded from the digital ecosystem. These patterns suggest that while mobile ownership is high, true digital engagement remains limited and selective.

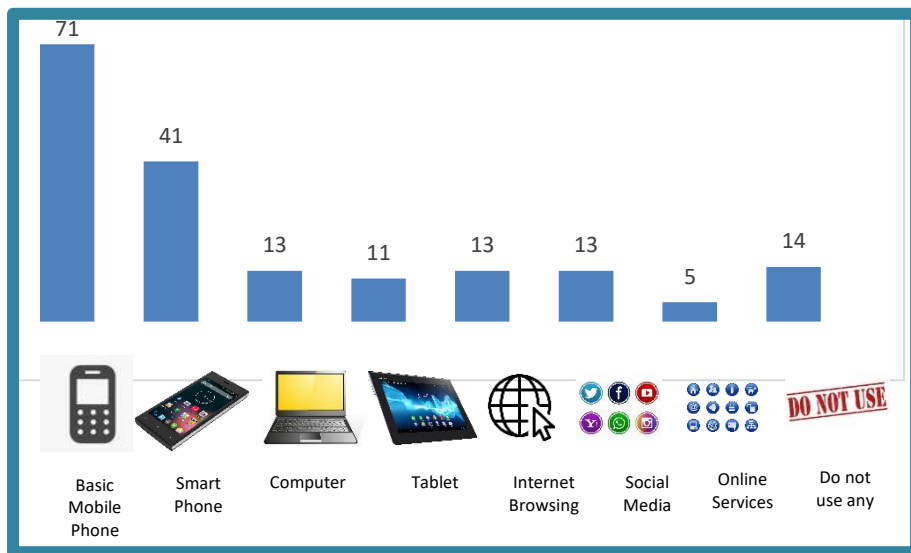


Figure 27: Elders' Access to Digital Devices and Tools

Digital access among elders shows clear patterns of disparity shaped by age, education, financial status, and living arrangements. Younger elders, especially those in their 60s, are more likely to own smartphones and use the internet, while access declines sharply among the oldest. Education plays a major role—graduates are far more digitally connected than those with no formal schooling. Financial independence and co-residence with youth also boost access, as does living in Non-metro cities. In contrast, elders (80+ - 42%), who are dependent, unemployed and with no formal education, remain largely excluded from the digital world, with many relying solely on basic phones or avoiding digital tools altogether.

Comfort levels using them

The graph highlights a steep comfort gap in elders' use of digital tools. While most feel very comfortable making phone calls, confidence drops significantly when it comes to video calls, social media, or browsing the internet—with many reporting only moderate ease or active discomfort. Usage of more transactional tools like online banking or paying utility bills is even lower—not because of discomfort alone, but because nearly half have never attempted these tasks. Overall, while basic communication is familiar terrain, more complex or app-based functions remain underutilized, reflecting a mix of unfamiliarity, hesitation, and lack of exposure.

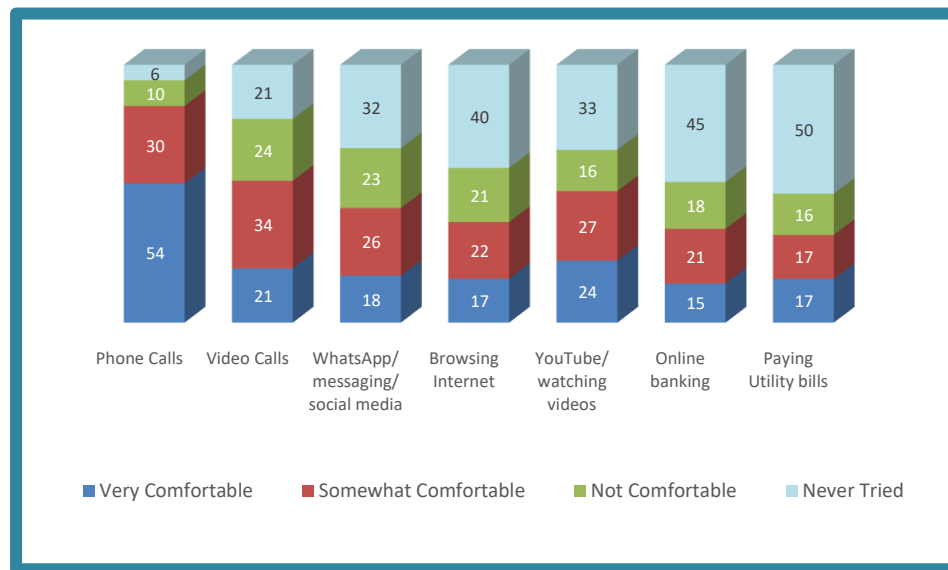


Figure 28: Comfort levels of Elders using Digital Tools

Comfort with digital tools declines notably among elders who are older, less educated, financially dependent, or living alone—indicating that the most marginalized are also the most digitally excluded, with over 60% having never tried many digital tasks. This suggests that structural disadvantages compound digital disengagement. Interestingly, elders in non-metro cities report greater comfort than those in metros, likely due to stronger intergenerational proximity, slower lifestyles, and greater reliance on informal support from family.

Barriers in using digital tools

Elders report a wide range of challenges in adopting digital technology, with complexity and fear of mistakes topping the list. **Two-thirds (66%)** find digital tools too confusing, and over **half (51%)** hesitate due to fear of making errors. A substantial portion (**40%**) **express a lack of interest altogether**, while others point to gaps in support—25% say no one taught them properly, and another **25% cite not owning a smartphone or internet as a barrier**. Cognitive limitations also emerge, with **23% forgetting what they learn** and **20% unable to read English**. Visual and physical issues are less common but still present, including **difficulty reading small text (9%)** and health-related challenges like **limited dexterity (5%)**. **Only 4% of elders feel confident and barrier-free** in their digital use, underscoring the urgent need for simplified interfaces, patient instruction, and inclusive access strategies. **Cognitive limitations as well as visual and physical issues** were higher among the **80+** as well as those with no formal education.

Willingness to learn more

Willingness to learn digital technology among elders is promising, with **42% expressing definite interest** and another **28% saying they might be open to it**. However, nearly **one in five (19%) are not willing to learn**, and **11% remain unsure**—indicating that while a majority are receptive, a significant minority still need encouragement, reassurance, or better

Despite tech fears, forgetfulness, and access gaps, many elders remain open to learning—if guided with patience, simplicity, and support.

access. This suggests a strong foundation for digital inclusion efforts, provided they are patient, supportive, and tailored to individual comfort levels. Again **the very old, uneducated, unemployed, in poor health, daily wage workers and financially dependent on family** were **not willing or were**

unsure if they wanted to learn.

10.2. Youth support in technology

This subsection explores how elders learn to navigate digital tools, with a focus on the role of youth in supporting this transition. It examines the extent and nature of digital assistance provided by younger family members, the challenges elders face in accessing this support, and how such interactions influence intergenerational bonding. By incorporating both elder and youth perspectives—quantitative and qualitative—it sheds light on how digital learning can become a shared space of connection, frustration, or growth, depending on the context and relationship dynamics.

Learning to use digital tools

Children (54%) and **grandchildren (52%)** are the main sources of digital learning for elders, showing the vital role of immediate family in bridging the generational digital divide. **Neighbours (32%)** and **friends (25%)** also provide notable support, reflecting the value of informal community networks. Only **5% learned through NGOs or community volunteers**, and just **1% taught themselves**. **Notably, 14% of elders reported not having learned digital tools at all**, underlining the ongoing need for accessible and empathetic digital guidance.

Support provided by youth – elder and youth perspectives

Both elders and youth report high levels of digital support, with strong alignment in perceptions across key tasks. The most commonly supported area is **using smartphones or apps—mentioned by 73% of youth and 70% of elders**—reflecting the centrality of mobile technology in elder digital use. Assistance with **online forms, bookings, and banking also shows close agreement (50% youth, 49% elders)**, indicating practical support is a major area of youth contribution.

However, differences emerge around communication. While **48% of youth say they help elders with messaging and video calls**, only **38% of elders report this**—suggesting youth

may overestimate their role or elders may not see these interactions as “support.” Similarly, **42% of youth say they share photos or news digitally, compared to 37% of elders**, indicating a slight perception gap in casual sharing.

A small portion of both groups—**15% of youth and 13% of elders**—report **no digital engagement**, suggesting that most families are participating in some form of intergenerational tech interaction. The findings highlight both active involvement and subtle disconnects in how digital help is perceived and remembered across generations.

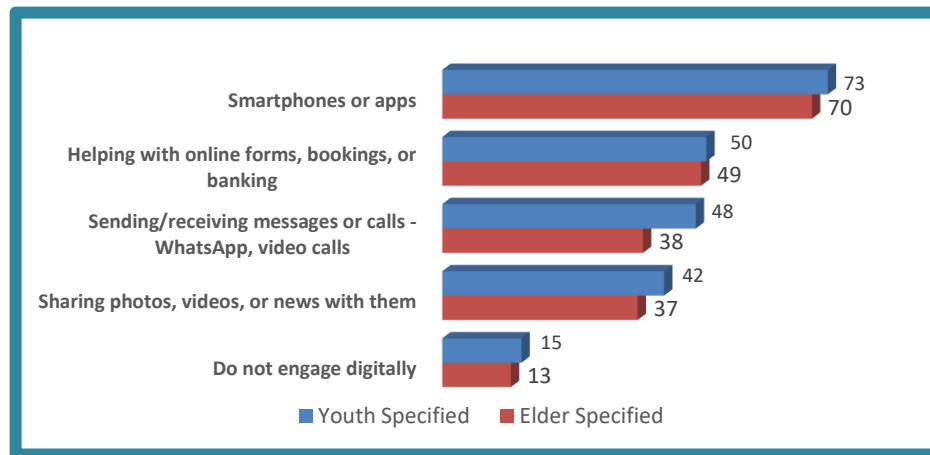


Figure 29: Support from Youth in Digital Technology use – Youth and Elder perspectives

Challenges in getting support from youth – both elder and youth perspectives

The comparison between challenges reported by **youth** and **elders** in digital learning support reveals a striking mismatch in perceptions, reflecting a classic intergenerational communication gap.

Youth overwhelmingly believe that **elders are disinterested (78%)**, **forget instructions (66%)**, or **struggle to understand (65%)**. In contrast, **elders point to the youth's lack of patience (71%)**, **fast or jargon-filled explanations (49%)**, and a **tendency to take over rather than teach (30%)** as major barriers. This suggests that what youth perceive as resistance or slowness is often the result of poor teaching strategies or rushed interactions from their side.

Elders also express emotional hurdles—44% feel embarrassed to ask repeatedly, and **24% fear damaging the device**. This underlines that the digital learning process for elders is not just technical but deeply emotional, requiring empathy and reassurance.

Additionally, **23% of elders say youth assume they cannot learn**, while **only 6% of youth admit holding that belief**. This points to a perception gap that can discourage elders and reinforces feelings of inadequacy.

Interestingly, **device access or infrastructure** is cited by **youth (43%)** rather than elders, suggesting youth may be more aware of these systemic limitations or more reliant on up-to-date tools to offer help.

Challenges Specified by Elders	% Response	Challenges Specified by Youth	% Response
They are too busy or impatient	71	They are not interested or resistant to using technology	78
They explain too fast or use technical terms	49	They forget how to use it and ask repeatedly	66
I feel embarrassed to ask repeatedly	44	They have difficulty understanding instructions	65
They do it for me without teaching	30	Lack of appropriate devices or internet access	43
They assume I cannot learn	23	I don't have enough time or patience	23
I fear making mistakes or spoiling the device	24	Language barrier (e.g., English-only interface)	18
I do not feel confident using digital tools	9	They cannot learn at this age	6
None	7	None	2

Table 4: Challenges cited by Youth and Elders in interacting Digitally

The challenges faced by elders and youth in interacting digitally were also echoed by them during the Focus Group Discussions.

“I have a smartphone. I use WhatsApp, but beyond that, I don’t try.” — Elder, Kolkata

“For online payment I depend on my son... I don’t understand all that.” — Elder, Kanpur

“They won’t teach us, just say ‘we’ll do it for you.’” — Elder, Madurai

“They ask again and again. It’s frustrating. I’ve taught my parents a thousand times but they still forget.” — Youth, Kolkata

“They don’t trust GPay or DigiLocker. They want a paper bill.” — Youth, Mumbai

“They can’t swipe or open the phone. Button phones feel safer to them.” — Youth, Madurai

“We feel proud when they do it for the first time... but angry when they ask again.” — Youth, Kolkata

“It’s like a child... you do something for them and they light up. But you can’t do it every day.” — Youth, Mumbai

“When I have my own things to do and they ask me to explain for the fifth time, I feel bad but I also get angry inside.” — Youth, Madurai

“They don’t listen. If you explain nicely once and they forget, it’s their fault.” — Youth, Kanpur

These views reflect the mixed emotional terrain of digital intergenerational support. Elders express both a willingness to engage and a reliance on youth for digital tasks, but also feel sidelined when they’re not taught or are simply “done for.” Youth, in turn, show a blend of pride, frustration, and fatigue—highlighting the tension between their desire to help and the repetition involved. While some youth feel a sense of joy when elders succeed digitally, many also feel overwhelmed or impatient when elders struggle or resist. The generational gap in digital fluency is not just about skills, but also trust, time, and mutual understanding.

Perception of digital technology use bringing youth and elder closer

A **strong majority of elders—73%**—believe that **digital technology has helped bring them closer to youth, either definitely or to some extent**. This suggests that beyond functional use, digital tools are also seen as vehicles for emotional connection and interaction across generations. **Only a small proportion (15%)** feel that it hasn’t helped much, and **just 6% feel it has created more distance**, indicating that negative effects are limited. This widespread perception of digital bonding potential underscores the importance of inclusive digital practices and patient support from youth to sustain and deepen intergenerational ties.

Digital tools are seen as bridges, not barriers—most elders feel technology draws them closer to youth, especially when supported by family, proximity, and empowerment.

Perceptions of digital technology strengthening elder–youth bonds vary widely across subgroups. **Younger elders, those who are educated, financially independent, and engaged in private sector or salaried work** are more likely to feel that technology has brought them closer to youth. In contrast, **older elders (especially those over 80), those with poor health or with financial dependence**, feel less digitally connected. **Elders who live in the same household with youth and those who interact with sons or daughters** report stronger impact of digital technology on bonding. **Non-Metro city elders** also report higher perceived closeness through digital means than their Metro counterparts.

10.3. Digital Inclusion Index

The **Digital Inclusion Score for Elders** is a composite index (0–100 scale) designed to measure the level of digital access, ability, support, and challenges faced by elders. It combines four components: **device access, comfort in use, learning support, and barriers**.

Each component is scored and normalized individually, and summed to generate the final score. Full calculation details are available in the Annexure.

The overall **Digital Inclusion Index** for elders stands at **50.71**, reflecting a **moderate level of digital access, comfort, learning support, and barrier minimisation**. However, this average mask stark disparities across demographic and socio-economic segments.

Age is a key differentiator, with digital inclusion gradually declining from younger elders (60–70 years: 51.5) to the oldest age group (80+ years: 42.83), indicating that technological engagement is increasingly difficult with advancing age. **Gender** also plays a role, with **men (52.37)** consistently showing higher inclusion than **women (48.99)**, likely due to historical differences in exposure and autonomy.

Elders who are younger, educated, and supported thrive digitally—while the oldest, least educated, and isolated remain on the margins of India's digital journey.

A **clear education gradient** is visible—elders with **graduate-level qualifications score as high as 60.2**, while those with **no formal education fall to 43.37**, highlighting the enabling effect of literacy and learning on digital confidence. **Financial status**

mirrors this pattern: the **financially independent score 53.28**, compared to just **43.21** for those **fully dependent on others**, reflecting how economic autonomy empowers digital participation.

Occupationally, elders still engaged in **private sector jobs (57.74)** or the **self-employed (54.78)** report much higher inclusion than **those unable to work due to health reasons (43.03)** or **daily wage workers (45.59)**, suggesting that employment offers not just income but also exposure to digital tools.

Living arrangements and support structures also shape inclusion: those **living with spouse and children (50.93)** fare far better than those **living alone (46.71)**. Co-residence with youth boosts digital learning opportunities, as does a **nuclear family structure (52.32)** over joint families (49.00). Likewise, proximity matters—elders **living in the same household as youth (51.21)** or even in **other towns but in close contact (51.83)** report better digital experiences than those in **separate households within the same city (49.10)**.

The **source of income** also reveals insight: elders with **employer pensions (57.87)** or **business/salary income (54.64)** are far more digitally included than those **relying on family support (46.00)**.

The nature of youth relationships also influences inclusion. Elders engaging primarily with **sons/daughters (53.96)** show greater digital confidence than those relying on **neighbours (46.24)** or **family friends (46.23)**. Finally, elders in **non-Metro cities (53.14)** fare better than

those in **Metros (49.40)**—possibly due to stronger intergenerational support, less anonymity, and slower-paced environments more conducive to learning.

Overall, digital inclusion is driven by a **convergence of education, financial autonomy, proximity to youth, and supportive relationships**. Conversely, elders who are **older, less educated, financially or physically dependent, or socially isolated** remain at the margins of India's digital journey.

In conclusion, while digital inclusion among elders remains moderate overall, it reveals a deeply uneven landscape shaped by age, education, financial independence, and social proximity. Many elders still rely on basic mobile phones, and fewer than half use smartphones or internet-based services—indicating that meaningful digital participation remains limited. Despite these challenges, a large number express willingness to learn, particularly those who are younger, better educated, and financially secure. Youth play a vital role in enabling digital access, but mismatched expectations and communication gaps often create frustration on both sides.

The Digital Inclusion Index highlights these disparities, showing that elders who are co-residing with family, especially sons or daughters, fare significantly better. Conversely, those who are older, dependent, isolated, or living alone are consistently less included. Nonetheless, elders widely acknowledge that digital technology has the potential to bring them closer to younger generations. With empathetic support and targeted interventions, this potential can be fully realised—turning digital tools into bridges rather than barriers across generations.

11. FINANCIAL AND HEALTH INCLUSION

This section delves into two critical dimensions of ageing—**financial security and health support**—that shape elders’ sense of dignity, autonomy, and wellbeing. It explores how financially independent elders differ from those reliant on others, and examines the roles youth play in supporting them. Health-wise, the focus spans self-perceived wellness, disease prevalence, caregiving for daily needs, and access to medical care. By integrating quantitative data and elder perspectives, the section offers a comprehensive look at the realities of ageing in India. The **Support Need Index** ties together these insights, revealing the breadth of assistance elders need and how well youth perceptions align with those needs.



11.1. Elders’ Financial independence and dependency

This subsection examines the financial standing of elders—whether they are self-reliant or dependent on others—and the implications this has for their dignity and day-to-day life. It explores not only current dependency levels but also the support elders receive and expect from youth, contrasting these with youth perspectives. By analyzing differences across gender, age, socio-economic class, education, living arrangements, income sources, proximity to youth, and health status, this section uncovers which groups enjoy greater financial autonomy and where vulnerabilities persist.

Financial Dependency status

Nearly half (**45%**) of elders report being **financially independent**, while a significant proportion—**38%**—are **partially dependent** on family or others. A smaller but notable group (**15%**) is **fully dependent**, indicating a continued need for family-based or external support. These figures suggest that while a majority retain some financial agency, a substantial number still rely on others, underscoring the importance of social safety nets,

While many elders manage their own finances, age, health, and household roles still leave a large segment leaning on others for economic support.

pensions, and inclusive income opportunities for elders.

Significant subgroup differences in elder financial dependency reveal clear patterns. Financial independence is **highest among males, younger elders, those with higher education (especially graduates), and those employed in private or self-owned businesses**. In contrast, full dependency is more common among **older elders (80+), women, those with no formal education**, as well as those **unemployed due to health reasons**. Living arrangements also matter—those **in joint families** report higher dependence. These

disparities highlight how age, gender, education, occupation and household structure shape elders' economic autonomy.

Support received and expected from Youth – Youth and Elder perspectives

The data reveals a high level of youth involvement in supporting elders with financial matters, though perceptions differ notably between elders and youth. Elders report significantly more help than youth acknowledge—especially for **ATM withdrawals (55% vs. 23%), health insurance or related matters (40% vs. 18%),** and **utility bill payments (26% vs. 11%).** This suggests that youth may under-recognize the extent of their assistance, particularly for routine or informal financial tasks.

Conversely, youth report higher involvement in **guiding financial decisions (14%)** than elders acknowledge, pointing to either occasional but memorable support or overstatement by youth. **One-third of youth (29%)** say they **provide no financial support,** contrasting sharply with **only 6% of elders who say they receive none**—indicating a significant perception gap. Overall, while elders feel supported, youth may underestimate their caregiving role, highlighting the need for better intergenerational communication around financial assistance.

Both elders and youth agree on a substantial level of financial assistance being provided by youth. Around one-third of youth (34%) report giving **partial financial support,** a figure closely mirrored by elder (25%), indicating general alignment on ongoing assistance for everyday needs.

However, when it comes to **complete financial dependence,** the perspectives diverge more—**25% of youth** state they fully support their elders, while only **17% of elders** acknowledge receiving full financial help. This gap may reflect elders' reluctance to admit dependence or youth's broader definition of support.

Similarly, **providing pocket money or covering small expenses** is noted by both groups at **25%,** suggesting that even where full support isn't needed, many elders still rely on youth for minor financial help—highlighting the role of youth in ensuring day-to-day financial comfort for elders.

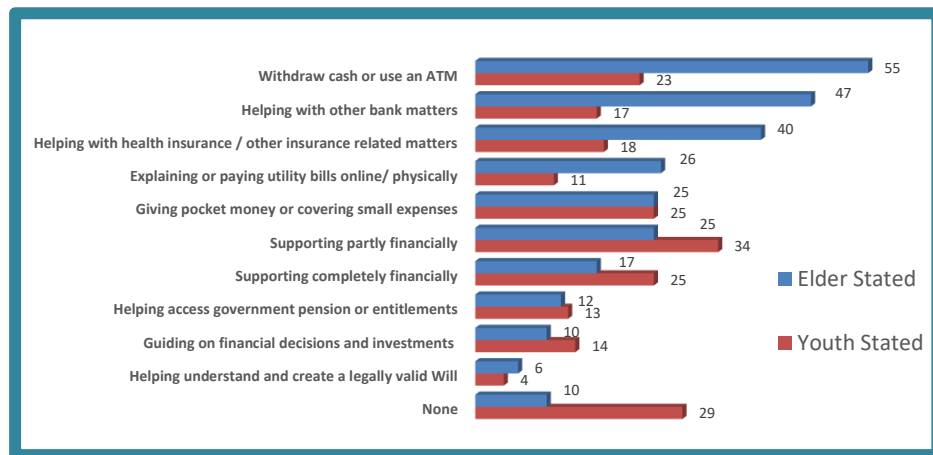


Figure 30: Financial Support Received by Elders from Youth – Youth Stated and Elder Stated

The youth tend to perceive their **expected financial role** as larger than elders report desiring. For instance:

Helping with pensions, documents, or subsidies is highly valued by both groups, but **77% of youth** report this as an expectation, compared to **69% of elders**, indicating strong alignment with a slight overestimation by youth.

For **supporting small income-generating work**, youth again report higher expectations (**57%**) than elders (**48%**), possibly reflecting their proactive outlook on elder independence.

The biggest gap appears in **giving small financial help if possible**—**63% of youth** cite this as an expectation, while only **38% of elders** report it. This may reflect youth overestimating elders' need or elders underreporting dependence.

There is also a **notable perception gap** regarding **assisting with bank accounts or digital payments** with **45% of youth** reporting that elders expect this kind of support, whereas only **17% of elders** themselves state this need. This **28-point gap** suggests that youth may **overestimate elders' dependence** on them for handling digital financial tasks, or elders may **underreport their need** due to hesitation, pride, or lack of awareness. It also indicates that **digital financial literacy** may be an area where elders struggle silently or rely on informal coping mechanisms without explicitly seeking help. This reinforces the need for **patient, trust-building support** that encourages elders to express such needs more openly.

Conversely, elders (18%) are slightly more likely than youth (5%) to expect **teaching basic financial literacy**, suggesting that youth may not fully recognize this need.

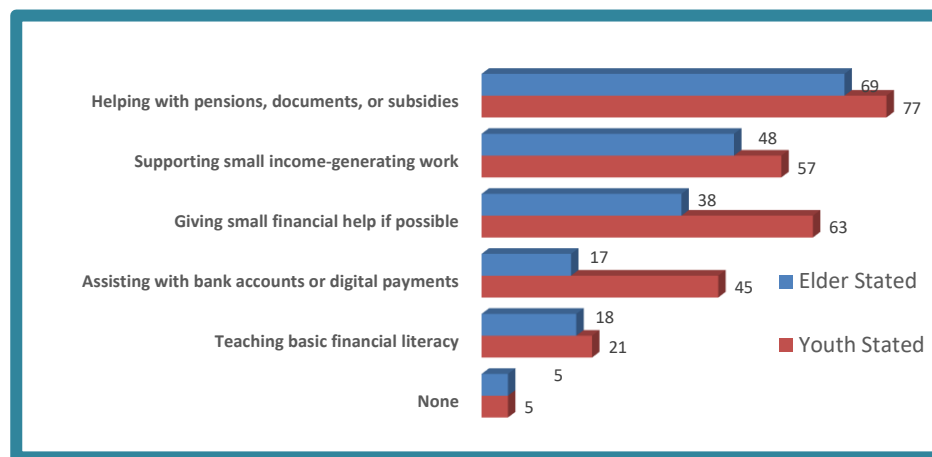


Figure 31: Financial Support Expectations from Youth – Elder and Youth Stated

Overall, while both groups acknowledge key areas of financial support, youth consistently perceive a higher level of expected contribution—indicating both care and a possible misalignment in perceived needs.

During the FGDs the elders also exposed some underlying financial vulnerabilities and emotional trade-offs that many elders experience—especially those without steady income, savings, or pension support.

“Pension is not enough to manage all expenses. I have to ask my son for money, and that doesn’t feel good.” — Elder, Kanpur

This reflects the emotional strain of financial dependence, even when elders are entitled to some pension support.

“I used to earn earlier, now everything depends on my children. It’s not that they refuse, but I feel I’ve lost control.” — Elder, Chennai

This highlights the sense of loss of autonomy that accompanies financial dependency.

“I have some savings, but I worry it won’t last. Medical bills can come anytime.” — Elder, Mumbai

This quote captures insecurity and anxiety related to financial planning and health expenses in later life.

“My daughter helps me with my banking. But I feel shy asking again and again.” — Elder, Kolkata

This shows both reliance and discomfort in seeking digital financial help from younger family members.

11.2. Health status and caregiving support

Here we explore the health and caregiving landscape for elders, drawing on their self-assessed well-being, disease prevalence, medical access, and levels of support received for daily and instrumental activities. It also contrasts youth and elder perspectives on expected caregiving support, while analyzing differences across key demographic and social variables. Through both data and qualitative insights, it captures how health status shapes elders' care needs—and how family structures, proximity, and resources influence whether those needs are met with dignity or neglect.

Elder self-assessed health status

A majority of elders (57%) rated their health as either **good (39%)** or **excellent (18%)**, suggesting that over half perceive themselves to be in relatively positive health. However, **43%** described their health as **fair (26%)**, **poor (15%)**, or **very poor (2%)**, highlighting a significant segment that may require more sustained medical or caregiving support. These self-assessments reflect both the diversity of health experiences in old age and the importance of tailoring health interventions based on perceived well-being.

The overall mean self-assessed health score among elders is **3.57** on a 5-point scale (1=Very Poor, 5=Excellent), indicating a general perception of health between **fair and good**. However, there are notable subgroup differences:

Age is a major factor: scores decline significantly with age—from **3.73** among those 60–70 to just **2.70** among those 80+, highlighting increasing health challenges with advancing years.

Elders feel reasonably healthy—but age, education, and who they live with often tip the scale between thriving and just surviving.

education average **3.27**.

Education strongly correlates with better perceived health; graduates score over **4.08**, while elders with no formal

Financial independence and **employment status** (especially in the private sector or self-employed) are linked with better health ratings. In contrast, those unable to work due to health reasons report the lowest average score (**2.67**).

Living arrangements also influence perception: elders living alone report poorer health (**3.13**) compared to those living with others.

Geographically, **Non-Metro city elders** rate their health highest (**3.92**), while **Metro city residents** report lower averages (**3.38**), possibly reflecting stress or lifestyle disparities.

Proximity to youth and **closer familial relationships** (particularly with children) also appear to boost health perceptions, pointing to the importance of support and emotional well-being.

In sum, better health ratings are consistently associated with **younger age, education, financial stability, and supportive living environments**.

Elder specified disease prevalence

The most frequently reported health issue among elders is **mobility problems (74%)** and **chronic pain** (back, joints, etc.) at **73%**, followed by **high blood pressure (47%)**, **vision problems (44%)**, and **diabetes (38%)**. These findings highlight the dominance of musculoskeletal and chronic lifestyle conditions in older age.

Hearing loss affects **27%**, while **memory issues or forgetfulness** are reported by **20%**, pointing to cognitive and sensory declines. **Heart-related conditions (19%)** and **respiratory problems (17%)** also reflect age-related deterioration in cardiovascular and pulmonary health. Notably, **depression or loneliness** was reported by **8%**, indicating a smaller but important mental health burden.

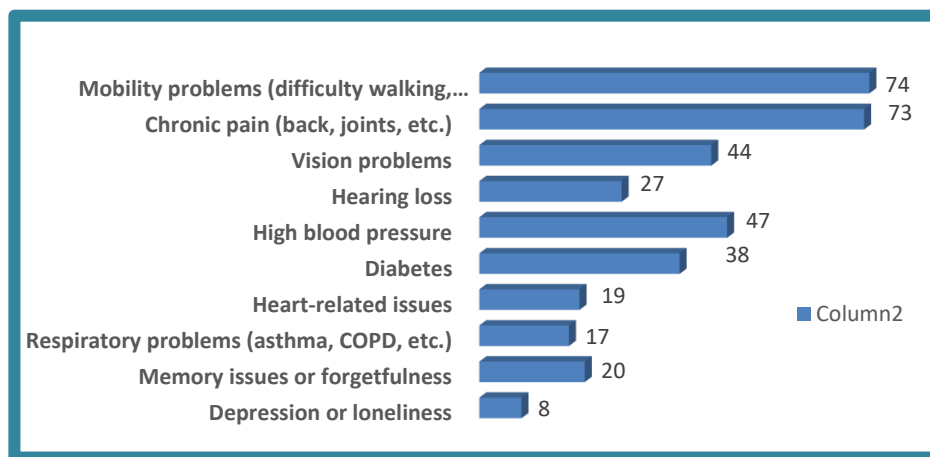


Figure 32: Elder Stated Health Issues

These insights underscore the need for comprehensive elder care strategies that go beyond physical illness to include sensory, cognitive, and emotional well-being.

Elder specified medical consultations / visit

Government hospitals or clinics are the primary source of medical consultation for elders, accessed by a substantial **82%**—indicating the dominant role of public healthcare in elder care. **Private hospitals/clinics** follow at **48%**, and **local doctors** at **42%**, suggesting that nearly half of the elders rely on paid or semi-formal care.

Alternative and outreach services are less commonly used: only **17%** consult **AYUSH or traditional medicine practitioners**, **14%** receive **home visits by healthcare workers**, and **13%** access **mobile health clinics or camps**.

Notably, only **5%** report using **geriatric care facilities**, highlighting a significant gap in age-specific institutional care. A very small fraction (**1%**) say they **don't seek medical care regularly**, suggesting high overall engagement with the healthcare system—though this may also reflect limited access to age-appropriate or home-based services rather than consistent preventive care.

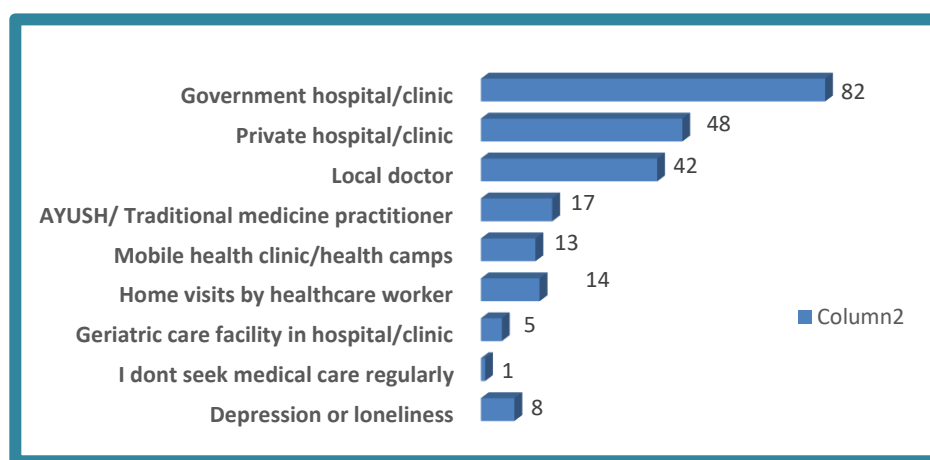


Figure 33: Medical Facilities availed of by Elders as stated by them

There were no notable differences in this access across gender, age or SEC, though those in non-Metros accessed more private medical and alternative medical care. Smaller cities may have a lower access to government healthcare facilities and a higher prevalence of Traditional medicine practitioners.

Elder specified support need for Activities of Daily Living (ADL) and Instrumental Activities of Daily Living (IADL)

Significant number of elders report needing assistance with both **Activities of Daily Living (ADLs)** and **Instrumental Activities of Daily Living (IADLs)**, underscoring the intensity of care many require. Among ADLs, nearly **half need help with mobility inside the home (46%)** and **getting in and out of bed (47%)**, while around **42% require support for bathing, personal hygiene, or using the toilet**. Even eating assistance is needed by **39%**—pointing to physical frailty in a considerable portion of the elderly population.

Support needs are even higher for IADLs, which involve complex tasks: **74% need help with transportation**, **70% with managing money**, **69% with using phones or mobile apps**, and **64–69% with cooking, cleaning, shopping, and taking medicines**. These figures highlight

those functional limitations **extend beyond physical care to daily household and financial responsibilities**, requiring sustained family or community support to enable safe, independent elder living.

Activities of Daily Living	% Require Assistance - Always or Sometimes	Instrumental Activities of Daily Living	% Require Assistance - Always or Sometimes
Help With Bathing Or Personal Hygiene	42	Help With Cooking Or Preparing Meals	64
Help With Dressing And Grooming	38	Assistance With Shopping For Groceries Or Medicines	66
Assistance With Using The Toilet	42	Help With Managing Money Or Paying Bills	70
Help With Getting In And Out Of Bed Or A Chair	47	Help With Taking Medicines On Time	64
Help With Eating Or Feeding	39	Assistance With Using The Phone Or Mobile Apps	69
Assistance With Mobility Inside The Home	46	Help With Transportation To Markets, Doctors, Or Other Places	74
		Help With House Cleaning Or Laundry	69

Table 5: Elder Specified Requirement of Assistance for ADL and IADL

Expected Support for health and wellbeing of Elders – Youth and Elder views

Both **elders and youth** express **strong alignment on physical health support expectations**—**81% of elders** and **82% of youth** state that youth should **take elders to doctors or health camps**, and **65%** from both groups mention **helping with medication reminders or home-based care**.

However, promoting healthy habits like **walking or eating well** is acknowledged by a higher **63% of youth**, as compared to **57% of elders**, reflecting differences in how health promotion is perceived across generations.

The **expectation gap is also wide in emotional caregiving**. While **48% of youth** say they should **listen to elders' emotional concerns**, only **42% of elders** report expecting this. Here **youth awareness exceeds elder expectations**—possibly reflecting increasing sensitivity among youth to mental health and emotional needs.

This mismatch becomes particularly relevant in light of elder-reported health issues: **8% of elders report depression or loneliness**, and **20% cite memory issues or forgetfulness**. These numbers, though not high, indicate that a **vulnerable subgroup exists whose emotional wellbeing requires active support**. Youth recognition of emotional caregiving is encouraging, but it must be consistently translated into empathetic practice.

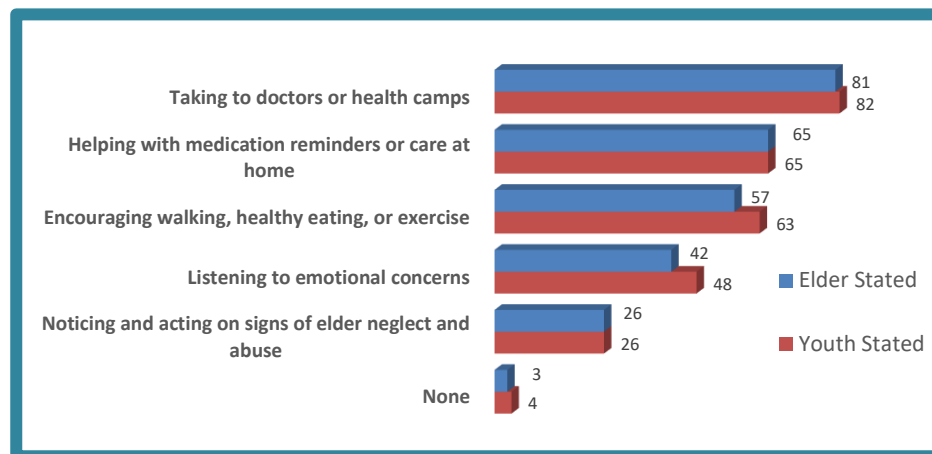


Figure 34: Expectations of Health-related Support from Youth – Elder and Youth stated

Higher percentages of **students** and those **living in joint families** and **non-Metros** have specified the need for **providing emotional care as well as providing advice on healthy living**. This is probably because **students and youth in joint families** likely have **more time, proximity, and emotional involvement** with elders. Youth in **Non-Metros** are often embedded in more **traditional family structures**, where intergenerational care is culturally reinforced, explaining the higher emphasis on emotional and preventive health support.

Among elders, higher percentages of **uneducated elders, home-makers and those living in joint families** expected health related support across all parameters. **Home-makers and uneducated elders**—often with limited financial independence or external engagements—tend to rely more on family for health-related decisions and emotional care. Similarly, **elders in joint families** may expect more support due to the larger household network, where caregiving roles are more diffusely shared and culturally expected.

In summary, while youth and elders agree on **practical care**, emotional support remains a more complex space. **Bridging this emotional gap** will be critical to strengthening intergenerational relationships and addressing the rising concerns of **mental and cognitive health among India's ageing population**.

Focus Group Discussions also revealed similar expectations from youth in the area of health support.

“When I’m sick, I don’t want to ask for help. But I have no choice.” — Elder Kolkata & Mumbai

Reveals the tension between needing support and the desire to retain dignity.

“Don’t just take us to the doctor. Talk to us. Hug us.” — Elder Mumbai

A powerful reminder that emotional care is as vital as physical healthcare.

“I took my grandfather for his check-up. He doesn’t like to ask, but he needs help.” — Youth, Mumbai

Acknowledges the elders’ reluctance to seek help even when they need it.

“We can help with their yoga, walks, even laughter clubs.” — Youth, Kolkata

Indicates a willingness to support preventive and wellbeing practices.

“We need to tell them how to eat healthy and stay active.” — Youth, Kanpur

Highlights youth perception of playing an advisory or guiding role in elder health.

11.3. Support Need and Expectations Index – Elder and Youth

The **Support Need and Expectations Score – Elder** is a composite index designed to quantify the level and type of support that elders need and expect across key domains of their wellbeing. It uses eight components, each individually scored and normalized, to generate a cumulative score out of 100. Here’s how it works:

1. **Health Status (0–10):** Based on self-assessed health, with poorer health translating to higher support need.
2. **ADL/IADL Dependency (Two parts, 0–20 each):** Measures dependence in daily (ADL) and instrumental (IADL) activities. Higher dependency scores indicate greater need.
3. **Expected Economic Support (0–15):** Captures elders’ expectations of financial assistance.
4. **Expected Health/Emotional Support (0–10):** Reflects the emotional and caregiving support elders hope to receive.
5. **Intergenerational Effort Expectation (0–5 each):** Gauges expectations from youth in both general and health-related help.
6. **Qualities Appreciated in Youth (0–10):** Measures elders’ perception of positive traits in youth, relevant to caregiving.

7. **Belief in Adaptability** (0–5): Reflects whether elders feel they or youth can adjust to meet each other's needs.

Excluded responses are accounted for to ensure accuracy. Full computation methods are available in the Annexure. The final score indicates the breadth and depth of an elder's support needs—spanning health, emotional, financial, and intergenerational domains.

The **Support Need and Expectations Score for Elders** (mean score: **42.92**) reflects moderate perceived dependency and expectations across health, economic, and intergenerational domains. However, significant subgroup differences reveal the factors shaping this need:

Age: Scores rise notably with age, peaking at **48.85** among elders aged 80+, driven by increasing health issues and dependency.

Education: Surprisingly, elders with **no formal education** report higher support expectations (**47.42**) than educated groups, possibly due to lower confidence and digital or economic literacy.

Occupation: Elders **unable to work due to health reasons** report the highest scores (**51.75**), as do **retirees** (**45.09**), reflecting heightened need for care and assistance. In contrast, those **currently working in the private sector** have lower support needs (**35.39**), possibly due to continued income and activity.

Financial Status: **Fully dependent elders** score highest (**46.75**) vs. financially independent elders (**41.3**), showing a clear link between economic reliance and expectations from family.

Living Arrangement: Those **living alone** have the lowest scores (**35.77**), indicating either lower expectations or possible social withdrawal. **Joint families** show higher scores (**45.47**), possibly because elders feel more entitled to or reliant on support.

Health Status: Elders needing support with **ADL** (**48.61**) and **IADL** (**44.85**) report significantly higher expectations, reinforcing how physical limitations amplify dependency.

Proximity & Relationship: Elders **living with youth** (**44.6**) and interacting with closely related (e.g., **grandchildren**: **43.73**) report higher scores than those more distantly connected (e.g., **neighbours**: **42.94**), showing that proximity increases both dependency and expectation.

City Type: Elders in **Non-Metro cities** report higher needs (**44.64**) than those in **Metro cities** (**41.99**)—perhaps due to better awareness or differences in family structure and cost of care.

Overall, support expectations rise with **age, dependency, poor health status, financial vulnerability, and co-residence**, emphasizing the importance of tailored care strategies for the most at-risk elders.

The **Support Need and Expectations Score – Youth** is also a composite index (0–100 scale) that captures the types and intensity of support youth believe they should provide to elders, along with their perceptions of elders’ openness, effort, and adaptability. It includes six components:

1. **Economic Support (0–20)**: Measures youth's willingness to offer financial help, based on responses to 6 items.
2. **Health & Emotional Support (0–20)**: Captures support provided for medical care, reminders, emotional concerns, etc.
3. **Expectations from Elders – Openness & Effort (0–10 and 0–10)**: Two sets of items assess how much youth expect elders to show willingness and effort in staying engaged and learning.
4. **Appreciation of Elder Qualities (0–20)**: Reflects youth acknowledgment of elders’ wisdom, patience, resilience, and emotional value.
5. **Belief in Elder Adaptability (0–20)**: Based on whether youth believe elders can change or learn—scored highest if they strongly agree.

Responses marked for exclusion (e.g., "Don't Know") are removed for calculation accuracy. The final score reflects how strongly youth feel about supporting elders and what they expect in return—helping to map intergenerational support dynamics.

The **Support Need and Expectations Score for Youth** stands at a moderate overall mean of **51.15**, closely aligned with the **elder mean score of 42.92**. While elders express their needs based on lived dependence, youth frame their scores around perceptions, responsibility, and willingness to help. The data reveals striking subgroup contrasts:

Age and Gender:

Youth aged **18–24** (51.77) and **25–30** (50.42) shows similar expectations, indicating a consistent attitude across youth segments.

Gender differences are negligible, with males (51.42) and females (50.84) almost equally aligned.

Education:

Youth with **Post-graduate (56.03)** and **Secondary-level (55.78)** education have higher scores—possibly due to increased awareness or exposure to caregiving values.

Those with **no formal education (47.37)** or only up to **Diploma/Graduate (48.79)** score lower, possibly due to economic or capability constraints.

Occupation:

Students (54.30) and **homemakers (54.55)** score higher, likely due to more time and emotional bandwidth to engage with elders.

Unemployed youth (45.94) have the lowest scores, perhaps reflecting stress or disengagement.

Self-employed youth (54.1) report higher expectations, potentially tied to more flexible schedules and family-based work life.

When it comes to support, elders express their needs—and youth step up with expectation, empathy, and effort, but not always in sync.

Relationship with Elders:

Stronger emotional bonds yield higher scores:

Youth in contact with **family friends (63.35)**, **other relatives (59.26)**, or **neighbours (57.78)** report **greater readiness to support** than even those with parents (54.13) or grandparents (53.73).

This may reflect a more communal view of elder care beyond kinship.

Household Structure and Proximity:

Joint (53.87) and **Extended (58.95)** family youth show higher responsibility than those in **nuclear households (48.89)**.

Youth **co-residing with elders (53.05)** show greater involvement than those in separate households or different cities.

City Types

Youth in **Non-Metro cities (53.7)** display greater support than those in **Metro cities (49.43)**, consistent with elder findings—suggesting deeper family or social ties outside high-pressure metros.

Youth expectations align broadly with elder needs, but with distinct gaps across occupations, and family structures. While urban pressures may reduce involvement in metros, joint families, smaller towns, and student populations demonstrate stronger

intergenerational solidarity. These findings highlight the importance of family environment, education, and city context in shaping youth perceptions of elder support.

This section highlights how ageing in India is shaped by both financial dependency and health-related vulnerabilities. While 45% of elders report financial independence, a significant share remains partially or fully dependent—especially older adults, women, and those without formal education. Health concerns are widespread, with high levels of chronic pain, mobility issues, and assistance needed for daily and instrumental activities.

Youth play a key caregiving role, but gaps exist between what elders need and what youth perceive. Elders often understate emotional and financial dependence, while youth may overestimate their expected role—particularly in digital or routine tasks. Still, both groups express alignment in core areas like doctor visits and medication reminders.

Support Need and Expectations Scores—42.92 for elders and 51.15 for youth—show broad convergence but highlight deeper needs among isolated, uneducated, or dependent elders. Youth in joint families, smaller cities, or students tend to report stronger engagement.

To ensure dignity in later life, India must strengthen financial and healthcare safety nets while fostering intergenerational empathy and communication.

12. CHALLENGES IN INTERGENERATIONAL COMMUNICATIONS

This section delves into the frictions and disconnects that often surface in conversations between elders and youth, shedding light on how generational differences shape communication patterns. It contrasts how each group perceives barriers—whether emotional, attitudinal, or technological—and explores comfort levels across topics ranging from health to life advice. The analysis identifies top reasons for communication gaps, qualities that could bridge them, and suggestions for improving intergenerational understanding. It also presents a Generational Gap Perception Index to quantify these challenges and draws on lived experiences to bring out the emotional nuance of feeling misunderstood, unheard, or out of sync across generations.



12.1. Communication barriers – Youth and Elder views

This subsection focuses on specific barriers that hinder open communication between elders and youth—ranging from topic discomfort to perceived generational divides. It also highlights the qualities and actions both groups believe can improve connection, with patterns explored across key demographic and relational factors.

Interaction Barriers – Elder and Youth specified

There is a strong alignment between elders and youth on key barriers to intergenerational interaction, with the top reason cited by both being that **“youth have busy schedules” (76% elders, 74% youth)**. Both groups also agree that the **other party lacks interest in interacting (40% elders vs. 39% youth)**.

However, youth are more likely to cite **communication gaps (30% vs. 28%)** and judgment from elders (25% vs. 22%)—indicating that youth may feel more criticised or misunderstood in these exchanges. They also specify the **absence of common interests or topics (43% youth vs. 40% elders)**, suggesting that generational disconnect stems more from lifestyle differences than unwillingness.

Only about **10% youth and elders** specified that there **were no barriers**. Overall, while both groups recognize time constraints and interest gaps, youth seem more sensitive to emotional and conversational friction, whereas elders highlight distance and discomfort.

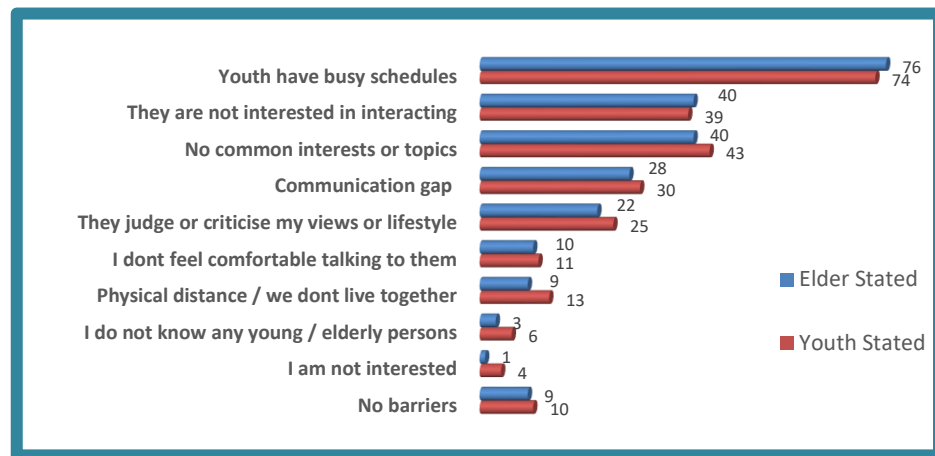


Figure 35: Barriers to Intergenerational Interaction – Elder and Youth perspectives

More elders aged 80+ report **fewer common interests**, while **younger elders (60–70 years)** report more frustration with **youth being busy** and **less interested**, suggesting greater expectations of interaction.

Highly educated elders (graduates and above) report **more difficulty with shared interests** and **communication gaps**, reflecting exposure to modern discourse but limited emotional closeness.

Elders **unable to work due to health reasons** and the **fully dependent** report **greater judgment from youth** and higher discomfort in approaching them. Elders needing help with **daily tasks** report significantly more barriers in communication, shared topics, and emotional comfort—likely due to increased dependency and lowered self-esteem.

Elders in **Metro cities** report **more communication gaps**, while those in **non-Metro cities** report **lower barriers**—suggesting traditional values and slower pace foster better intergenerational connection.

More educated youth (especially post-graduates) report **lower barriers overall** but **higher perception of communication gaps**, suggesting greater awareness but also sensitivity to generational misalignment. **Unemployed youth** report higher **emotional discomfort** in interacting with elders.

Students most frequently cite **elders being disinterested (44%)** and **lack of shared interests (51%)**, possibly due to wider digital–generational gaps. Youth **living in the same household** and in **joint families** report **higher barriers in the areas of communication gap, lack of interest and criticism of lifestyle**.

Metro youth report **higher communication gaps**, indicating urban pressures and changing family dynamics, while more **non-Metro youth** cite **lack of interest from elders**.

Comfort level discussing various issues/ topics

Mean comfort scores (1 = Not Comfortable, 3 = Very Comfortable) for youth and elder conversations across four personal topics were calculated. The scores show **modest comfort levels overall**, with no major divergences between elder and youth responses, but some subtle nuances:

Life Advice (Values, Habits, Decision-making)

Youth (2.32) report slightly more comfort than **elders (2.24)** in discussing life guidance. This suggests that youth are fairly open to receiving life advice, while elders may perceive a slightly lower receptivity or feel less comfortable offering it.

Career or Education Plans

Comfort is **lowest** across all topics, with elders at **1.89** and youth at **2.00**. Both groups feel less at ease here, possibly due to generational gaps in understanding contemporary career choices or elders' perceived lack of updated knowledge.

Friendships, Relationships, or Love

Comfort levels are similarly moderate: elders at **2.05** and youth at **2.08**. The closeness in scores indicates mutual hesitancy but not strong discomfort—this could be a topic broached occasionally, depending on relationship dynamics.

Mental Health, Emotions, or Stress

Both groups report identical comfort (**2.08**), showing a slight improvement in willingness to discuss emotional and mental health topics. This marks an encouraging trend toward emotional openness and breaking taboos, especially with younger generations acknowledging mental well-being.

While none of the topics score near full comfort (3), scores around **2.0–2.3** suggest a **"somewhat comfortable" zone**—indicating openness with room for growth. The **greatest ease is around life advice**, while **career discussions remain the most awkward**. Emotional topics like stress and relationships fall in between, reflecting a generational shift toward greater empathy and engagement.

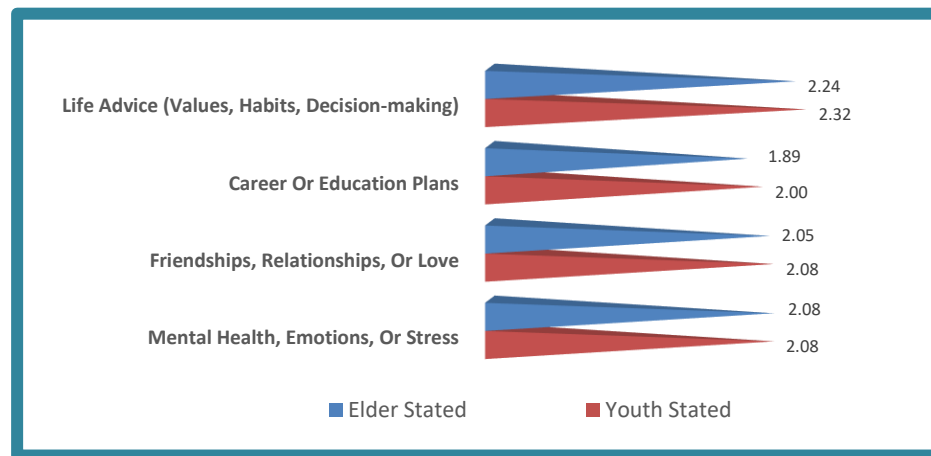


Figure 36: Mean Comfort Levels (1=Not Comfortable, 3=Very Comfortable) discussing various topics with each other as stated by Youth and Elders

As with other parameters in intergenerational relationships, comfort levels for elders rise with **education, co-residence, and financial autonomy**, and declines with **age, dependency, and isolation**. Along similar lines, youth who are **more educated**, or from **joint/extended families** report **greater comfort** across all topics. In contrast, **educational, occupational, and relational isolation** (e.g., being unemployed or less educated) reduce communication ease with elders.

If we look at these mean scores against the persons that youth and elders have interactions with clear patterns are revealed.

Life Advice (Values, Habits, Decision-making)

Elders are most comfortable discussing life advice with **non-relatives they co-reside with (2.69)** and **family friends (2.47)** – suggesting emotional ease with non-judgmental or familiar non-kin, followed closely by **children (2.28)** and **grandchildren (2.27)**.

Youth feel equally or more comfortable with **Family friends (2.60)** and **other relatives (2.44)** over even **parents (2.42)**.

Career or Education Plans

Youth are most comfortable discussing this with **Parents (2.23)** and **grandparents (2.19)**.

Elders, however, report lower comfort across the board, especially with **other relatives (1.66)**. Again, **non-relatives in the same household (2.45)** offer elders more ease than relatives—possibly due to less judgment or expectations.

Friendships, Relationships, or Love

Comfort is fairly **balanced and moderate** across both groups with being slightly higher for **Elders** with **co-residing non-relatives (2.62)**. **Youth** feel most open with **family friends (2.38)** and **other relatives (2.27)**. This suggests **interpersonal comfort and non-hierarchical relationships** enhance openness on this topic.

Mental Health, Emotions, or Stress

Elders prefer **non-relatives in the household (2.65)** and **other relatives (2.20)** for emotional conversations. **Youth** feel **most open with other relatives (2.25)** and **family friends (2.28)**. This may reflect that **emotional safety and lack of judgment**—not blood relation—encourage mental health conversations.

	Relationships	Life Advice	Career Or Education Plans	Relation-ships	Mental Health
Elders	Children/ Children's Spouses	2.28	1.99	2.17	2.12
	Grandchildren/ Grandchildren's Spouses	2.27	1.91	2.03	2.13
	Other Relative	2.08	1.66	2.12	2.20
	Not related, but staying in same household	2.69	2.45	2.62	2.65
	Neighbour / Tenant	2.44	1.99	2.22	2.18
	Family friend	2.47	1.98	2.25	1.92
Youth	Great Grandparent / Grandparent	2.40	2.19	2.15	2.20
	Parent	2.42	2.23	2.24	2.18
	Other Relatives	2.44	2.18	2.27	2.25
	Neighbour	2.40	1.85	2.20	2.21
	Family friend	2.60	1.89	2.38	2.28

Table 6: Mean Comfort Levels discussing various topics by the relationship with the persons they interact with – Youth and Elder

Both elders and youth **open up more to non-parental or non-immediate family figures**—especially **family friends, other relatives, and co-residing non-relatives**. **Trust, emotional safety, and perceived lack of judgment** are key in facilitating intergenerational dialogue, more so than kinship ties alone.

Perception of Generation Gap

51% of youth and **45% of elders** say **“Yes, a big gap”**, indicating strong recognition of a noticeable generational divide from both sides. This suggests that despite age differences, both groups are aware of the disconnect in values, communication, or lifestyle.

38% of elders and **30% of youth** believe there is a **manageable gap**, reflecting optimism that differences can be bridged through effort and understanding.

Only **10% of elders** and **12% of youth** say **“Not really”**, showing that very few completely dismiss the idea of a gap. An even smaller fraction—**3% of elders** and **4% of youth**—say **“No”**, meaning near-universal recognition of at least some generational divide.

A small percentage (5% elders, 4% youth) responded **“I don’t know what that means”**, indicating limited awareness or understanding of the term among a few respondents.

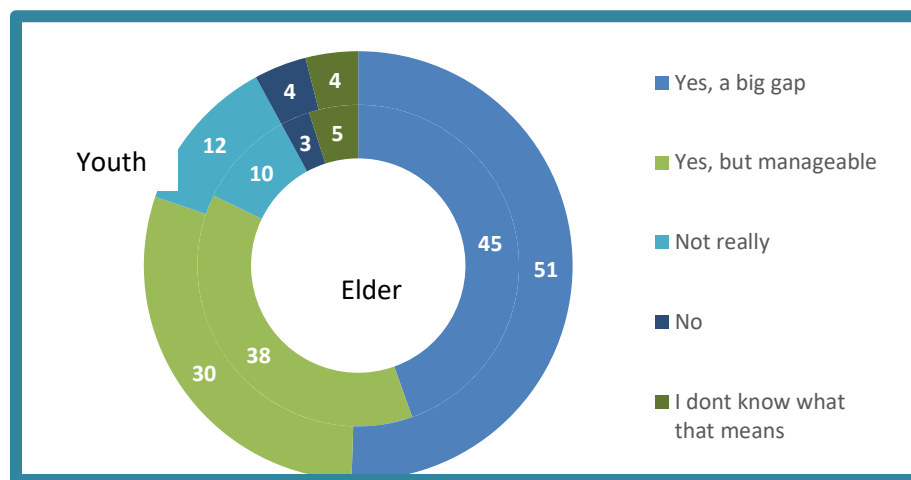


Figure 37: Perception of a Generation Gap by Elders and Youth

Both youth and elders broadly acknowledge the existence of a generation gap—over **80% in both groups** feel there is a gap (big or manageable). While the youth slightly more often see it as a major issue, the elders lean slightly more toward seeing it as manageable. This shared awareness offers a strong foundation for designing interventions aimed at improving intergenerational communication. In the next sub-section, we will study this perception using the Generational Gap Perception Index in order to detect any significant differences across the various youth and elder subgroups by age, gender, SEC, occupation, financial independence, household structure, proximity and relationships as well as types of cities (Metro vs. Non-Metro).

Top reasons for Barriers in Communication

Perceptions of **generational disconnects** that challenge intergenerational communication are mirrored by elders and youth. The common themes reflected across generations are -

Mutual perception of not being understood tops the list with **72% of youth** saying elders “don’t understand the current generation,” while **54% of elders** feel youth “don’t understand older generation views.”

Lack of openness is echoed by **55% of youth** who believe elders aren’t open to hearing new ideas. Similarly, **50% of elders** feel youth aren’t patient listeners.

Language and communication style differences are felt by both. **Youth** (64%) are more likely to feel that elders hold **outdated or strict views**, whereas **49% of elders** struggle with the **slang and modern expressions** youth use.

Differences on **digital fluency** are also stark with **46% of elders** saying youth are “too dependent on digital devices” and **48% of youth** saying elders “are not familiar with digital tools.”

Emotional and Cultural Barriers are there on both sides with **awkwardness** felt by both youth and elder, but more by elders: **27% of elders** feel hesitant to share vs. **22% of youth**.

Only **5% of elders** and **6% of youth** report **no communication issues**, indicating that **over 90% in both groups** experience some form of barrier.

Elders		Youth	
Reasons for not communicating easily with Youth	% Response	Reasons for not communicating easily with Elders	% Response
They don't understand older generation views	54	They don't understand the current generation	72
They are not open to listening patiently	50	They are not open to hearing new ideas	55
They use modern language or slang that I don't follow	49	They use outdated or strict views	64
They are too dependent on digital devices	46	They are not familiar with digital tools	48
I feel awkward or hesitant to share	27	I find it awkward to open up	22
We have different ways of talking or thinking	27	We speak different languages / communication styles	20
Our views of right and wrong are different	23	Nothing - I communicate easily	6
Our timings do not match	7		
Nothing I communicate easily	5		

Table 7: Top reasons for barriers in communication – Elder and Youth perspectives

Generational disconnects are real and **reciprocally felt**—both groups feel misunderstood, unheard, and divided by cultural shifts, digital habits, and communication styles. These findings underscore the need for **interventions that foster empathy, digital bridging, and intergenerational listening**.

Older elders (80+) and those **unable to work due to health** are more likely to feel youth don't understand or listen to them and report **digital dependency** as a barrier. Elders with **no formal education** or those living **alone** more often report confusion due to modern slang, communication gaps, and hesitancy to share. Elders in **non-metro cities** show **slightly fewer barriers**, likely due to stronger family bonds and shared cultural norms. In essence, **vulnerability (age, health, dependence)** and **distance—whether relational, digital, or emotional—amplify communication challenges** in elder–youth interactions.

Youth with no formal education and those in **lower-education tiers** report more difficulty, especially around **understanding elders' views, feeling judged, and facing communication gaps**. **Unemployed youth, daily wage workers,** and those in **agricultural jobs** report the **highest discomfort**, especially with value clashes and digital disconnects. **Postgraduates, self-employed,** and **students** report higher ease and fewer communication barriers—suggesting that education and autonomy play a role in reducing intergenerational tension. **Metro youth** feel more discomfort around **judgment and slang use**, while **non-Metro youth** show slightly better adaptability, likely due to cultural continuity. In essence, **generational friction for youth arises from authority gaps, digital divides, and emotional hesitations**, with education and relationship quality acting as key buffers.

Improving Intergenerational Understanding

There is strong optimism from both elders and youth about improving intergenerational understanding.

Nearly half of elders (49%) and a **majority of youth (57%)** believe mutual understanding can **definitely be improved**.

An additional **35% of elders** and **27% of youth** say "maybe", indicating broad openness to better intergenerational relations.

Only a small minority (12% elders, 11% youth) are doubtful, and **very few (1–2%) reject the idea entirely**, suggesting pessimism is minimal. Identical small shares (3%) in both groups are unsure.

In short, both generations largely believe that stronger mutual understanding is possible—

Both generations believe connection is possible—through shared time, open talk, and mutual respect.

highlighting a shared foundation of hope for better connection and communication.

There is also a strong alignment between elders and youth on how mutual understanding can be improved, with some nuanced differences.

Spending more quality time together is seen as the most effective step by both groups—**84% of elders and 86% of youth**—suggesting a shared belief in the power of presence and attention.

Open and respectful conversations (60% elders, 63% youth) and **sharing experiences and stories** (51% vs. 63%) also rank high, underscoring the value of active listening and dialogue.

Youth consistently rate social inclusion steps higher—such as participating in joint activities (43% vs. 36%) and including elders in outings (33% vs. 22%)—indicating their recognition of the need to bring elders into shared spaces.

Learning from each other is equally acknowledged (24% elders, 23% youth), showing mutual appreciation for cross-generational exchange.

Institutional and community-driven solutions like **school/college programs** or **social initiatives** receive less emphasis (12–16%), reflecting preference for personal over structural approaches.

Respect and empathy campaigns are suggested more by elders (14%) than youth (11%), hinting that elders may feel more need for social recognition.

Overall, both groups favour relational over programmatic interventions, with youth often showing greater enthusiasm for inclusive activities. This suggests fertile ground for strengthening intergenerational bonds through time, dialogue, and shared experiences.

Improving Intergenerational Connection

Both elders and youth overwhelmingly agree that improving intergenerational connection starts with **openness and empathy** from older persons.

The top recommendation is to **be open to youth opinions and experiences**, cited by **76% of elders and 80% of youth**—underscoring mutual recognition that respect for younger voices is foundational.

Youth place slightly more emphasis on **avoiding criticism** (57% vs. 52%) and **sharing stories in an engaging way** (58% vs. 50%), suggesting that tone and style matter in communication.

Elders and youth also align on the importance of **curiosity and participation**, with about one-third recommending elders **show interest in youth trends/technology** and **join family or community activities**.

Creating time for conversations is seen as helpful but not top priority (25–27%), while only a small minority stress **digital learning** (8% elders, 11% youth), indicating that skill gaps are secondary to relational openness.

Very few (3–4%) believe **nothing needs to be done**, showing widespread agreement that elders have a role to play in bridging the generation gap.

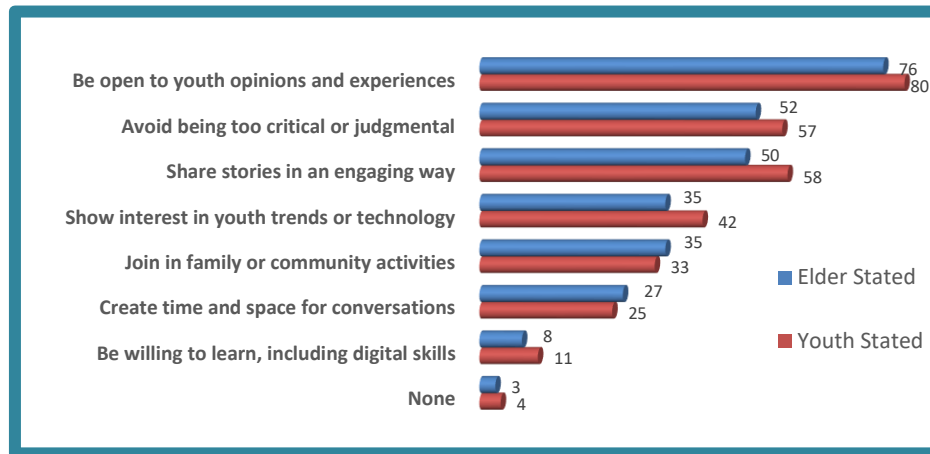


Figure 38: What elders need to do to improve Intergenerational Connection according to Elder and Youth

Overall, the data reflects a shared belief that **mutual respect, reduced judgment, and meaningful storytelling** are key ways elders can foster better connections with youth.

Improving Intergenerational Communication

Both elders and youth identify **simple, respectful, and empathetic communication by the elders** as the key to improving dialogue. The strongest consensus is around the need to **use friendly and simple language**, with **78% agreement from both groups**, suggesting that clarity and tone are essential across generations.

A majority also recommend **avoiding constant comparisons with the past** (57% elders, 59% youth), indicating that judgmental or nostalgic framing can hinder engagement.

Youth particularly want elders to **understand their stress and challenges** (61% vs. 54%), showing a need for emotional awareness and empathy from older persons.

Respecting boundaries during advice-giving is important to half of youth (50%) and 44% of elders, reinforcing the value of sensitive guidance over unsolicited preaching.

While **fewer highlight showing care and interest** (35% youth, 26% elders), this still reflects a notable minority seeking more emotional availability.

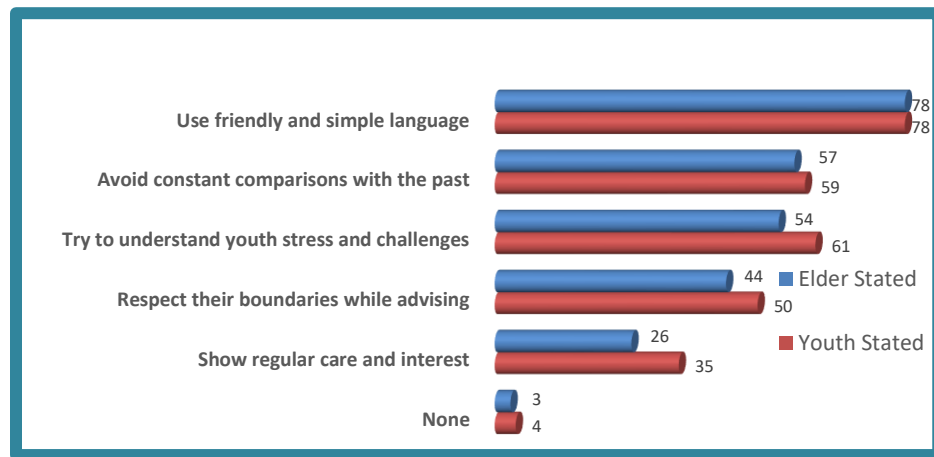


Figure 39: What Elders need to do to improve communication with Youth – Elder and Youth perspectives

In essence, the data reflects a shared belief that **better intergenerational communication begins with mutual respect, emotional understanding, and non-judgmental dialogue.**

Personal Qualities that will foster better Intergenerational Connect

Both elders and youth show strong alignment on the **key interpersonal qualities** that help build intergenerational relationships. **Patience** tops the list for both groups (70% youth, 65% elders), reflecting its foundational role in fostering understanding despite differences.

Empathy and understanding are equally valued (54–55%), showing a shared desire for emotional reciprocity and compassion.

Openness to listening (47% youth, 44% elders) and a **sense of humour** (47% youth, 43% elders) also feature prominently, suggesting that mutual respect and light-heartedness are vital connectors.

Youth place slightly more emphasis on **support during difficulties** (49% vs. 42%), indicating their appreciation for emotional reliability from elders.

Notably, **non-judgmental attitudes** and **respect for elders' views** are less frequently mentioned, especially by elders—possibly suggesting lingering perceptions of criticism or unmet expectations.

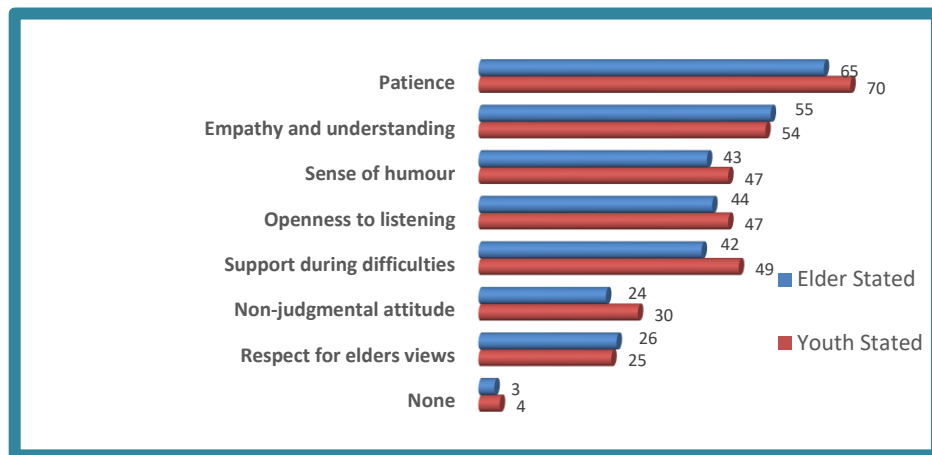


Figure 40: Personal Qualities that will improve Intergenerational Connect – Elder and Youth perspectives

Overall, both generations value **emotional intelligence, mutual respect, and warmth**, affirming the importance of relationship-building qualities in bridging age gaps.

Both elders and youth were specifically asked if adaptability was important for the elder generation. A strong majority of both elders (73%) and youth (77%) agreed that **adaptability is important for older persons to stay connected** with younger generations. This high level of consensus reflects a shared recognition that bridging generational divides requires openness to change—especially from elders.

Only a small minority in both groups (10% elders, 9% youth) believe adaptation is unnecessary, while a moderate segment remains uncertain (17% elders, 14% youth). This indicates that while most embrace the idea of generational flexibility, a few still need encouragement or clarity on what adaptation means in practice.

Overall, these findings underscore **broad mutual support for intergenerational connection through adaptability and growth**.

Some challenges in intergenerational connect were also voiced by the elder and youth during the Focus Group Discussions.

“I just stay silent. If we speak, they say we’re complaining again.”- Elder, Madurai

“Earlier we would run to greet our father. Today’s kids don’t even know if we’ve eaten.”- Elder, Kanpur

“We raised them with love. Now they say, ‘You don’t understand, leave it to us.’ — Elder, Kanpur

“I wanted to make mutton for my grandson. But he ate outside and didn’t tell me.” – Elder, Madurai

“My dadi doesn’t like anything I do. Even standing at the gate irritates her.” — Youth, Kanpur

“We love our grandparents, but we don’t want to be controlled by them.” — Youth, Madurai

“They interfere in everything — from what I wear to how I speak.” — Youth, Kolkata

12.2. Generational Gap Perception Index

The **Generational Gap Perception Score – Elder** is a composite index designed to measure how elders perceive and experience generational disconnect with youth. It is calculated on a **0–100 scale** and comprises four key components:

1. **Barriers to Interaction (0–20)** - Calculated based on the number of stated communication barriers (out of 10 possible reasons).
2. **Communication Discomfort (0–20)** - Derived from average comfort scores across four personal topics (life advice, career, relationships, emotions). Scoring is reverse-weighted: lower comfort yields higher scores, reflecting greater discomfort.
3. **Perceived Generation Gap (0–40)** - Captures elders’ subjective rating of the extent of generational difference. Higher perceived gap leads to higher scores.
4. **Perception of Possibility of Improvement (0–20)** - Measures optimism about bridging the gap. Scores are reversed: low optimism results in higher values (indicating more perceived disconnect).

The **final score** is the sum of these components, offering a comprehensive reflection of **how disconnected elders feel from younger generations and how hopeful they are about improvement**. Details of the calculations are there in the Annexure.

The **Generational Gap Perception Score – Elder** averages to **51.17**, suggesting a moderate perceived divide between older and younger generations. However, distinct patterns emerge across subgroups:

Age and Gender: Older elders (80+) perceive slightly less generational gap than younger ones. Males report a marginally higher perception of the gap (51.86) than females (50.44).

Education: Perception of gap rises with education—**elders with graduate and higher secondary education report the highest scores (54+)**, indicating that exposure and expectations may increase perceived disconnect.

Occupation: **Daily wage workers and self-employed elders show higher scores (52–53)**, while those **never employed report the lowest (48.95)**, possibly due to differing levels of intergenerational engagement.

Financial Dependency: **Partially dependent elders perceive the gap more acutely (52.31)** than either **fully dependent (50.05)** or **fully independent elders (50.96)**.

Sources of Income: Those reliant on **family support (53.56)** or **rental/savings income (53.35)** show higher gap scores, compared to pensioners or earners—possibly due to greater vulnerability or limited direct interaction.

Living Arrangement: Elders **living with non-relatives report higher gap scores (55.36)**, suggesting co-residence with emotionally distant or younger members may heighten perceived disconnect.

Health and Functionality: **Elders with ADL/IADL limitations report significantly higher gap scores (~52.5)** than those without, linking dependency with perceived distance from youth.

Proximity and Relationship: Closer emotional proximity (e.g., interacting with children) correlates with slightly lower scores. Elders linked to **family friends or other relatives report the highest scores (~55–56)**, hinting at lower emotional resonance despite physical closeness.

Location: Elders in **Non-Metro cities (52.65)** report more perceived gap than those in **metros (50.37)**—possibly due to lifestyle differences or differing norms in interaction.

Hence, we can conclude that elders’ sense of generational gap is shaped by their education, health, financial status, and the nature of intergenerational relationships. Greater dependency, formality in relationships, and urban lifestyles are associated with heightened perceptions of disconnection.

The **Generational Gap Perception Score – Youth** is also a composite index that mirrors the structure used for elders, designed to assess how youth perceive the divide between themselves and older generations. It is computed on a **0–100 scale** and includes the same four components as specified for the elder score. Details of the calculations are provided in the Annexure.

The score averages **49.83**, indicating a moderate perception of generational disconnect from the youth perspective. Key subgroup variations reveal important insights:

Education: Youth with **no formal education (54.14)** and those with **secondary education (51.96)** perceive the widest gap, while those with **graduate/postgraduate degrees** report lower scores (~48.7), suggesting that higher education may foster more understanding across generations.

The Generational Gap Index reveals that disconnection is real—but shaped more by education, dependence, and emotional distance than by age alone.

Occupation: **Homemakers (51.79)** and **students (50.32)** indicate stronger awareness of generational gaps—possibly due to more direct engagement with elders.

Relationship with Elders: Youth citing connections with **family friends (51.84)** or **other relatives (51.92)** feel a wider generational divide, likely due to emotional or ideological distance compared to closer familial ties (e.g., parents: 50.65, grandparents: 50.24).

Household Type: Those in **extended families (53.81)** report higher perception of gap compared to nuclear or joint families, indicating potential friction in larger, more hierarchical households.

City Type: Youth in **Non-Metro cities (51.58)** report higher scores than those in **Metro cities (48.65)**—suggesting that the stress or structure of smaller urban settings may exacerbate generational divides.

Youth perceptions of generational gap are influenced by educational background, household structure, nature of elder relationship, and urban context. Those with limited interaction or emotional distance from elders—especially in extended families or smaller cities—report higher perceived divides. Conversely, education and nuclear family structures may facilitate better understanding and lower gap perceptions.

This section reveals a nuanced and multifaceted picture of intergenerational communication between elders and youth. Despite mutual affection and shared aspirations for connection, deep-seated barriers—ranging from busy lifestyles and generational misunderstandings to emotional hesitations and digital divides—impede open dialogue. Both elders and youth broadly acknowledge the presence of a generation gap, yet also express strong optimism about bridging it through empathy, quality time, and mutual respect.

Quantitative findings and the Generational Gap Perception Index show that communication comfort improves with education, proximity, and stronger emotional bonds, while dependency,

isolation, and lack of shared experiences widen the perceived gap. Encouragingly, both generations favour relational over institutional strategies—valuing listening, non-judgmental conversations, and storytelling over structured programs.

Ultimately, this section affirms that intergenerational divides are not insurmountable. Instead, they are shaped by relational dynamics, social context, and willingness to engage. With shared intent and small but meaningful shifts in how both generations interact, listen, and express themselves, these divides can evolve into deeper understanding and renewed connection.

13. SUPPORT SYSTEMS AND AWARENESS ABOUT GOVERNMENT SCHEMES

This section explores the safety nets, support structures, and civic responsibilities surrounding elder care in India—from awareness of government schemes to expectations from family, society, and youth. It begins by assessing how well elders know existing welfare policies and their views on their adequacy. It then compares the support elders currently receive versus what they expect—both from youth and public systems. The section also unpacks intergenerational responsibilities, mapping how both elders and youth view the roles of family, state, and institutions. Finally, it examines youth readiness and willingness to engage in elder care, culminating in a Volunteerism Inclination Index that quantifies intent, confidence, and barriers to participation.



13.1. Awareness of schemes by elders

Elders were asked if they were aware of government schemes and policies and the following examples were provided to help them answer the question.

Type of Support	Example
Monthly pension or financial support	Old age pension under Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS) , Pradhan Mantri Vaya Vandana Yojana (PMVVY)
Free or subsidized health care	Ayushman Bharat , government hospitals, free medicines
Discounted travel for elders	Concessions in trains or state transport buses or airplanes
Legal protection and elder care laws	Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act
Access to emergency or elder helplines	National helpline for elders (14567)
Community care programs or health camps	Senior citizen health check-up camps, day-care centres
Digital or mobile phone training for elders	Basic mobile/ internet training under Digital India initiatives
Meals, ration, or housing for poor elderly	Annapurna scheme, night shelters, old age homes with food support

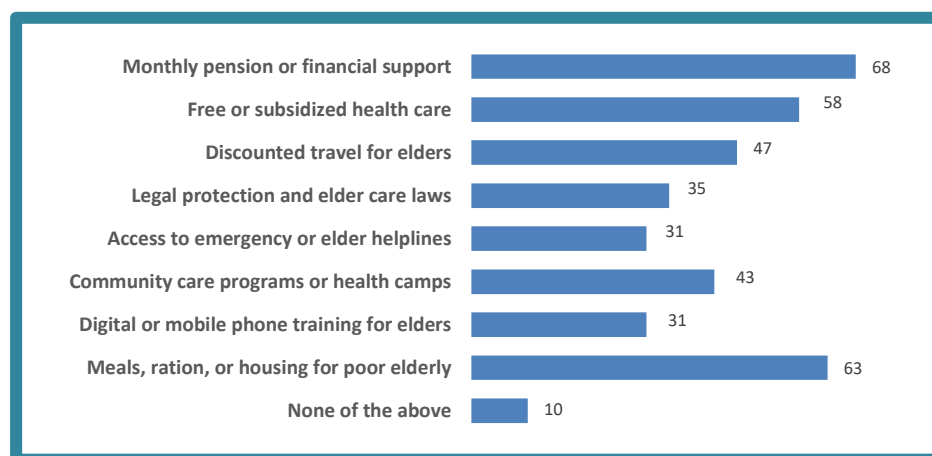
Table 8: Types of Government Schemes and Policies and their Examples

Elders' **awareness of key government schemes and support mechanisms**, shows the highest recall for **monthly pension or financial support (68%)** and **meals, ration, or housing for poor elderly (63%)**, suggesting these are the most well-known provisions.

Free or subsidized healthcare (58%) and **discounted travel (47%)** are also widely recognized, indicating strong public visibility of welfare measures related to health and mobility.

In contrast, **awareness drops sharply** for areas like **legal protection and elder care laws (35%)**, **digital/mobile phone training (31%)**, and **emergency helplines (31%)**, pointing to **gaps in outreach** around safety, legal rights, and digital inclusion.

Only **10%** reported not being aware of any of these initiatives, showing that while



awareness is fairly high overall, **critical support services—especially those related to legal aid and digital access—remain under-recognized** and may require better information dissemination.

Figure 41: Elder Awareness of Government Policies and Schemes for the Elderly

A majority of elders (61%) believe that **government schemes and policies for the elderly are sufficient**, suggesting overall confidence in current support mechanisms. However, **nearly one-fourth (23%)** express dissatisfaction, pointing to a **sizable minority that perceives gaps or unmet needs**. Notably, **16% are not even aware** of such schemes—highlighting a **critical information and outreach deficit** that may be limiting access and impact of existing initiatives. This underscores the need for better communication and ground-level sensitization as stated above.

13.2. Support received vs. expected by elders

This subsection contrasts the actual support elders receive with what they expect from

youth, highlighting alignment gaps in caregiving, financial, and emotional domains.

Current support received

Family members are by far the **primary support system**, cited by **86%** of elders. This is even stronger among those **above 80 years (90%)**, **financially dependent (90%)**, and those **living with children (89%)**. It is lowest among those **living alone (60%)**. This underscores the continuing centrality of familial caregiving in urban India, especially within multi-generational or co-residential arrangements.

Neighbours or friends (45%) form a notable secondary circle of support, especially among the **more educated elders** (57% among higher secondary, 53% among graduates) and those **living alone or with spouse only (57%)**, suggesting reliance on community ties when familial support is less immediate.

Family remains the elder lifeline, but as urban bonds loosen, neighbours, NGOs, and paid care quietly step in.

Familial support and neighbourhood support is higher among **non-Metro elders** than Metro probably due to **stronger community ties, preserved family structures, slower pace of urbanization and lower dependence on formal systems**

NGOs and community groups (24%) and **government services** (24%) are accessed by nearly one in four respondents, indicating moderate institutional engagement. This could point to increasing outreach or reliance on organized support structures, especially for those without close family support or financial independence.

Domestic staff or caregivers are cited by 11%, representing formal or paid care support. This is likely concentrated among financially better-off elders, those living alone, or those with health-related dependencies.

Just **2%** claim to **manage on their own**, suggesting that almost all elders rely on some form of external support—primarily family—emphasizing the low prevalence of complete self-reliance in old age.

Hence, even though traditional familial support remains dominant, there is growing dependence on community, institutional, and paid caregiving options, particularly in urban settings where migration and changing family structures affect co-residence and daily caregiving.

Support expected from youth

The mean scores (on a 1–3 scale, 1=Not Important, 2=Somewhat Important, 3=Very Important) reflect that elder place **highest importance on spending more time together (2.53)**, indicating a strong desire for shared presence and companionship from youth. This

is highest among **elders above 80 (2.58)**, **those dependent on family (2.60)**, and **those with close proximity (2.56 in same household, joint families – 2.64)**, underscoring its emotional significance in late old age and co-residing setups.

This is followed by **emotional support/listening (2.46)**, suggesting that elders highly value

For elders, quality time and a listening ear matter more than money or gadgets—especially in the twilight years and non-metro homes.

being heard and emotionally understood. This is also particularly valued by **elders aged 80+ (2.56)**, **those unable to work due to poor health (2.61)**, and those **fully dependent (2.55)**—highlighting a strong need for empathy among the most vulnerable.

Patience and financial help are rated equally (2.37), showing moderate but meaningful expectations around respectful behaviour and monetary assistance. **Financial help** is slightly more important to **elders over 80 (2.48)**, **less educated (2.48)**, and those **fully dependent on family (2.48)**—revealing economic anxieties among isolated or low-income segments.

Teaching digital tools scores the lowest (1.94), revealing that while digital inclusion is emerging, it remains a relatively lower priority compared to emotional and relational needs. **However**, interest is higher among the **better educated (2.33 graduate/diploma holders)** and **working elders (2.16 in private sector)**—indicating a digital divide tied to education and employment exposure.

Non-metro elders consistently report higher expectations across all types of support—especially in time (2.62), financial help (2.44), and emotional listening (2.55)—suggesting greater reliance on intergenerational support in less urbanized settings.

Overall, the data highlights that **interpersonal connection and emotional presence** are more valued by elders than material or technical forms of support.

13.3. Role of family, society, and state – views of elder and youth

This subsection explores how elders and youth view the roles of family, society, the state, and institutions in elder care, including the perceived responsibilities of different actors in ensuring elder well-being.

Primary responsibility of elder care

Elders and youth were asked to rank **who they believe should be most responsible for the care and well-being of older persons**, and a mean ranking score was calculated based on 1=Least Responsible and 6=Most Responsible, for **family members, government, non-governmental organizations (NGOs), old age homes, society at large and elder persons themselves**.

Universal consensus on family as primary caregiver:

Family members are seen as most responsible by both elders (5.23) and youth (5.00) across all subgroups. The belief is **strongest among elders who are fully dependent (5.37), those aged 71–80 (5.35)**, and those in **joint households (5.44)**, reaffirming the traditional model of family-led care. **Youth in non-metro areas (5.20)** and those close to elders (5.1 among those living in same household) assign slightly **higher responsibility to family** than those in metros.

Government's role viewed with more weight by youth:

Youth rate **government responsibility higher (3.89)** than elders (3.70), especially **students (4.0)**—indicating growing expectations of state involvement among younger, urban populations.

NGO role seen as moderate, but more valued by youth:

Youth give a higher mean score (3.28) to **NGOs** than elders (3.09), suggesting they are more open to community-based or civil society engagement.

Old age homes gain conditional acceptance:

Both elders (3.07) and youth (3.09) rate **old age homes** relatively low in responsibility. Among elders, support is slightly higher among **those aged above 80 (3.10)**

Society at large and self-care seen as peripheral:

Society at large is rated lower by both groups (elders: 2.76, youth: 2.79), especially by elders with **higher dependency**, who clearly prioritize personal networks over diffuse societal support.

The idea that **elders should care for themselves** is stronger among **elders living alone or with spouse**.

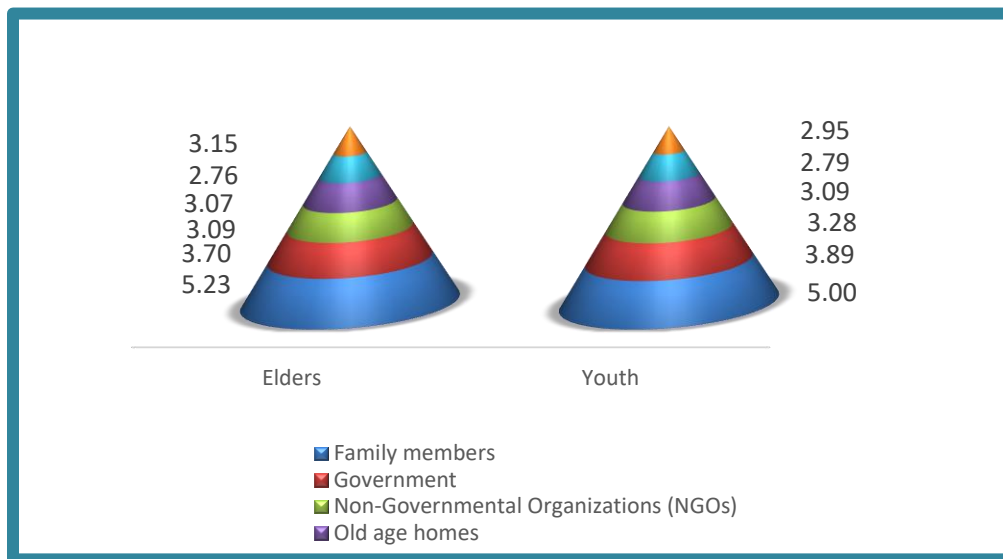


Figure 42: Mean Ranking of Importance of various entities in providing support to Elders – Elder and Youth perspectives

Youth expressed these views during FGDs about who should support Elders.

“Family should care. But yes, government should at least give pension and health support.” — Youth, Madurai

“Government can only give ration. Emotion comes from family.” — Youth, Kanpur

“Even if the government doesn’t, I will do my bit.” — Youth, Mumbai

“If someone is alone, they need external help. But most of us can’t take that responsibility every day. It’s too much.” — Youth, Kolkata

Role of educational institutions

At the overall level, both **youth (81%)** and **elders (78%)** strongly support the inclusion of school/college programs that promote youth engagement with older persons, reflecting a shared belief in the value of intergenerational interaction.

There is widespread support by youth across age, gender, SEC, and occupation, with **students (87%)** and **those in joint families (87%)** most enthusiastic. Youth from **non-metro cities (83%)** support the idea more than **metro youth (79%)**, suggesting youth from smaller cities see greater benefit in structured elder-youth interactions.

Among elders support is high across age groups, especially among **elders with higher education (Diploma/Graduate: 95%)** and those living in **non-Metro cities (88%)**.

Youth and elders alike champion intergenerational service programs, but the call is loudest from students, joint families, and non-Metro cities—where connection is seen as a bridge, not a burden.

These were the views expressed by youth on school/college run programs during the FGDs.

“Our college asked us to join an NGO and help at old-age homes. We loved doing that.”
— Youth, Kolkata

“We can teach elders yoga or laughter therapy on weekends. That feels nice.” — Youth, Mumbai

“We should be taught how to support them emotionally, like a subject in school.” — Youth, Madurai

13.4. Youth willingness to support and Volunteerism Inclination Index

This subsection assesses youth willingness to support, engage with, and volunteer for elder care, culminating in a Volunteerism Inclination Index that reflects both their intent and perceived responsibility, with insights drawn from quantitative patterns and qualitative narratives.

Youth willingness to support elders

At the **overall level**, a strong **76% of youth believe they have a role in improving the lives of older persons**, suggesting widespread recognition of intergenerational responsibility and empathy. Only 9% disagree, while 15% remain uncertain.

Education shows a clear gradient with agreement being highest among **postgraduates (92%)** and **higher secondary pass-outs (79%)**, while those with **no formal education (71%)** are comparatively less convinced. This suggests that **higher education correlates with a stronger sense of civic and intergenerational duty**.

Most youth see themselves as changemakers for elders—especially the educated and co-residing—while others await direction to turn empathy into action.

Students (83%) and those in **self-employment (84%)** are particularly affirmative, whereas **daily wage workers (68%)** express comparatively less belief in their role.

Youth who live in **joint households (83%)** and those **interacting parents and grandparents** are more likely to affirm their role—indicating that **closeness to elders positively influences attitudes**.

The “**May be**” response (15% overall) is higher among the **unemployed (19%)** and **agricultural workers (23%)**, indicating some uncertainty or lack of clarity about how they can contribute meaningfully.

Support for youth involvement in elder well-being is widespread, especially among educated and co-residing youth. However, lower conviction among less educated and economically vulnerable subgroups highlights the need for **targeted awareness and structured engagement opportunities** to translate good intentions into action.

Youth willingness to volunteer for elder care

At the **overall level**, a promising **75% of youth express willingness to volunteer** in programs supporting the elderly—such as companionship, tech assistance, or errands. This high interest signals a positive foundation for intergenerational engagement initiatives.

Education is a strong enabler:

Support is highest among **postgraduates (86%)** and high school pass-outs (**76%**), while lower among those with **no formal education (74%)** suggesting awareness and access to such programs are linked to educational capital.

Occupation matters:

Students (82%) and **self-employed youth (83%)** show high intent, contrasting with **daily wage workers (58%)** and **agricultural workers (70%)**, where both intent and certainty are lower—highlighting practical barriers like time or resources.

Household and relationship proximity influences readiness:

Those from **joint families (83%)**, **extended households (85%)**, and youth living in the **same household as elders (83%)** are most willing to volunteer, suggesting personal connection and familiarity boost motivation.

Three in four youth are ready to stand by seniors—especially students and those living with elders—while the rest just need the right nudge to step in.

“**Maybe**” responses (**13% overall**) are notably higher among the **unemployed (14%)**, those in **other city/village proximity (18%)**, and **those with looser elder ties** (e.g., interacting with neighbour: 14%)—indicating an openness that could be activated with the right push or facilitation.

Willingness to volunteer for elder care is high across youth, especially among those with closer intergenerational ties, education, and stability. However, targeted efforts are needed to convert the “**maybes**” and address **barriers among economically vulnerable groups** to make volunteering inclusive and scalable.

Among the activities that they want to volunteer for, **“spending time with elders living alone”** emerges as the most preferred volunteer activity among youth (82%), indicating a strong inclination toward direct emotional engagement and companionship. This preference is even higher among **students (88%), postgraduates (95%),** and those in **joint or extended families (84%),** suggesting that personal connection and educational exposure reinforce empathy-driven motivations.

Other popular areas include **assisting with hospital or market visits (63%)** and **teaching digital skills (56%),** especially among youth living in non-metro cities (71%, 73%), and those who have strong relational proximity (e.g., to parents or grandparents). Activities like **running errands (51%), helping in old-age homes (41%),** and **supporting mental health (25%)** find moderate interest, though notably higher among **metro youth and those with closer familial ties.**

Youth wants to help the elders in small ways that can have a bigger impact on them. Some of ways that they can help were voiced during the Focus Group Discussions.

“We can take them for outings, help buy fruits, help them find books or music they like.”
— Youth, Kolkata

“Helping doesn’t always mean big things. I take my grandma to the doctor, or just set up YouTube for her.” — Youth, Mumbai

“During Durga Puja, we can have events in old-age homes. Dance, theatre — it makes them feel part of us.” — Youth, Kolkata

“On Diwali, we give them clothes. Even if small, it’s a way to show we care.” — Youth, Mumbai

“Like our parents, we also take dada-dadi to the temple on Chhath.” — Youth, Kanpur

“Helping them get a small pension or work-from-home thing would be ideal.” — Youth, Kolkata

“My nana loves listening to 90s music — so I set up YouTube playlists for him.” — Youth, Kolkata

Confidence and preparedness for supporting elders

At the overall level, **54% of youth report feeling “very confident”** and another **36% “somewhat confident”** in their ability to care for an older person in the future, giving a strong combined confidence rating of 90%.

Notable differences emerge across subgroups. **Confidence is highest among postgraduates** and those in **joint or extended families** —suggesting that educational exposure and household structure enhance caregiving preparedness. Those with **closer relational proximity** (e.g., youth interacting with parents, grandparents) also report higher confidence. On the other hand, **daily wage workers**, youth in **metro cities**, and those with weaker elder connections (living in household with no elders) exhibit relatively lower confidence. Additionally, **“not sure” or “not confident”** responses are slightly more common among the **unemployed and younger 18–24 age group**, indicating a potential need for guidance, training, or exposure.

Youth demonstrate strong overall confidence in their ability to care for elders, especially when supported by **education, family structure, and lived intergenerational experience**. Tailored capacity-building efforts could help bridge remaining gaps among less connected or economically vulnerable segments.

Volunteerism Inclination Index

The **Volunteerism Inclination Score** is a composite index ranging from **0 to 100**, designed to measure young people's potential to engage in elder care initiatives. It integrates five key components:

- 1. Shared Responsibility Belief**, rated on a scale from 1 to 5 and normalized to a 0–20 score
- 2. Willingness to Volunteer**, based on direct intent, with highest scores assigned to the most affirmative responses
- 3. Volunteer Interest Types**, calculated by the number of different volunteer activities selected, scaled to 20
- 4. Role of Society & NGOs**, which combines perceived importance of institutional roles
- 5. Perceived Limits of Family Care**, where greater recognition of family limitations translates to higher scores and it is normalized using an inverse score method

The final score is the sum of all these normalized components, giving a comprehensive view of a youth’s inclination to volunteer for elder support.

The **mean Volunteerism Inclination Score** among youth stands at **53.38**, indicating a moderate-to-high overall readiness to engage in elder care support. The differences across subgroups are as following -

Youth volunteer spirit runs highest where education, empathy, and elder bonds meet—bridging generations with purpose.

Education plays a significant role: scores rise steadily from **52.32 among those with no formal education** to **55.03 among postgraduates**, confirming that awareness, exposure, and civic-mindedness increase with educational attainment.

Occupation-wise, **students (54.72)** and the **self-employed (55.41)** report the highest inclination, while **daily wage workers (49.58)** and **agricultural workers (48.97)** show lower scores, likely due to economic constraints and limited time flexibility.

By geography, youth in **non-Metro cities (54.85)** are slightly more inclined than those in metros (52.38), and those in **joint families (54.92)** show greater inclination than those in nuclear families (52.42), reflecting stronger intergenerational influence.

In essence, the inclination to volunteer is strongest among the **educated, relationally connected, and socially embedded youth**, while it drops among those facing **economic or social vulnerabilities**.

This section reveals that while **family remains the cornerstone of elder support**, a **multi-actor approach** involving community, institutions, and youth is increasingly relevant. Elders are moderately aware of government schemes, but critical gaps remain—especially in digital inclusion, legal protection, and helpline access—highlighting the need for better outreach. Elders deeply value **emotional presence, empathy, and respectful care** from youth, with expectations highest among the most vulnerable. Encouragingly, youth overwhelmingly affirm their **responsibility, willingness, and confidence** to support elders, particularly those who are educated, live in joint families, or have strong personal connections with older persons. The **Volunteerism Inclination Index** underscores a promising foundation for intergenerational engagement, while also flagging areas for intervention—particularly for youth with economic constraints or limited exposure to elder care. As India's population ages, these insights can inform more inclusive elder care strategies, combining **policy, proximity, and youth participation** to build a compassionate and resilient support ecosystem.

14. FUTURE ASPIRATIONS AND FEARS ABOUT AGEING – ELDER AND YOUTH VIEWS

This section explores how youth and elders envision ageing—unpacking their fears, hopes, and expectations around care, living arrangements, and what constitutes a good life in old age—while highlighting where their views converge or diverge across demographic and relational contexts.



14.1. Fears about getting old

At the overall level, both youth and elders share core fears about ageing—**loneliness/isolation**, **poor health**, and **financial insecurity**—but they diverge significantly in emphasis.

The common top fears are **Loneliness or Isolation** for both groups (Youth: 69%, Elders: 68%). **Poor Health or Physical Weakness** is slightly more prevalent among youth (67%) than elders (61%). **Financial Insecurity** is more feared by youth (62%) than elders (58%), suggesting forward-looking anxiety among youth about the cost of ageing.

Youth show greater fear of **technology-related obsolescence** (20%) and **mental decline** (15%) compared to elders (16% and 14%, respectively). **Loss of dignity and respect** is a concern for 37% of youth—comparable to elders (32%). Fear of **being dependent for daily tasks** is higher among youth (50%) as compared to elders (44%)

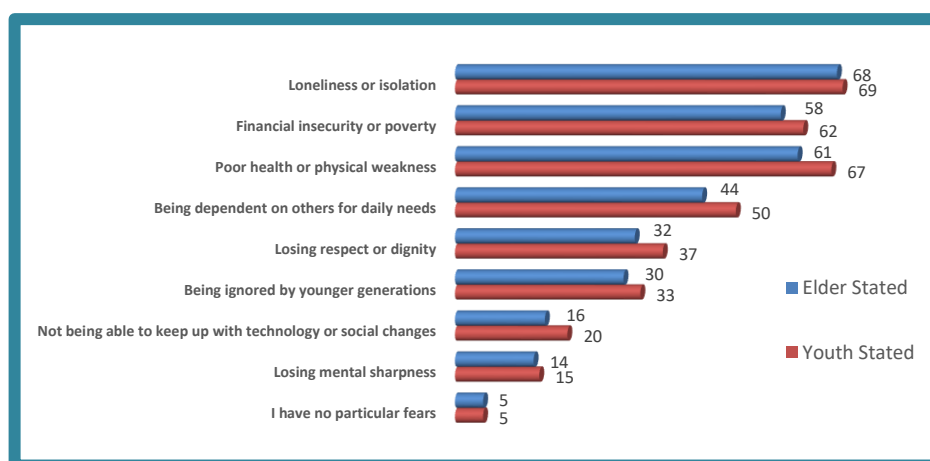


Figure 43: Fears about Ageing – Elder and Youth perspectives

Youth aged 25–30 report slightly fewer fears compared to the 18–24 group—possibly due to greater stability or distance from old age. Elders above 80 show heightened fear across all domains.

Elders with lower educational levels consistently report higher fears across most items—highlighting vulnerability.

Students and homemaker youth and elders, as well as elders unable to work show greater fear of financial and physical vulnerability.

Joint and extended households show higher levels of anxiety among youth and elders alike, especially related to poor health and financial insecurity, perhaps due to visible exposure to elder decline.

Youth and elders in non-Metros report slightly **higher levels of most fears**, especially about isolation and respect.

Only 5% of youth and 5% of elders say they have “no particular fears.” Among youth, this is marginally higher in the 25–30 years age group and among graduates/diploma holders, living in nuclear families in Metro cities; for elders, this appears among younger, financially independent living with children and spouse.

While both generations fear vulnerability in old age, **youth fears are anticipatory and framed by modern anxieties** like digital irrelevance and future dependency, whereas **elder fears are experiential**, shaped by present realities of health decline, social detachment, and dependence.

Some of the fears expressed during the FGDs by the youth bear this out.

Who will be my caretaker? Will I be kept in an old age home?” — Youth, Mumbai

“Our own parents expect a lot. I don’t want to do that to my kids.” — Youth, Kanpur

14.2. Expectations of living and care arrangements and environment

A comparison of youth and elder responses reveals a **strong shared aspiration for family-based ageing**, though it is slightly more pronounced among the youth. **88% of youth** expect to live with their family when they are old, while **83% of elders** say they currently live with or would move in with their family as they grow older. The consistency across age, gender, and socio-economic groups in both datasets underscores the cultural norm of multigenerational co-residence in urban India.

However, nuanced subgroup differences among elders point to **greater uncertainty and barriers to realization**. The desire to live with family declines among those **above 80 years (80%), financially dependent**, or **living alone** (as low as 57%) or living in **metro cities (79%)**. In contrast, among youth, expectations remain high across all groups, especially those with close relationships with grandparents or parents (92–93%) and those from joint households (92%). These patterns suggest that while youth are optimistic and culturally aligned with elder care expectations, elders—particularly the vulnerable—may face practical or emotional gaps that temper their outlook.

Expectations for elder care (when the elderly become older and the youth become elderly) reveal both shared family reliance and evolving preferences, particularly between youth and elders, and across subgroups.

Core Expectations:

Both generations primarily expect care from **children or grandchildren** (65% of elders, 63% of youth). However, youth show slightly higher expectations from a **spouse/partner** (66% vs. 56% for elders) and **other family members** (39% vs. 34%).

Youth's Shifting Outlook on Formal Care:

Youth are notably more inclined towards formal care options such as **paid caregivers or domestic help** (28% of youth expect this, compared to 18% of elders), **old age homes or assisted living** (30% of youth vs. 19% of elders), **government or community programs** (18% of youth vs. 10% of elders). This indicates a growing acceptance of non-familial support, likely driven by changing lifestyles and increased awareness of such services.

A higher percentage of youth (10%) are also "not sure" about their future care, reflecting this evolving landscape.

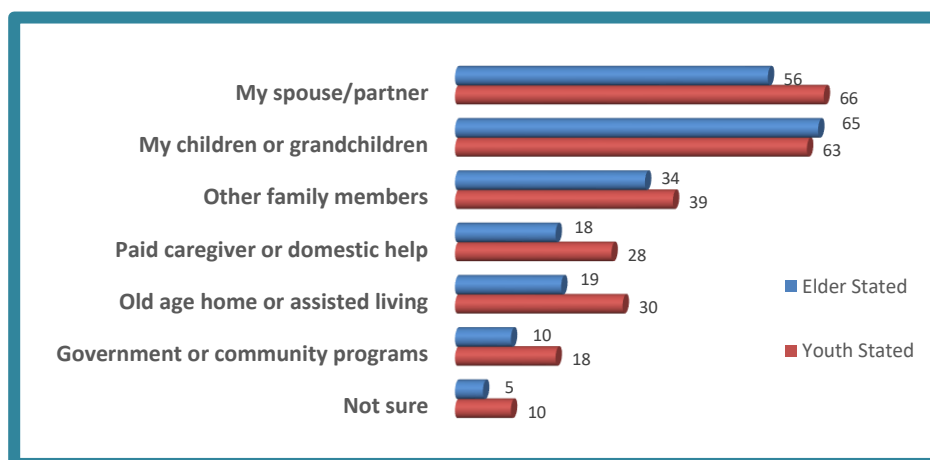


Figure 44: Who will provide care when Elders become Older and Youth become Elder – Elder and Youth perspectives

In summary, while family remains central to elder care expectations, youth increasingly foresee a role for formal care services, with socioeconomic factors and living situations significantly influencing these projections.

In terms of the environment that the elder and youth want to live when they grow older or become elderly, a striking similarity is the overwhelming preference for **living with close family (joint or extended household)**, with 75% of elders and 73% of youth choosing this option. This highlights a strong cultural inclination towards multi-generational living, suggesting that family support is a cornerstone of desired elderly care for both groups.

Following this, both cohorts also show a significant preference for being **independent but near family**, with 36% of elders and 48% of youth opting for this. This indicates a desire for autonomy alongside the comfort of proximity to loved ones. The higher percentage among youth might suggest a future trend towards more independent living arrangements for seniors, but still within a family support network.

Interestingly, **living in an old age home with good care and facilities** is chosen by 38% of elders and 48% of youth. The higher percentage among youth could reflect a more pragmatic view of future care needs, or perhaps a greater acceptance of institutional care if quality is assured. This has also been brought out by the aspect of who will care for them in their old age detailed above.

Less popular, but still noteworthy, are preferences for living **with a partner or spouse only** (26% elder, 40% youth) and **in a peaceful retirement community** (20% elder, 26% youth). The higher numbers for youth in these categories might signal a shift towards smaller household units and community-based living in the future, possibly influenced by changing social structures and economic conditions.

Finally, a small percentage of both elders (6%) and youth (9%) haven't thought about it, indicating that while many have clear preferences, some remain undecided.

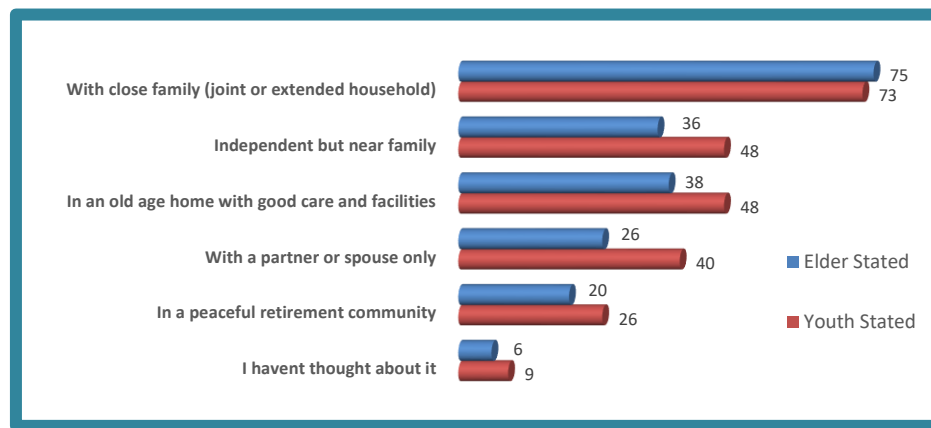


Figure 45: Environment in which Elders and Youth want to live when they become Older or Elderly

In summary, the data strongly emphasizes the enduring importance of family in elderly living arrangements for both generations, while also hinting at a potential future where independent living near family, and even quality old age homes, might become more widely accepted, particularly by the younger generation.

During the FGDs youth voiced these environments that they want to live in when they are elderly, emphasizing that youth possibly want more respectful detachment when they are older than the current elders.

Even if I have children, I'll want my own peaceful space.” — Female, Kolkata

“I want to build a bank balance, live alone, no emotional drama.” — Male, Kanpur

14.3. Important factors for a good life as an elderly

For both groups, elder and youth, **financial security** stands out as a paramount concern, with 70% of elders and a higher 72% of youth identifying it as crucial. This underscores a universal understanding that financial stability is foundational for well-being in later life, enabling access to necessities and comfortable living.

Good physical and mental health is also a top priority, highly valued by 66% of elders and 68% of youth. This indicates a strong awareness across generations that health is indispensable for maintaining quality of life and independence.

The desire for **being respected and valued** is slightly higher among youth (48%) compared to elders (45%). This could suggest that younger individuals foresee a greater need for recognition and appreciation as they age, or perhaps they perceive current societal shortcomings in how elders are valued. **Staying socially connected** and living with loved ones is very important for both,

This aligns with the previous observation from other data that youth and elders often envision multi-generational living arrangements.

Being independent in daily life is valued by 22% of elders and youth. This indicates a shared desire for autonomy and self-sufficiency, even as physical capabilities may decline.

Finally, **having purposeful and meaningful activities** (11% elder, 9% youth) and **access to healthcare and support services** (12% elder, 8% youth) are considered important, though by a smaller percentage of both groups. The slightly higher emphasis on healthcare by elders is intuitive, as they are likely experiencing the need for these services first hand.

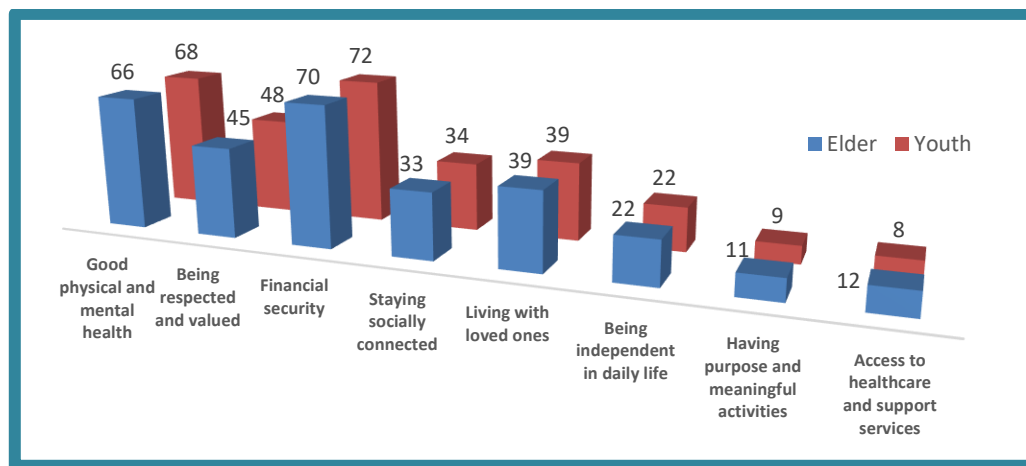


Figure 46: Most important factors for a good life in old age – Elder and Youth perspectives

In summary, while financial security and good health are universal top priorities for a good old age, youth place a slightly higher emphasis on being respected, valued, and socially connected, suggesting a proactive view on the emotional and social aspects of aging. Elders, having more direct experience, prioritize practical considerations like health and independence, but also share the desire for financial stability.

This section reveals a nuanced picture of aging aspirations and fears across generations. While both youth and elders share core anxieties about loneliness, poor health, and financial insecurity, youth exhibit a stronger forward-looking apprehension regarding dependency and technological obsolescence. Crucially, the desire for family-based living arrangements remains paramount for both groups, reflecting a deep-seated cultural norm. However, youth show a growing pragmatic acceptance of formal care options and a greater desire for independent living near family or in retirement communities, hinting at evolving societal landscapes. Ultimately, both generations prioritize financial security and good health for a fulfilling old age, though youth place a notably higher emphasis on respect, value, and social connection, suggesting a proactive approach to the emotional and social dimensions of aging.



Key Learnings and Way Forward

15. KEY LEARNINGS FROM THE STUDY

This section provides a comprehensive synthesis of key insights gleaned from the study's examination of youth and elder perspectives on aging and intergenerational interactions. It meticulously highlights areas of both agreement and dissonance in their views, uncovering where perceptions align and where significant gaps exist between stated attitudes and lived experiences.



Furthermore, it delves into critical thematic disparities—such as the perceived value of elders versus their actual emotional state—and explores how family structure, urban location, elder vulnerability and emotional states profoundly shape these intergenerational dynamics.

15.1. Perceptions about Ageing

Urban Indian youth generally respect elders and are concerned about their well-being, associating them with wisdom but also loneliness and dependence. However, elders often experience a deeper emotional distress and feel less valued than youth perceive. Stereotypes about physical decline persist, and media portrayals, while influential, don't fully capture elders' complex emotional realities.

Youth acknowledge elders' wisdom and the need for support, while elders confirm some physical decline and feelings of loneliness. Both value face-to-face family interactions. Youth's perceived high respect for elders doesn't always translate into elders feeling genuinely valued or included in decisions. Youth also underestimate the intensity of elders' negative emotions.

15.2. Interactions and Bonding between Elders and Youth

Frequent, family-centric interactions define intergenerational relationships in urban India, largely occurring at home. While both generations value in-person contact, a significant digital divide hampers communication. Joint families and non-metro settings foster stronger emotional bonds, yet many elders, despite frequent contact, express feelings of being overlooked or isolated, highlighting a gap between consistent presence and meaningful emotional connection.

Both generations agree on high daily interaction frequency, primarily at home and through shared activities like meals and conversations. Youth overestimate elders' engagement with digital communication, while elders express frustration with phone-centric interactions and often feel "reminded of their age" or "left out."

15.3. Respect, Value and Role of Elders

Most elders in urban India perceive a moderate level of respect and value from younger generations, particularly within their immediate families. This sense of worth is significantly influenced by factors such as age (with older elders often receiving more reverence), education, financial independence, and living arrangements. While elders contribute actively through advice and childcare, a notable segment, especially the isolated or financially dependent, feels less acknowledged, highlighting disparities in how respect is manifested and perceived in a rapidly evolving social landscape.

Elders largely perceive themselves as respected by younger family members and healthcare providers, aligning with youth's stated general respect for elders. Despite feeling generally respected, a segment of elders (14-21% feeling rarely/not at all respected by neighbours/friends) and a small minority (5% rarely/never consulted in family decisions) indicate a gap between perceived general respect and consistent, practical inclusion.

15.4. Digital Inclusion and Technology Use

Digital inclusion among urban Indian elders is moderate and highly uneven, with basic mobile phone use common but limited adoption of smartphones and internet services. While many elders are willing to learn, significant barriers exist due to perceived complexity, fear of mistakes, and a notable lack of patient support from youth. Youth, primarily children and grandchildren, are the main digital enablers, but a striking perception gap concerning elders' disinterest versus youth's impatience hinders effective learning. Digital tools are widely seen by elders as bonding opportunities, but true inclusion is largely driven by age, education, financial autonomy, and direct family support, leaving vulnerable elders further marginalized.

Both elders (70%) and youth (73%) largely agree that youth provide significant support in using smartphones/apps and assisting with online forms/bookings. Elders also widely (73%) believe digital technology brings them closer to youth.

A stark mismatch in perceptions exists regarding learning barriers. Youth overwhelmingly believe elders are disinterested (78%) or forget instructions (66%), while elders blame youth's impatience (71%) and fast explanations (49%). Youth (48%) think they help more with messaging/video calls than elders (38%) report receiving. Elders (44%) feel embarrassed to ask repeatedly, a sentiment youth (6%) largely do not acknowledge.

15.5. Financial and Health Inclusion

Financial and health inclusion are crucial for elders' dignity and well-being in urban India. Nearly half of elders are financially independent, yet a significant portion remains dependent, highlighting the need for robust social safety nets. Health challenges, especially mobility issues and chronic pain, are widespread, requiring extensive caregiving. Youth play a vital support role, but there's a consistent perception gap where elders often understate their financial and emotional dependence, while youth may overestimate their expected involvement. This underscores the need for improved intergenerational communication and tailored support systems to ensure elders' holistic well-being.

Both youth and elders largely agree on the substantial level of financial assistance youth provide (e.g., partial support, pocket money). They also align strongly on youth's role in physical health support, such as taking elders to doctors (81% elders, 82% youth) and helping with medication (65% both).

Elders report significantly *more* help with financial tasks like ATM withdrawals and health insurance than youth acknowledge, suggesting youth may under-recognize routine assistance. Conversely, youth report higher involvement in guiding financial decisions and providing small income-generating work support than elders explicitly expect. Critically, youth (48%) are more likely to expect to listen to elders' emotional concerns than elders (42%) report expecting, indicating youth may be more attuned to emotional needs that elders are reluctant to voice.

15.6. Challenges in Intergenerational Communications

Intergenerational communication in urban India faces significant barriers, largely stemming from busy schedules and perceived lack of interest from both sides. While both youth and elders recognize a generational gap, there's a strong shared optimism for improvement through empathy, quality time, and mutual respect. However, key disconnects remain in communication styles, digital fluency, and emotional openness, often exacerbated by education levels, living arrangements, and the nature of relationships. Bridging these gaps requires a focus on relational dynamics over formal interventions.

Both elders (76%) and youth (74%) strongly agree that "youth have busy schedules" is the top barrier. They also align on a "lack of interest in interacting" (40% elders vs. 39% youth) and generally acknowledge the existence of a generation gap (over 80% in both groups perceive a gap, big or manageable). Both prioritize "spending more quality time together" (84% elders, 86% youth) and "open and respectful conversations" (60% elders, 63% youth) for improvement.

Youth are more likely to cite "communication gaps" (30% vs. 28% elders) and "judgment from elders" (25% vs. 22% elders). Youth also more frequently mention "lack of common interests/topics" (43% vs. 40% elders). Elders, however, more often struggle with "modern language or slang" (49%) and perceive youth as "too dependent on digital devices" (46%), while youth (48%) see elders as "not familiar with digital tools."

15.7. Support Systems and Policy Awareness

Family remains the cornerstone of elder care in urban India, with 86% of elders relying on family support. However, there is a growing recognition of the need for a multi-actor approach involving government, NGOs, and youth. While elders show moderate awareness of government schemes, critical gaps exist in knowledge of legal protections and digital training. Youth demonstrate a strong willingness (75%) and confidence (90%) to support elders, particularly educated youth and those in joint families, highlighting a significant potential for intergenerational volunteerism. Bridging information gaps and providing structured opportunities are crucial for enhancing elder well-being.

Both elders (81%) and youth (78%) strongly support school/college programs promoting youth engagement with older persons. Both universally agree that "Family members" are most responsible for elder care (elders 5.23, youth 5.00 on a 6-point scale).

Youth rate "Government responsibility" higher (3.89) than elders (3.70) for elder care, indicating growing expectations of state involvement among younger generations. Elders perceive a higher need for "financial help" from youth (2.37 mean importance) compared to youth's emphasis on "teaching digital tools" (1.94 mean importance) as a priority for elders.

15.8. Future Aspirations and Fears about Ageing – Elder and Youth Views

Both youth and elders share fundamental fears about aging—namely loneliness, poor health, and financial insecurity—but their perspectives are shaped by their current life stages. While both generations strongly aspire for family-based living arrangements in old age, youth show a growing pragmatic acceptance of formal care options and a desire for independent living near family. Financial security and good health are universal priorities for a good life in old age, with youth placing a slightly higher emphasis on being respected, valued, and socially connected, indicating an evolving outlook on aging.

Loneliness/isolation (Youth: 69%, Elders: 68%), poor health (Youth: 67%, Elders: 61%), and financial insecurity (Youth: 62%, Elders: 58%) are top shared fears. Loss of dignity/respect is also a significant concern for both (Youth: 37%, Elders: 32%).

Youth express higher fear of being dependent for daily tasks (50% vs. 44% elders), technology-related obsolescence (20% vs. 16% elders), and mental decline (15% vs. 14% elders). These reflect forward-looking anxieties about future challenges.

Elders' fears are more rooted in their present realities, particularly health decline and potential social detachment

Both have an overwhelming preference for living with close family (Elders: 75% currently or would move in; Youth: 73% expect to). However, youth (48%) show a higher preference for being "independent but near family" compared to elders (36%).

Both primarily expect care from "children or grandchildren" (65% elders, 63% youth). However, youth show a notable shift towards formal care options like "paid caregivers/domestic help" (28% youth vs. 18% elders) and "old age homes/assisted living" (30% youth vs. 19% elders)

Financial security (Elders: 70%, Youth: 72%) and good physical/mental health (Elders: 66%, Youth: 68%) are universal top priorities. Youth (48%) place a slightly higher emphasis on "being respected and valued" than elders (45%).

15.9. Thematic Gaps in Perception vs. Practice

Respect/Value: Youth believe elders are valuable and respected, but elders' qualitative responses reveal feelings of being ignored or having their opinions side-lined in practice.

Independence/Capability: Youth believe elders can remain active with support, and financially independent elders express autonomy. However, a significant portion of elders, especially the oldest and financially dependent, report feeling dependent, anxious, or losing control, suggesting a gap between the aspiration of independence and the practical realities of their lives.

Emotional State: Youth perceive elders as "lonely" or "dependent," but elders' self-reported "negative feelings" about aging (54%) and prevalence of loneliness (47%) are often more intense than youth might fully grasp.

Digital Engagement: Youth perceive digital interactions as meaningful ways to connect, but in practice, elders engage less and often prefer traditional face-to-face communication, leading to a gap in desired vs. actual modes of connection.

Quality of Interaction: Despite frequent physical interaction, elders sometimes feel a lack of genuine emotional engagement ("They come for money, not for advice," "Even if we

live in the same house, we eat alone"), indicating a gap between physical presence and deep emotional bonding.

Value and Inclusion: While youth are present and assist, elders' expressions like "We are told the plan, not asked" suggest a gap where their opinions are not always sought or genuinely valued in practice, despite frequent conversation.

Inclusion in Decisions: While 75% of elders feel their opinions are "always" or "often" considered in family decisions, a notable 25% feel "sometimes," "rarely," or "never" consulted, indicating a gap between the ideal of elder inclusion and the practical experience for some.

Societal Relevance: Elders feel highly relevant to their immediate family (59%), but this drops significantly for broader society (39-44% for neighbours, friends, community, society), suggesting a gap between their family roles and broader societal acknowledgment of their value.

Acknowledgement of Contributions: While 78% of elders feel their contributions are acknowledged, nearly 1 in 5 (18%) feel "rarely" or "not at all" acknowledged, indicating a gap in consistent appreciation for their efforts.

Access vs. Engagement: While basic mobile phone ownership is high (71%), active digital engagement (e.g., social media 13%, online services 5%) is low, indicating a gap between device access and meaningful use.

Willingness vs. Support Quality: A majority of elders are willing to learn digital technology (42% definite interest, 28% open), but the actual support they receive often falls short due to youth's impatience or tendency to "do it for me without teaching" (30% elders report this).

Emotional vs. Functional Use: Elders widely perceive digital tools as enhancing emotional connection (73% feel closer to youth), despite the practical barriers and frustrations in learning to use them.

Financial Dependency: While 45% of elders are independent, 38% are partially, and 15% are fully dependent. Elders' reluctance to admit full dependency (only 17% acknowledge full support vs. 25% youth who say they provide it) creates a gap in acknowledged need versus actual provision.

Digital Financial Support: Youth significantly overestimate elders' expectation for help with bank accounts or digital payments (45% youth vs. 17% elders), highlighting a silent struggle or lack of explicit communication from elders.

Emotional Caregiving: Youth's higher awareness of emotional support needs (listening to concerns) compared to elders' explicit expectations suggests that this crucial area might be under-addressed in practice, even if recognized in principle.

Preventive Health: Youth are more likely to acknowledge their role in promoting healthy habits (63%) than elders expect (57%), indicating a proactive outlook from youth that elders may not fully internalize.

Perceived Disinterest vs. Underlying Barriers: Both groups perceive disinterest from the other, but deeper issues like youth's "judgment from elders" or elders' "hesitancy to share" reveal emotional barriers beyond simple lack of interest.

Comfort in Discussion: While both generations show moderate comfort discussing emotional topics like mental health and relationships (mean 2.08 out of 3), suggesting openness, there's a practical gap where actual communication might be hindered by impatience or perceived criticism. Career/education plans remain the most awkward topic for both.

Digital Fluency vs. Relational Openness: Despite recognizing digital fluency as a barrier, both groups prioritize relational qualities (patience, empathy, non-judgment) over digital learning when discussing ways to improve connection, suggesting that emotional connection is seen as more fundamental than technical skill.

Scheme Awareness vs. Sufficiency: While 61% of elders believe government schemes are sufficient, 16% are not even aware of them, indicating a significant information and outreach deficit. Awareness is highest for "monthly pension" (68%) and "meals, ration, or housing" (63%), but drops sharply for "legal protection" (35%) and "digital/mobile phone training" (31%).

Primary Support System: 86% of elders cite family as their primary support, significantly higher among the 80+ age group (90%) and financially dependent (90%). Only 2% claim to manage on their own, highlighting near-universal reliance on external support.

Expected Support from Youth: Elders prioritize "spending more time together" (mean 2.53) and "emotional support/listening" (mean 2.46) over "teaching digital tools" (mean 1.94), emphasizing relational and emotional needs over technical assistance.

Youth Willingness to Volunteer: 75% of youth are willing to volunteer, with "spending time with elders living alone" (82%) being the most preferred activity. This demonstrates a strong inclination for direct emotional engagement.

Optimism vs. Reality in Living Arrangements: While youth are highly optimistic about

living with family (88% expect to), vulnerable elders (80+, financially dependent, living alone) show a lower desire or ability to realize this, indicating practical or emotional gaps that temper their outlook.

Evolving Care Preferences: Youth's increasing acceptance of formal care and independent living models, even when still desiring family proximity, suggests a pragmatic outlook on future societal changes and care needs that may differ from current elder experiences.

Proactive vs. Reactive Approach to Well-being: Youth's slightly higher emphasis on respect, value, and social connection for a good old age suggests a more proactive view on the emotional and social dimensions of aging, whereas elders' current priorities are more rooted in present practicalities like health and independence.

15.10. The Intergenerational Dynamics of Nuclear vs. Joint Families

The structure of a household in urban India, whether nuclear or joint, profoundly shapes the experiences and perceptions of both elders and youth, influencing everything from daily interactions and emotional bonds to financial security, health support, and even future aspirations. These family dynamics paint a nuanced picture of intergenerational relationships, revealing both the strengths and challenges inherent in each living arrangement.

In **joint and extended families**, a strong sense of collective life prevails, characterized by **significantly higher daily interactions** between elders and youth. These households often foster a more interdependent structure where shared social activities, such as storytelling and religious events, and daily routines like meals and spiritual practices, are commonplace. Elders in these settings tend to report **greater emotional closeness** with youth and a broader range of interactions, which in turn leads to **higher "Value and Respect Scores"** from youth. Elders feel more involved in family decision-making and are more likely to contribute to childcare and household work, perceiving greater acknowledgment of their contributions. This strong familial bond also translates into **higher expectations for overall support** from elders, who often feel more entitled to or reliant on the larger household network for financial and practical assistance. Youth in these families, recognizing this inherent responsibility, show **higher "Support Need & Expectations Scores"** and a greater willingness to volunteer for elder care initiatives.

However, this constant proximity can also lead to perceived communication barriers and a wider generation gap among youth, possibly due to more frequent, sometimes mandated, interactions and the complexities of managing diverse views within a larger group. Despite these challenges, youth from joint households overwhelmingly expect to live with family in their old age, though they also report higher levels of anxiety regarding poor health and

financial insecurity, likely stemming from direct exposure to the realities of aging within their extended family. While there's robust intergenerational interaction, elders in joint families show **slightly lower digital inclusion**, suggesting that while traditional support networks are strong, a conscious effort may be needed for digital literacy.

Conversely, **nuclear families** often present a different set of dynamics. Elders in these households report **lower daily interaction** with younger generations and tend to depend more on neighbours or family friends for social contact and support, highlighting a greater reliance on external networks when co-residing kin are absent. This reduced daily engagement can contribute to elders experiencing **lower perceived respect and involvement** in family decisions. In terms of **digital inclusion**, elders in nuclear families surprisingly show **higher scores**, possibly because youth in these settings are more consciously involved in teaching digital skills, or perhaps because the absence of a large support network necessitates greater self-reliance on technology. Youth in nuclear families report **lower perceptions of the generation gap**, suggesting that their interactions might be more fluid or less constrained. While family remains valued, elders living alone or with only a spouse, often reflecting nuclear arrangements, exhibit **lower support expectations** from family, possibly due to social withdrawal or fewer perceived entitlements, leading them to rely more on neighbours, friends, and institutional support. Youth in nuclear families also show a slightly lower inclination to volunteer for elder care compared to their counterparts in joint families, indicating that the immediate, visible need for elder care might be less pronounced in their daily lives.

In essence, while **joint families** reinforce traditional care models and a strong sense of intergenerational obligation, fostering deep emotional bonds and shared experiences, they can also bring forth unique communication challenges and anxieties. **Nuclear families**, though still valuing family, tend to navigate a more diversified approach to elder care, often relying on external networks and potentially fostering greater individual digital literacy, but sometimes at the cost of daily intergenerational engagement and perceived elder involvement.

15.11. The Intergenerational Landscape: A Tale of Metro vs. Non-Metro Urban Living

The urban environment, whether a bustling metropolis or a smaller non-metro city, significantly shapes the experiences of both elders and youth, influencing their perceptions of aging, their interactions, and the support systems available to them. This geographical distinction creates distinct intergenerational dynamics, revealing varying levels of connection, respect, and preparedness for the challenges of later life.

In **Non-Metro cities**, there's a palpable sense of stronger intergenerational bonds, often rooted in more traditional norms and a slower pace of life. Elders in these settings consistently report **higher levels of perceived respect** from youth, greater involvement in family decisions, and a stronger sense of being valued for their advice and contributions. This translates into elders feeling more refreshed and happier with their interactions. Both elders and youth report **significantly higher daily interactions** and stronger emotional bonding, frequently engaging in shared social activities like storytelling and joint media consumption.

This closer community fabric also fosters **greater digital comfort and higher perceived closeness through digital means** for elders, suggesting that strong intergenerational support networks ease their technological adoption. Consequently, elders in non-Metro areas self-assess their health as better and express **higher expectations for support** across all domains, including time and financial assistance, indicating a greater reliance on family and community for care.

Youth in these areas, while exhibiting a **higher "Stereotype Negative Bias Scores"** (more traditional ageist views), surprisingly also express **stronger expressions of "Value and Respect"** for elders. They show greater concern for the emotional and social challenges faced by elders, potentially indicating an awareness of perceived erosion of intergenerational bonds in smaller urban settings. This heightened awareness translates into a **higher inclination to volunteer** for elder care and greater support for school/college programs promoting intergenerational engagement.

However, youth and elders in non-Metro cities also report **slightly higher levels of fears about aging**, particularly regarding isolation and loss of respect, perhaps reflecting the unique social dynamics or specific support structures within these smaller urban centres. Despite stronger traditional values, youth in non-Metros report **higher perceived generational gaps** than their Metro counterparts.

In contrast, **Metro cities** present a more fragmented and fast-paced intergenerational landscape. Youth in these bustling centres tend to have a **slightly more favourable overall "Ageing Attitude Score"** and **lower "Stereotype Negative Bias Scores,"** suggesting a more modern and less traditionally ageist outlook. However, this often comes at the cost of direct intergenerational engagement. Elders in Metro cities report **lower perceived respect** and feelings of usefulness, which could be attributed to faster-paced urban lifestyles and a greater sense of anonymity. Their interactions with youth are less frequent, and they tend to feel less refreshed by these exchanges. Consequently, elders in Metro cities show **comparatively lower digital inclusion**, possibly due to less immediate intergenerational support for technology adoption.

While elders in Metro cities report **lower self-assessed health** (potentially reflecting urban stresses) and **lower support needs/expectations**, this might indicate a greater reliance on external, formal services rather than familial care. Metro elders also report **more communication gaps**, and youth experience **higher discomfort around judgment and slang use**, reflecting the pressures of urban lifestyles and evolving family dynamics. Youth in Metro cities show slightly less support for school/college programs promoting elder engagement and, for daily wage workers, lower confidence in caregiving ability, suggesting that urban pressures might impact both willingness and capacity for direct elder support.

In essence, non-Metro cities largely preserve a **community-centric and family-driven model of elder care**, characterized by frequent interaction, mutual respect, and a stronger sense of collective responsibility, even if some traditional biases persist. Conversely, Metro cities lean towards a **more individualized and potentially fragmented approach**, where while attitudes towards aging might be more progressive, the practical realities of urban life can lead to less direct intergenerational engagement and a greater reliance on formal or external support systems.

15.12. The Emotional Heartbeat of Intergenerational Relationships

The emotional landscape within intergenerational relationships in urban India is rich and complex, coloured by empathy, affection, frustration, and deep-seated fears. Despite varying daily interactions and evolving societal roles, the underlying emotional needs and perceptions significantly shape how elders and youth connect, support each other, and envision their futures.

Elders, while often experiencing **loneliness and a sense of invisibility**, particularly if financially dependent or facing health challenges, also report **happiness and contentment**, especially when employed or financially independent. A high majority (73%) feel "**Extremely Close**" or "**Close**" to youth, enjoying their company and feeling "happy and refreshed" or "emotionally closer." However, this closeness doesn't always translate into a feeling of being fully understood or respected. Qualitative feedback reveals an **emotional ambivalence**, where elders desire deeper, and more meaningful engagement beyond mere presence, sometimes feeling "reminded of their age" or experiencing quiet disappointment despite frequent contact. They often express a **sense of loss regarding traditional respect**, feeling unheard or misunderstood, with sentiments like, "If we speak, they say we're complaining again," or "Today's kids don't even know if we've eaten."

Elders, especially those who cannot contribute tangibly due to health or education, often serve as **strong emotional anchors**, providing invaluable wisdom, moral guidance, and presence, and their sense of worth is significantly boosted by the acknowledgment of these

contributions. They explicitly voice a need for **emotional care beyond physical health support**, longing for connection: "Don't just take us to the doctor. Talk to us. Hug us."

In the digital realm, elders demonstrate a **strong willingness to learn**, but are also vulnerable to emotions like **fear of making mistakes (51%) and embarrassment (44%)**. Yet, they widely believe digital technology can foster **closer emotional bonds** with youth, highlighting their optimism despite personal anxieties.

Financial dependency adds significant **emotional strain**, leading to feelings of "loss of control" and shyness about repeatedly asking for help. Their fears about aging are deeply emotional, centered on the **loss of dignity and respect (32%)** and the fear of **being dependent for daily tasks (44%)**, reflecting a desire to maintain autonomy and value.

Youth perceptions of elders are often tinged with **empathy**, frequently associating "lonely" as a top descriptor for aging. While they recognize their role in improving elders' lives and express a **willingness to support elders' emotional well-being**, particularly through activities like "spending time with elders living alone" (82%), the practical application can be challenging.

Youth sometimes experience **frustration and impatience** when teaching elders digital skills, highlighting the emotional toll of consistent support. They also express their own emotional needs and boundaries, articulating frustration with elders' perceived resistance or criticism ("My dadi doesn't like anything I do") and a strong desire for **autonomy** ("We love our grandparents, but we don't want to be controlled by them").

Their fears about their own aging are deeply emotional, encompassing concerns about **dignity, autonomy, and social connection**, with explicit fears of "losing control" and becoming a "burden." Their desire for "peaceful space" and avoidance of "emotional drama" in their own old age indicates a potential shift in the emotional dynamics of future intergenerational living. Crucially, youth's responses emphasize that **emotional safety and lack of judgment** are paramount for fostering deeper conversations, especially on sensitive topics like mental health. They recognize that true support goes beyond mere practical assistance, underscoring the universal need for **emotional presence and companionship**.

In essence, the emotional quotient defines the quality of intergenerational relationships. Despite challenges, both generations yearn for genuine connection, understanding, and mutual respect. The disconnect often arises not from a lack of affection, but from differing expressions of emotional needs, perceived boundaries, and the practical stresses of modern life. Bridging this emotional gap requires active listening, patience, and a conscious effort

to acknowledge each other's feelings and contributions, fostering an environment of empathetic engagement.

15.13. The Multifaceted Vulnerabilities of Elders in Urban India

The experience of aging in urban India is profoundly shaped by various vulnerabilities, particularly among specific elder subgroups. These vulnerabilities, often intertwined, exacerbate feelings of isolation, diminish perceived value, and heighten anxieties about the future, necessitating targeted support and empathetic engagement.

Age itself is a significant factor, with the **oldest elders (80+)** facing compounding challenges. They report **decreasing emotional closeness** with youth, often due to reduced energy and opportunities for interaction, leading to feelings of being "reminded of their age." This age group experiences a **sharp decline in digital inclusion**, finding it harder to learn and navigate technology due to cognitive and physical barriers. While often receiving higher cultural reverence, they report **lower involvement in family decision-making** and a **decreased sense of contribution**, believing they don't contribute at all in some cases. They exhibit increasing health challenges, higher support needs, and are more prone to full financial dependency. Consequently, the 80+ age group shows **heightened fear across all domains of aging**, particularly poor health and loneliness, and their desire to live with family declines, suggesting practical barriers to co-residence.

Financial dependency emerges as a critical vulnerability. Elders who are financially dependent consistently report **lower emotional bonding** with youth, possibly due to feelings of burden or reduced autonomy. They perceive **less respect** and feel less valued for their advice, believing their contributions are not acknowledged. Financially dependent elders also exhibit **very limited digital access** beyond basic phones, scoring significantly lower on digital inclusion indices. This dependency translates into **higher overall support expectations** from family, although they may feel shy about repeatedly asking for help. They are less likely to desire living with family, potentially due to practical constraints or emotional burdens, and express **higher anxiety around financial help**.

Health limitations further amplify vulnerabilities. Elders **unable to work due to health reasons** or those with **ADL/IADL limitations** report **greater judgment from youth** and higher discomfort in approaching them, along with more communication barriers due to increased dependency and potentially lowered self-esteem. They exhibit **very low digital inclusion**, compounded by physical limitations. These elders consistently report **higher support needs**, indicating significant reliance on others, and they particularly **value emotional support**, highlighting a heightened need for empathy.

Social isolation is a pervasive vulnerability, especially for **elders living alone**. They exhibit the **lowest emotional closeness and willingness to interact**, underscoring isolation as a critical factor for emotional well-being. This isolation also contributes to **lower digital inclusion** and a **reduced sense of usefulness** across most domains, as lack of co-residence diminishes their perceived value. Isolated elders tend to have **lower support expectations**, which may reflect social withdrawal rather than genuine independence, and they show a significantly lower desire to live with family in their old age.

Lower educational levels compound many of these vulnerabilities. Elders with **no formal education** show the **lowest digital inclusion**, facing significant barriers like inability to read English, making them highly excluded. They also report **higher fears** across most aspects of aging and express **higher expectations for financial help** from youth, indicating specific economic vulnerabilities.

In summary, these vulnerable elder groups, often overlapping in their characteristics (e.g., an 80+ elder may also be financially dependent and have health issues), face compounded disadvantages. Their experiences are marked by diminishing emotional bonds, reduced perceived value, significant digital exclusion, heightened health and financial anxieties, and a pervasive sense of isolation. Addressing these multifaceted vulnerabilities requires a holistic approach that combines financial, health, social, and emotional support, tailored to their specific needs and aimed at fostering greater dignity, autonomy, and connection.

The study reveals that urban Indian youth generally respect elders and acknowledge their wisdom, yet this respect often falls short in practice, with elders frequently feeling less valued and more emotionally distressed than youth perceive. Despite frequent, family-centric interactions, a significant gap persists between physical presence and meaningful emotional connection, often exacerbated by a digital divide and communication challenges rooted in differing expectations and technological comfort. While family remains the primary support system for elders, particularly in joint and non-metro settings which foster stronger bonds and perceived respect, vulnerabilities stemming from age, financial dependence, health, and isolation critically impact elders' sense of worth and digital inclusion. Both generations share fundamental fears about aging, emphasizing financial security and health, but youth show a pragmatic shift towards accepting formal care, suggesting an evolving outlook on aging that balances traditional family reliance with modern independence. Bridging these pervasive perception-practice gaps requires a concerted effort to enhance digital literacy with patience, foster deeper emotional engagement, ensure practical inclusion in decisions, and develop comprehensive support systems that cater to the diverse and often unvoiced needs of vulnerable elders.

16. WAY FORWARD

This section outlines action points aimed at fostering stronger, more empathetic, and inclusive intergenerational relationships in urban India. Drawing directly from the insights and perceived gaps identified between youth and elder perspectives, these recommendations focus on actionable strategies. We explore how to enhance understanding through public education and empathy workshops, boost digital literacy via youth-led training, strengthen elder care infrastructure, and implement impactful intergenerational programs.



16.1. Public Education, Empathy Workshops and Shaping Age Positive Narratives

Addressing the perception gaps and stereotypes is crucial for fostering genuine respect and understanding.

For NGOs and Educational Institutions:

- **Develop and implement "Aging Sensitization" curricula for schools and colleges.** This should move beyond theoretical respect to practical empathy, focusing on the emotional realities of aging. For example, modules could include simulating mobility issues or sensory impairments to help youth understand physical challenges, or role-playing scenarios to practice active listening.
- **Host intergenerational empathy workshops in communities.** These workshops should bring together youth and elders to share life stories, discuss challenges, and bridge communication gaps. Given that youth perceive elders as "lonely" or "dependent," and elders report feeling "unheard," these workshops can create safe spaces for genuine dialogue. Focus on topics both generations agree are important, like "spending more quality time together".
- **Launch awareness campaigns through local media (community radio, local newspapers, and social media) to challenge ageist stereotypes.** Highlight elders' diverse contributions, beyond traditional roles, emphasizing their value as emotional anchors and wisdom keepers. Counter the persistence of stereotypes about physical decline by showcasing active and engaged elders.

For Other Stakeholders: Media, Corporate and Philanthropies:

- **Integrate intergenerational empathy and respect into public awareness campaigns.** Utilize mass media (TV, radio, digital platforms) to feature positive intergenerational stories that showcase mutual learning and support, rather than just reinforcing traditional deference.
- **Support research and action into culturally relevant psychosocial support models for elders.** The study highlights emotional distress and loneliness among seniors and youth perceiving it as a negative. Research should be done on impact of isolation and emotional distancing on mental and physical wellbeing of the older persons and role of youth in helping older person deal with it.

16.2. Digital Inclusion: Youth-Led Training Initiatives

Bridging the significant digital divide requires patient, empathetic, and tailored approaches, leveraging youth's digital fluency.

For NGOs and Educational Institutions:

- **Establish specially designed programs.** Pair tech-savvy youth volunteers with elders for one-on-one or small-group training sessions. These programs should prioritize patience and repeated explanations, as elders blame youth's impatience (71%) and fast explanations (49%) for learning difficulties, while 44% feel embarrassed to ask repeatedly.
- **Develop elder-friendly digital literacy modules.** Focus on practical applications that elders value, such as video calls to connect with family (73% elders believe digital technology brings them closer to youth), online banking basics, and accessing essential services. Avoid jargon and use visual aids.
- **Create specialized digital literacy workshops for vulnerable elders.** This includes the 80+ age group, financially dependent elders, and those with no formal education, who show significantly lower digital inclusion.
- **Promote digital literacy for elders as a youth volunteer activity.** Youth are willing to volunteer (75%), and "spending time with elders living alone" (82% preferred activity) can naturally integrate digital support. This offers a structured opportunity for youth to act as digital enablers.

For Government (in collaboration with NGOs):

- **Fund and scale up digital literacy centers specifically designed for elders in urban areas.** Ensure these centers have trained, patient instructors and provide hands-on support.
- **Develop simplified, accessible digital interfaces for government services relevant to elders.** This reduces the learning curve and empowers elders to access information and benefits independently.
- **Incentivize youth participation in digital mentorship programs.** Consider providing certificates, community service hours, or small scholarships to encourage sustained engagement.

Corporate

- Support Digital Literacy programs and device access for seniors, and promoting intergenerational connect and learning. Include such programs under CSR. In particular, technology companies to take lead in digital inclusion for the marginalized
- Encourage and sensitize the design and development IT community (often led by young professionals) to adopt 'design' approach appropriate for the elders

16.3. Strengthening Intergenerational Care Infrastructure

Enhancing both formal and informal support systems is vital to address elders' financial, health, and emotional needs.

For NGOs:

- **Establish community-based elder support centers with intergenerational connect.** These centers can offer holistic support, including social activities, emotional counseling, health screenings, and information about government schemes. Address the critical elder need for emotional care beyond physical health: "Don't just take us to the doctor. Talk to us. Hug us."
- **Advocate for improved elder care training for professional caregivers.** Focus on empathetic communication, understanding age-related challenges, and respecting elder autonomy.

- **Develop programs to support informal family caregivers.** Given that 86% of elders rely on family support, provide resources for caregiver well-being, stress management, and practical caregiving skills.

For Government:

- **Promote awareness of elder legal protections.** On lines of other successful mass campaigns like universal inclusion of 70+ under PMJAY and also include it as important component of ElderLine and Regional Resource and Training Centres outreach. Only 35% of elders are aware of legal protections, a significant gap that needs to be addressed through accessible public campaigns.
- **Regulate quality formal care options.** Youth show a notable shift towards considering "paid caregivers/domestic help" (28%) and "old age homes/assisted living" (30%), indicating a growing demand for such services.

16.4. Intergenerational Programs

Creating structured opportunities for meaningful interaction can bridge perception gaps and strengthen bonds.

For Government

- Consider a National Intergenerational Engagement Mission: Launch a special mission to promote structured intergenerational programs in schools, colleges and communities
- Leverage and engage the network of Senior Citizen Associations (SCAs) that currently exists in major cities, for connecting youth member/associations for meaningful connect and collaboration
- On the lines of NSS (the national volunteering youth force for social service), launch a 'Silver NSS' program that institutionalises opportunities for elders to engage in the society along with the youth. This could be enabled through existing institutions in both youth and seniors' segment (SCAs)

For Social Sector/Community based Organisations:

- **Launch "Wisdom Exchange" programs.** These could involve elders teaching traditional skills, storytelling, or sharing life experiences, while youth share modern

knowledge or help with technology. This leverages elders' role as "emotional anchors" and addresses youth's desire for genuine connection.

- **Organize intergenerational events and festivals.** These events should celebrate cultural heritage while incorporating activities appealing to both age groups, fostering shared experiences beyond routine interactions.
- **Develop volunteer opportunities that pair youth with vulnerable elders for companionship.** "Spending time with elders living alone" is a preferred activity for 82% of youth volunteers, indicating a strong interest in addressing loneliness.

For Educational Institutions & Corporates:

- **Integrate community service hours that include intergenerational activities for students.** This institutionalizes engagement and ensures consistent interaction.
- **Encourage youth to lead projects that directly benefit elders in their communities.** This could involve creating digital content for elders, organizing health camps, or beautifying elder-friendly spaces.
- **Encourage and incentivize young employees' engagement with seniors in the family, workplace and community, and consider such programs under CSR**



